

The *Caterpillar* and



the *Dragonfly*

Based on a true story

The Caterpillar and the Dragonfly

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Chapter 1 - The Land Under the Cabin

Once upon a time, there lived a caterpillar named Gustavius.

But his only friend called him Gus. You'll be introduced to him later. Gus was a large, plump caterpillar, as green as the moss and ferns that grew where he lived. He used his antennae when he spoke, like the way humans use their hands when they talk. Gus was, in reality, a quite nice and pleasant fellow, but he was terribly shy. He didn't consider himself to be good-looking. He couldn't see well, and he was a slowpoke. He doubted that anyone would have a need for a friend like him. And so, he spent most of his time keeping to himself.

He lived under a large, old cabin in the woods. There was plenty of good moss to sleep on and yummy ferns and flower leaves to munch. Sometimes he thought about exploring the Land Beyond the Cabin, but he could never muster the courage to actually do it. He had heard stories of monsters... large, winged beasts with sharp beaks and a taste for plump, juicy caterpillars.

So he lived a quiet life under the cabin, somewhat protected from danger. When he thought of leaving, he always told himself, "Maybe tomorrow, but not today. There is so much to do here under this old cabin anyway."

Gus kept himself busy during the day. He spent his time doing things such as making his bed a little more comfy and trying new foods. The toadstools, for example, that grew nearby. He didn't like them at first, but the taste grew on him. The area where he spent most of his time was moistened by the drips of a large basin in the cabin above. Rain water would fill the basin, and a

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leak in the drain spigot would keep this section of the Land Under the Cabin nice and damp, just the way he liked it.

The cabin had been neglected for quite some time, and could no longer provide much protection for human inhabitants. But for Gus, who wasn't very picky, the cabin offered him everything he could ask for. The wall facing East was in the worst shape, for it was the side of the cabin that got the most wind and sun. Much of the siding was badly rotted or altogether missing. The studs that held up the roof were now visible, giving the skeletal structure a kind of haunted look. Part of the roof above that wall had collapsed as well, allowing both sun and rain to penetrate that section of the once-sturdy cabin. One benefit of all this weathering was the sunlight that was allowed to filter down through the warped floorboards. This area of the Land Under the Cabin was dappled with light during much of the day.

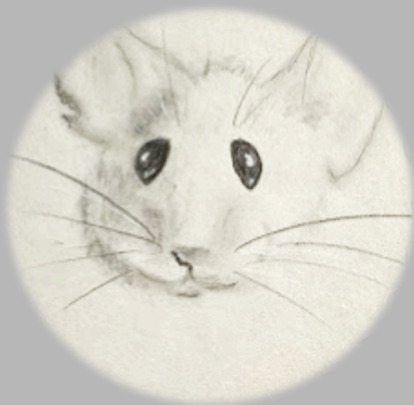
The space under the dilapidated cabin had a lot to offer a caterpillar who loved to explore. Flowers grew in the Eastern area that received the most light. Gus named that place Flower Garden. He called the shady, damp area where he liked to sleep Fern Forest. Then there was the Musty Dusty Corner, Weed Jungle, and the Treasure Trove. And so lived Gus the caterpillar, a simple guy living a simple life. He spent most mornings munching on leaves in Flower Garden, exploring the nooks and crannies of his domain during the afternoon, returning back to Fern Forest before it got too dark.

The cabin above that sheltered Gus had definitely seen better days. It sagged and sighed where it stood, situated in the center of a lovely plot of land. A rickety picket fence protected the perimeter, while a large oak tree shaded the grassy corner of the property. Several fruit trees were clustered on one side of the back yard, while a greenhouse and a once-red shed stood on the

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other side. This little abandoned clearing was nestled within a great forest. There were other homes in the area, but none were visible due to the number and variety of trees that were all that could be seen in every direction.

Gus's only friend was a kindly old field mouse named Jeremiah. He lived with his family out in the shed, but during his travels to forage for his large family, he would drop in from time to time. Jeremiah would tell Gus amazing stories of the Land Beyond the Cabin, which filled his imagination with wonder. The mouse would invite Gus to accompany him to visit the Land Beyond the Cabin for himself, but Gus would always answer, "Maybe tomorrow, but not today. There is so much to do here under this old cabin anyway."



And Jeremiah would twitch his whiskers and shake his head, and leave Gus munching on a dandelion leaf or a fern frond, alone under the creaky cabin.

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Chapter 2 - The Old Boot

It was a fine Sunday afternoon in May. Gus was feeling a little hungry as he inched his way toward Flower Garden for a snack. As he traveled, he wondered to himself if the distance didn't seem to grow with each trip.

He found a daisy in the corner of the garden a few days ago. It was Friday, but caterpillars don't keep track of time like that. He was wondering today if its leaves tasted as good as they looked. He had thought of tasting them when he discovered the flower, but for some reason decided to simply admire the tasty-looking leaves and had thus far been able to resist. But today, he was looking forward to nibbling on those tender green blades.

His eyesight was quite poor, but the sunlight streaming in from above on this particular Sunday helped him navigate toward the old, brown boot that had hidden the daisy from view until Gus had discovered it. The dusty leather work boot had somehow found its way under the cabin, although just *how* would forever remain a mystery to him. Gus stopped and peered for a moment. The boot had, since Gus had lived under the cabin, been lying on its side with the worn laces curling on the ground like cooked spaghetti noodles. But today, something about the boot was different. It seemed to him that something was perched on top of the boot, and *that* something was moving! Imagine his astonishment as he inched up close to the boot and discovered that he was right... a creature with gossamer wings was perched up there, sure enough! Gus did his best to make out the details of the insect he saw, as he knew the wings and antennae had to be those of an insect. He blinked hard and crept

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a little closer, and at last he was able to tell that he was looking at a dragonfly! He could tell that the creature's wings were delicate and clear, as they were lit up from the sun's rays shining through them.

A caterpillar doesn't have very good eyesight. In fact, they only see black and white, and are quite near-sighted as insect vision goes. He didn't know that one of the dragonfly's most striking features is the vibrant colors that decorate their slender bodies and shimmering wings.

Gustavus Caterpillar didn't need to be able to see colors and have excellent vision to be amazed. For a few moments, Gus just stared. Mostly because he couldn't think of anything to say to a dragonfly on top of a boot under a cabin. Other than Jeremiah, Gus hadn't had much practice making conversation.

As Gus stood transfixed, the dragonfly turned and noticed him, startled. For a time, the two sized each other up, neither finding the words to match the moment. There was a stillness in the air, and at the same time an electric feeling that something significant was happening here among the flowers.

Finally, Gus decided to open his mouth and see what might come out. "Hello," he said nervously. "M..my name is Gustavus, but you can call me Gus." he stammered. "Welcome to the Land Under the Cabin."

The dragonfly seemed to relax a bit after Gus introduced himself. Caterpillars aren't very intimidating as a matter of course, and Gus had a friendly, shy way about him. Jeremiah had told him that he was easy to talk to. But that didn't give Gus more self confidence.

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“Nice to meet you, Gus,” the dragonfly answered with a melodic voice. “My name is... is... oh my! I don’t remember what my name is!” Tears welled in the dragonfly’s eyes as confusion and panic gripped her. Gus looked more carefully at her, and was shocked to see that one of her delicate wings was torn. He wondered if she felt pain, because it sure looked like it hurt.

“Your wing!” he exclaimed in alarm. “What happened to you? I’ve always thought that the Land Beyond the Cabin was dangerous... but here’s proof, sure enough!”

The dragonfly thought for a moment and then shook her head sadly. “I don’t remember. Everything is all topsy-turvy in my head.” She looked again as though she may start crying. Gus thought about what he could say to offer some comfort.

“I’m sure you’ll remember. Just give yourself some time.” He looked around for some sort of inspiration. He noticed the laces in the old boot lying next to the flower. Then he looked at the dragonfly and noticed again how delicate and lacy her wings were. “I have an idea... until you remember your name, what if I call you Lacey?”

The dragonfly seemed to brighten a little at the suggestion.

“Lacey. That’s a pretty name... I like it!” She smiled as a breeze drafted through Flower Garden and caused Lacey’s torn wing to flutter.

“Are you hungry? Can you walk?” Gus asked Lacey gently. Lacey appeared a little unsteady as she shifted her weight and flapped her tattered wing helplessly.

“I’m not hungry, but I am very thirsty. And a bit weak. Perhaps with some help, I can manage to walk.” Lacey managed.

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Gus knew just where to take the injured dragonfly: the leaky basin that provided the water for Fern Forest! “I have an idea - do you think you could get on my back and hold on?” He squirmed his way closer to the sole of the boot.

“I think so...” Lacey said with uncertainty. Slowly and cautiously, she stepped down onto Gus’s broad back. Her sticky feet made it easier for her to cling to him as Gus inched his way back from where he had just come. It didn’t occur to him that he didn’t even look at the daisy as he had planned, or taste its tender leaves...

Eventually, the slow-moving (even slower than normal, with an injured dragonfly on his back) caterpillar could make out the drip, drip, drip from the basin overhead that soaked the mossy ground. Gus carefully maneuvered until he was pelted by the drops, heavy thuds of water plopping onto his head, droplets clinging to his antennae. He waited patiently there under the drips until Lacey had quenched her thirst.

“Thank you Gus. I feel much better now,” Lacey said after a few minutes. She yawned a great yawn. Gus moved away from the dripping water and suggested, “I know of a lovely spot for you to rest. Would you like me to take you there?”

“Yes, I think I would like that very much,” the pretty dragonfly replied as she settled herself for the ride.

“OK... Hold on tight then!” Gus urged as he slowly turned and started creeping toward the shadowy area under the cabin where the softest moss could be found. It only took the caterpillar a few minutes to reach their destination. Lacey didn’t even have a

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chance to finish the pleasant tune she hummed before Gus announced that they had arrived. He flattened himself as much as he could, allowing Lacey to dismount as easily as possible.

Gus showed Lacey a lovely bed of soft moss in the shadowy corner of the Land Under the Cabin. She wearily sank into the cool, green bed. “Thank you very much, Gus,” she said as her eyelids drooped, heavy with fatigue. “You have been very kind to me.”

Gus watched as the dragonfly slipped into sleep. He curled up protectively around her and felt very good inside. He had never had a chance to help someone like this. For the first time in his life, Gus felt useful. He liked that feeling and the feeling of concern that he had for the dragonfly in his care. These were new feelings for Gus the Caterpillar, and they were very good feelings indeed.

The next day, Gus busied himself with searching out the juiciest fern fronds he could find and brought them back to Lacey. “You just rest and eat, you are safe here,” he said softly. “Soon, you will be stronger and I will show you all of the secrets of the Land Under the Cabin.”

Several days passed, and Lacey did get stronger. After four days of rest and the leafy meals provided by Gus, Lacey was strong enough to test out her wings. But try as she might, her damaged wing prevented her from lifting off the ground. Gus saw the disappointment in Lacey’s face and tried to cheer her up.

“Don’t feel bad, Lacey. Your wings are still very pretty, and I’ve lived my whole life on the ground! Flying isn’t everything, after

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all.” Lacey smiled, but Gus could tell that she felt discouraged and missed the ability to fly.

“It’s hard to describe,” she told him quietly. “There’s freedom in the air. I used to fly so fast. The things you can see when you’re soaring in the sky. It’s incredible. I can’t remember my name, or where I’m from. But I do remember the joy of flying,” Lacey sighed with longing.

“I’ve never visited the Land Beyond the Cabin,” Gus admitted.

“Oh, Gus, really!” Lacey laughed, forgetting for the moment her broken wing. “You simply must see it for yourself! This Land Under the Cabin is very nice, but there is so much to see, so much to do out there... wonderful fields of flowers and friends to play with in the breeze. At least, that’s how it used to be.” She looked at her torn wing wistfully.

Gus looked dubious. “Maybe tomorrow, but not today. There is so much to do here under this old cabin anyway!” He pointed his antennae toward the corner of the cabin. “How about this-tomorrow, I’ll take you to explore Weed Jungle! We can play hide and seek. It will be fun!” And the two friends munched on a tasty leaf Gus harvested earlier that day.

“That does sound like fun!” replied Lacey. “Good night, dear friend.” And with that, Lacey gave Gus a kiss on his pudgy green cheek. Gus felt a funny feeling inside. He had trouble falling asleep as he thought about Lacey’s wing and how sad she had looked when she found that she had lost the ability to fly.

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Chapter 3 - A Visitor

The next day, Gus took Lacey to Weed Jungle. Along the way, he pointed out items of interest and helpful landmarks. As they passed the dented tin sand pail and shovel that had somehow found a home under the cabin, Gus gestured to the weeds in the distance. “The weeds are fun to hide in, but be careful of the thorny stalks. Also, I would recommend that you don’t eat the leaves. I tried them once, and it wasn’t very pleasant.” Gus looked a little greener than usual as he recalled the bitter taste and the tummy ache that followed.

“I trust you, Gus. No stinky weeds for me!” Lacey smiled as they neared the patch of ground choked with broad-leaved, thick-salked, prickly weeds. Lacey tucked her delicate wings close to her body to protect them from the thorns. Gus hid first, but his size made it fairly easy for Lacey to find him. As Gus began to count, Lacey hurried off to find a plant large enough to conceal her luminous wings. Gus did not peek as he counted. When he reached the last number, he shouted, “Ten! Ready or not, here I come! You can’t hide from me!”

As Gus searched, he heard a rustling and saw the stalk of a weed bend slightly. He saw a long stringy tail poke up from behind a large stone. As he peered from behind a fat weed stalk, he saw the familiar whiskers and pink nose of none other than his old friend Jeremiah! Jeremiah noticed Gus’s round face and antennae a moment later. “There you are, Gus! What are you doing here in the weeds?” Jeremiah asked as he scurried over to his friend.

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"I'm playing hide and seek," Gus whispered, as if the answer were obvious. As it dawned on Gus that Jeremiah had never met Lacey, he chuckled. "Oh, I have a new friend... Wait till you meet her!" His whisper was probably loud enough for Lacey to hear him, regardless of where she was hiding. Pushing his torso up the stem of a prickly weed, he looked around and shouted, "Come out, come out, wherever you are, Lacey! I have a friend that I want you to meet!" Soon he saw the rounded edges of Lacey's wings emerging from behind one of the cement blocks that the cabin rested on.

"This better not be a trick," Lacey warned as she made her way toward Gus. She stopped short when she saw the pointed teeth, pink nose, white whiskers, and beady eyes of a field mouse crouched next to her friend. No one could accuse Jeremiah of being a young mouse, but he wasn't terribly old, either. There was some graying of the hair around his mouth and ears that suggested that he had the experience and wisdom that comes with surviving in the Land Beyond the Cabin, and the stress and pressure of being a father. Jeremiah had shared details of his rather sizable family with Gus on many occasions.

Gus saw the surprise in Lacey's eyes and quickly introduced the mouse. "This is Jeremiah. Sometimes he visits me from the Land Beyond the Cabin," he explained with a beaming smile. Turning to Jeremiah, he added, "Jeremiah, this is my friend Lacey. She had an accident and can't remember her name. I suggested her name could be Lacey until her memory returns." The dragonfly and the mouse regarded one another for a moment, then Lacey advanced a few steps.

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“It’s a pleasure to meet you, Jeremiah.” She glanced toward the ground shyly, trying to hide her torn wing behind her. “I think Gus meant to say *if* my memory returns...”

The mouse bowed, his white whiskers brushing the ground. “The pleasure is mine, Miss Lacey.” He smiled a toothy smile as he approached her. “Oh, my!” he cried as he took in the vibrant colors of her body and the delicate curve of her wings. “You are indeed a magnificent creature. I never have been able to get close enough to one of your kind to see how marvelous your wings...” He stopped short as he noticed her torn wing for the first time. “Goodness!” he uttered as he surveyed the damage. “What happened to you?”

A tear welled in Lacey’s eye as she looked at the ground sadly. “I can’t remember what happened to me. All I remember is darkness and pain. And then... and then Gus appeared. I really don’t know what I would have done if he hadn’t found me,” Lacey concluded.

Gus turned a shade of crimson as the attention was directed toward him. Again, he tried to make Lacey feel better by pointing out that not all creatures can fly. “Life without wings isn’t so bad,” he suggested. “Jeremiah can’t fly, and the poor guy only has four legs! As for me, could you imagine me with wings big enough to get this,” he pointed at his sizable midsection, “off the ground?” The three friends laughed at the thought, and Gus was glad to get Lacey’s mind off her injury for the moment.

“Who’s hungry?” Jeremiah asked Gus and Lacey. “I left a nut for myself near the flowers. Shall we make our way over there?” His two friends agreed, and Lacey led the way. She was getting to

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know her way around the Land Under the Cabin, and the destination was easy to see thanks to the sunlight filtering through the warped cabin floor. As Gus and the mouse trailed behind, Jeremiah had a quiet conversation with his plump green pal. “It’s such a shame about Lacey’s wing,” he said softly as Lacey hummed a pretty tune up ahead, “dragonflies are not meant to live under cabins.”

Gus nodded in agreement. “Very true, Jeremiah. I wish there was something we could do...” After a moment, he added, “still, it has been nice to have her company. Having her here makes my days feel a little more special.”

Jeremiah smiled at Gus. “You’re a good friend, Mr. Caterpillar. She’s lucky you found her, and I’m sure your friendship is helping her more than you know. Still,” he added thoughtfully, “I think I’ll ask my friends in the Land Beyond the Cabin if there’s anything that might help a dragonfly heal a tattered wing.”

Gus brightened at the thought. “That would be great... please do!” But then he suggested in a whisper, “But let’s not mention that to Lacey. I try to keep her mind off her wing... and flying.”

“Hurry up, slowpokes! We’re almost there, and now I’m really hungry!” Lacey called back to her companions. When they arrived at last, the three friends had a grand luncheon.

Jeremiah even tried a bit of dandelion stalk when he saw how much Gus and Lacey enjoyed it. “Huh,” he said after sampling it, whiskers twitching, “I think I’ll stick to this, if it’s all the same to you.” He took another bite of his acorn as Gus and Lacey laughed.

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When the three were full and had quenched their thirst beneath the dripping basin, the light shining through the slats was noticeably dimmer, and Jeremiah announced that it was time for him to say farewell. “There’s an owl that lives in the great oak, and it’s not a good idea to pass by his tree after dark.”

The dragonfly and the caterpillar wished their friend a safe journey, then they turned toward the moss and a good night’s rest. As they waited for sleep to arrive, they chatted quietly about the day’s adventures. They agreed that it had been a very good day. The two friends snuggled into their soft beds and fell fast asleep.

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Chapter 4 - Reflections

As the soft morning sunlight filtered through the floorboards of the cabin the next day, Gus suggested another adventure to Lacey. “Today, I would like to take you to Treasure Trove. I think you’ll like it!” Gus proposed. Lacey’s eyes sparkled at the thought. “Treasure Trove? That sounds like a marvelous place! Let’s go eat, then you can take me there,” she answered.

The pair hurried through their breakfast and were soon on their way. As Gus did his best to move along quickly, he found it hard to talk and take in enough oxygen at the same time. Lacey saw him struggling and slowed down. “Let’s take our time, shall we Gus? It’s such a lovely day.” Gus was grateful that he had a thoughtful friend who didn’t get impatient with his pace.

“Tell me about your family, won’t you?” Lacey asked as the duo passed along the outskirts of Weed Jungle. Gus thought as he walked, searching his memory. “I don’t have any recollection of my family, Lacey.” Gus confessed quietly. “The earliest memory I have is of Fern Forest, crawling in the moss and nibbling on fern fronds.” Lacey looked shocked. “Oh, Gus! I’m sorry, I thought...”

But Gus was quick to respond. “It’s ok, I thought for the longest time that I was alone in the world. I didn’t know any other kind of life, so I wasn’t lonely. It was just the way it was. But then one day, I met Jeremiah and found out that there is a big world outside the Land Under the Cabin, with many different creatures. Jeremiah has told me lots of stories.”

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Lacey considered what to say. “Well, gee, Gus... I guess we’re more similar than we look. Neither one of us remembers where we came from, or even our parents!”

Gus had to agree. “At least we have each other, right? I’m very glad of that. You know, I didn’t really feel lonely before you arrived, but if you ever do leave, I will miss you terribly.” Gus declared.

“Well, I don’t know why I would leave, Gus. This is my home now. You are my family.” Lacey stopped and gave Gus a hug. Gus tried to hug her back, but his stubby legs didn’t reach very far around her.

As they continued their journey, Gus tried to give his friend an idea about the area he was going to show her. “There are so many strange objects in this spot. I can’t imagine where they all came from, but it’s super fun to explore! It’s one of my favorite places in the Land Under the Cabin. Oh, we’re almost there... do you see that box up ahead? That’s Treasure Trove!”

Lacey’s eyes widened as they walked up to an old box tipped on its side, contents spilling out. Lacey saw all kinds of kitchen items, cups, saucers, spoons and knives. Leaning up against the mouth of the box, she saw a silver platter. The platter was bent slightly, and the reflection she saw when she gazed in it looked quite silly, like a mirror in a fun house. Her head was very large, balancing on a squat body that seemed to be struggling to support the weight of such an impressive cranium!

She looked at Gus’s reflection next to hers. Gus was so thin, he resembled a scrawny green worm. The two friends broke out in

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peals of laughter as they moved up and down and side to side, their images distorted in all kinds of wonderful ways.

Lacey got behind Gus and spread out her wings. “Now I know what I would look like if I had wings too!” Gus exclaimed. Lacey fluttered her wings and they laughed even harder, but then her torn wing caught Lacey’s eye and, as sometimes happens, her laughter gradually turned into sobs. Gus turned around and did his best to console her.

“Oh Gus, I’m sorry to ruin our fun with tears!” Lacey said after she was able to stop crying. “I know I should be grateful to be healthy and alive. I don’t know why I reacted like that. I feel so silly...” She looked as if she may start crying again.

Gus tried to think quickly; he hated to see Lacey sad. “What are caterpillars afraid of?” he asked. Lacey sniffled and looked at him curiously. “What?” she asked back. “Well, don’t tell anyone, but we are terrified of doggerpillars!” Gus said with a straight face.

Lacey’s blank face made it known that she did not get the joke. Gus explained, “Oh, Jeremiah told me that one a while ago. I didn’t understand at first either.” Then Gus explained what he knew about dogs and cats and why the joke was supposed to be funny. Lacey laughed the polite laugh that you hear after someone tells a joke that they have to explain after they tell it. It made Gus happy though, because his joke had taken Lacey’s mind off her wing and her tears. “Come with me, there’s more!”

Gus showed Lacey the rusty toolbox that was missing its lid. An old hammer, some screwdrivers and other hand tools were found inside. The two friends took turns guessing what the tools may

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be used for, with neither having a clue as to what the truth could be. The truth was that the tools were used in the construction of the cabin that sheltered them from the world outside! Then they were left here and forgotten once the job had been finished.

“Whatever could that be?” asked a curious Lacey. A box of children’s toys had caught her eye. A large, colorful ball and the head and shoulders of a doll with a blue gingham top could be seen above the edge of the box lid, as well as a dark blue pinwheel decorated with white stars leaning out at one corner, as if ready to escape at a moment’s notice.

“Check this out...” Gus said as he scaled his upper half up the corner of the box as far as his little legs and lower half could manage, and he was able to hit a blade of the pinwheel with his outstretched antennae. The wheel turned very slightly. “Let me try, Gus,” Lacey offered, and Gus slinked his way back down and backed up a little. Lacey stood under the pinwheel and flapped her wings. Despite the damage, her wings produced enough wind to start the wheel spinning. Slowly at first, but faster and faster the longer Lacey directed air toward it with her beating wings. “Wow... look at that thing whirl!” shouted Gus as the stars blurred into white circles floating on a sea of blue.

The toy turned a bit from the force of the spinning blades, and the tips of the blades started to come in contact with one of the box flaps and a buzzing sang out. The friction started to slow the wheel, and as Lacey stilled her wings, the buzzing turned to flapping and then to nothing. “That was pretty awesome, Lacey!” Gus gushed. “Did you see how the stars blurred into circles when it was spinning so fast? That was really cool.”

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Lacey smiled in agreement. “You were right, Gus. I really like this Treasure Trove. There are so many interesting things here! But, let’s not explore too much today... I’d like to leave more to discover next time we come. What do you think?” Gus was happy that his surprise was appreciated by Lacey. “That’s a great idea! I have some other stuff I think you’ll like to see, but we can come back here anytime, right?”

They went back to Fern Forest for dinner and rest. As they settled in for the night, Lacey surprised Gus with some words as they were saying goodnight to each other. “You know, Gus... when you found me, I didn’t know who I was or how I got here. It was a very lonely feeling. I felt lost and scared. I want you to know how much your kindness and friendship mean to me. You and Jeremiah are the only friends I have, the only kind of family I know. Your heart is so big. I have a sense that everything is going to work out, even though my memory might never come back and I’ll never know what it feels like to fly again.”

The dragonfly fell silent, and all that could be heard for a few quiet moments was the song of a lone cricket somewhere out in the Land Beyond the Cabin. Then Gus replied to Lacey’s goodnight message. “Gee, Lacey... I think I know how you feel. I know what it’s like to feel disconnected and on your own. Since you appeared, it has occurred to me that there’s more to life than eating and exploring.” He had been looking up at the floor above but now rolled and turned his head to look at Lacey.

“But that word you used... ‘never’. Jeremiah once told me that you should never say never. I thought that didn’t make sense, when he said ‘never’ twice! But I think that now I understand what he meant. We don’t know what will happen tomorrow...

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What if your memory comes back? I think it's important to keep believing that things will work out."

More silence followed. Gus was drifting off into a dream when he heard Lacey's voice. Was it part of the dream? He couldn't tell. "I so enjoyed our adventure today. Thank youuu..." Gus sighed and smiled as he started to snore.

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Chapter 5 - Jeremiah's Secrets

One by one, the days passed, and soon Lacey knew every part of the Land Under the Cabin almost as well as Gus did. Gus didn't mention it to Lacey, but he thought he noticed a little droop in the edges of her wings as she didn't often use them anymore. He knew that Jeremiah was right... dragonflies weren't meant to live under cabins in the shadows. They were meant to spend their days in the bright sunlight, flying high and free.

Gus encouraged Lacey to start exercising as part of their morning routine. "You'll never know when you might need those muscles for something!" he would say good-naturedly. Lacey agreed, and she would flit her wings while running around Fern Forest. At first, she had a hard time going around once without resting. But every day, she found she could go farther. Not only did the exercise help her feel stronger, but she also felt that she could think more clearly and had a more positive outlook as well. The way she embraced the exercise motivated Gus to join her, although he could never hope to match her speed and grace.

He also tried to keep her mind occupied by inventing new games to play and telling her stories. He found Lacey to be a good listener. Sometimes she would quietly listen, then say something that made Gus think of his story in a different way. He liked to share what little he had learned about life, mostly from his time with Jeremiah, but also from mistakes that he had made.

"If a leaf is round, food you've found. If a leaf is sharp, you'll hear a harp." he recited. "I made that up after a few too many tummy aches when I ate the wrong kind of leaf. You see, one day Jeremiah told me about a place called heaven where we go after

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we die. He says in heaven, they play music played on a thing called a harp. I don't know if that's true, but it sure helps me remember which leaves are safe to eat!"

After the morning exercise and drinking drops of water as they fell from between the planks of the floor above them, Gus and Lacey started out for Flower Garden. It was a bright, sunny day. On bright, sunny days, Gus often suggested spending the morning hours with Lacey there, where she could perch atop the boot where he had first found her. The area of the cabin above Flower Garden was the most damaged by time and weather, which allowed direct sunlight to brighten her body and wings. Lacey quite enjoyed her time basking in the sun's warm rays.

"Have you ever thought of leaving the Land Under the Cabin, Lacey?" Gus wondered aloud. "Perhaps you can't fly, but you might be happier living by the lake where the sun can warm you all day." Lacey gazed up through a hole in the floor, through an open doorway beyond, at a fluffy cloud floating in the clear, blue sky. The cabin door had been blown open during a storm a few months earlier, so forcefully that one of the hinges broke. The weathered door could no longer swing freely in its frame as it had since the cabin was built.

She noticed the leaves on a tree fluttering in the breeze as she considered how to respond. "Maybe tomorrow, but not today. There's so much to do here under this old cabin anyway!" she said, causing a smile to spread across Gus's face. Then, more seriously, Lacey added, "The Land Beyond the Cabin is no place for me now. What would my friends think if they saw me like this? What place would I have there? I'm not a flier any more. Besides," she added with a warm gaze, "You are one of the kindest insects I've ever met. And... I feel safe here with you, Mr.

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Gustavius Caterpillar.” Gus blushed, suddenly feeling quite awkward. Feeling the need to change the subject, his mind raced, searching for the right thing to say.

“Well.. it’s been a long time since we’ve seen Jeremiah, hasn’t it? I wonder why he hasn’t been by.” was all he could muster.

Then, as if he had planned this moment with Jeremiah ahead of time, a pink nose and white whiskers peeked over the edge of the hole in the floor. “Hello... anybody home?” Jeremiah greeted the pair with a toothy grin.

“Jeremiah!” Gus and Lacey shouted at once. Gus felt quite relieved, both at the sight of his dear friend and the distraction his appearance provided. Jeremiah jumped down into the Land Under the Cabin, landing lightly on the boot near Lacey. After giving her a hug, he hopped down to the ground and embraced Gus.

The mouse seemed very happy to see his friends. “How are you? It’s so good to see you again!” he said cheerfully. Gus noticed there was something different about Jeremiah, as soon as the mouse stopped moving long enough for Gus to get a good look. The top of Jeremiah’s right ear was torn, one side flopping limply!

Lacey joined her friends and gasped when she noticed the injury herself. “Jeremiah, your ear! What happened??”

Jeremiah looked at Lacey’s torn wing and smiled with a twinkle in his eye and a wiggle of his damaged ear. “Well, my dear... it seems that now we have more in common than our choice of friends!” His squeaky laugh caught Gus and Lacey by surprise,

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and soon they were laughing too. “One evening, not long ago, I was running later than usual, and as fate would have it, the old owl in the oak tree decided to wake up earlier than usual! I guess he was looking for a snack, and found me!” he explained after the laughter quieted. “Thanks to a reflection in a puddle I was passing by, my mouse-like reflexes, and more than a little luck, I escaped with this little souvenir and a story to tell. But I much prefer this little souvenir to the alternative ending!” Jeremiah’s whiskers trembled as he considered what might have been. “If nothing more, it’s made me appreciate being alive, I can tell you!”

The three friends enjoyed catching up in the warm, peaceful afternoon air. Lacey impressed their visitor with her knowledge of the Land Under the Cabin. Gus was able to coax a little more of the story of the owl from his friend, and Lacey told him that she was very proud of his bravery and that she was quite happy that he had escaped. “Those birds are a danger to us all! I wouldn’t be surprised if my injury came while escaping from one of them myself!” Lacey opined.

Jeremiah squeakily cleared his throat before responding to the dragonfly, “Yes, indeed! I’d wager that’s exactly what happened!” After a pause, he continued, “Lacey, dear... I have something of a rather delicate nature to discuss with my pal Gustavius here. I hope you don’t think it rude if I walk with him for a bit while you rest here in the sunlight?” Lacey and Gus both looked a little surprised at Jeremiah’s request. Gus wasn’t used to hearing his full name, and wondered what Jeremiah could have to talk about alone.

Lacey’s manners set her two companions at ease as she quickly responded with a smile. “Of course! I am quite comfortable

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here. You boys go get some exercise.” Gus looked hesitant for a moment, but after getting an encouraging nod from Lacey, he turned and inched his way along the edge of the cabin’s foundation with Jeremiah. After they had walked for a while, Jeremiah started to speak.

“Listen, Gus. I didn’t want to get Lacey’s hopes up, but I learned something that might help the young lady, and I wanted to share the story with you. Maybe you’ll have some ideas. A few days ago, I encountered Randall the Wise. He is a kindly badger who knows just about everything there is to know. It was a bit of luck that I ran into him, since he wanders the woodland constantly and rarely sleeps in the same place two nights in a row. He is full of wisdom, and has been a friend to the field mice. Well, to most all creatures, truth be told. Well, I mentioned meeting Lacey and the damage to her wing. Randall told me quite a story after hearing about Miss Lacey’s wing. Now, he warned me this story may well be more fable than fact. He told me of a tribe of magical ladybugs that supposedly have the ability to repair damaged insect wings!”

Gus looked astonished. “What? I can’t believe it! Are you saying that Lacey might actually fly again?”

Jeremiah raised a paw of caution. “Let’s not get ahead of ourselves, Gus. That’s why I didn’t want to talk about this in front of Lacey, because I haven’t been able to verify that the story is actually true. And... there’s a little bit of a complication I haven’t mentioned.” Gus’s smile disappeared as he waited for his buddy to continue.

“The thing is, these ladybugs are rumored to live on the other side of the river. That’s a problem, because the river is much too

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wide for me or any of my woodland friends to get across. I think you already know this, but flyers don't normally talk to us land dwellers. I reckon they don't have a high regard for critters that don't have wings. In fact, Lacey is the first winged insect that has ever talked to me! She is such a sweet girl, that one!" The old mouse chuckled. "Unless we can figure out a way across the river, I'm afraid this ladybug legend will remain a mystery."

Jeremiah waited for Gus to process all he had heard. The caterpillar had never ventured beyond the cabin's boundaries, and thoughts of rivers and ladybugs and miracles were a lot for him to take in. "Well, gosh Jeremiah... I don't know what to say. There's got to be something we can do!" Gus finally managed.

Jeremiah nodded sympathetically in agreement. "Let's just think about it for a bit. Maybe we'll find an answer together!" He turned to look at Gus. "There's one more thing that I learned about our sparkly friend," the mouse added. "You're not going to believe this, but here it is: dragonflies don't usually eat plants! Normally, they dine on flies, mosquitos, and the like. I wondered if old Randall would ever stop laughing after I mentioned that I met a vegetarian dragonfly!" He started chuckling again as Gus processed that tidbit of information, and soon they were both laughing.

"It never occurred to me that she would eat something as nasty as a fly!" Gus exclaimed after he was able to compose himself. "I guess it never occurred to Lacey, either!" That comment spurred another round of laughter. Then, Gus's mind returned to the ladybugs. It made him feel sad inside, and he wished that there was a way for him to help Lacey. He thought of her back at the boot, waiting for them. "I think we should head back, Jeremiah. Thank you for telling me about the ladybugs, and for

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talking to Randall the Wise in the first place. I think it's wonderful that there's a chance Lacey might fly again. I just wish there was a way I could go find those ladybugs."

Jeremiah looked at his friend with surprise, "You mean to say that you, Gustavius-Maybe-Tomorrow-But-Not-Today-Caterpillar, would leave the Land Under the Cabin?" he asked. After he saw the look in Gus's eyes, his face grew somber. "Well! Gus, my boy... you're willing to help a friend in need. I think that makes you a very good friend, indeed." A small paw patted the springy green folds of skin behind the caterpillar's antennae and he gestured toward the flowers with his other forepaw. "Come on, let's get back to Lacey," he squeaked.

The Flower Garden was a little darker when they got back. The sun's rays were diffused, as dark clouds had gathered during their walk. The gloominess of the sky was offset by the melodic voice of a singing dragonfly. They caught sight of Lacey dancing by herself as she sang an enchanting tune. Gus felt time slow down. He stood still, spellbound. The song, the graceful movements of Lacey as she spun and dipped... everything else disappeared from his already limited vision. He knew without a doubt that it was the most beautiful thing he'd ever seen, so beautiful that he felt a tear roll down his chubby cheek.

"My, my! Gus, have you ever seen anything so graceful?" asked Jeremiah. It took a little longer than it should have for Gus to realize that Jeremiah was talking to him. He closed his mouth and thought of how to reply, "Uh, well, yeah. I mean, no! That is, you know... I think that her wings, and the way they kind of float and wave... and that melody..." His voice trailed off. When he noticed Lacey and Jeremiah eyeing each other with bemused looks, he finished lamely, "Well, it was pretty... pretty magical, I

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guess.” Lacey smiled a happy, radiant smile at Gus while a few mousy chuckles leaked out of Jeremiah.

“After all that, I’m sorry to say that I really must get back to my home. That owl...” A tiny tremor ran through Jeremiah as he hugged his friends goodbye.

“Well, goodb...wait,” Gus thought for a moment. “Hey, Jeremiah, have you ever thought of burrowing a tunnel under the river?” Jeremiah’s eyes popped open.

“The river?! Burrow under the river!! My dear boy, the sheer logistics of such an idea. And the lateral spasticity required to withstand the pressure of all that water? Not even to mention the ventilation problems...” Jeremiah began to laugh so hard that the laughter turned into a cough. “Burrow under the river!” The field mouse, who apparently knew all about subterranean construction, wiped the tears from his eyes and waved a fond farewell. He scampered through a gap in the foundation, chattering to himself, “Wait until Diane hears about this. Hee hee!”

As Jeremiah’s tail disappeared through the crevice, Lacey turned to Gus with a confused look. “What was that all about?” she asked. Gus looked at her, but didn’t know what to say. Finally he told her, “It’s nothing. I just wondered what’s on the other side of the river. That’s all.”

Lacey smirked. “The other side of the river? Why Gus, you haven’t even been to the other side of that wall,” she gestured toward the cabin’s foundation. “What a strange thing to wonder.” The look she gave Gus indicated that she suspected he was keeping something from her.

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Gus heaved his ample body with a sigh. “I don’t know, it was a dumb question. Hey, can we head to the mossy area now? It’s been a long day.” He started to inch along, as Lacey took one more bite before turning to follow.

“Hai, wai fo muh!” she called. It didn’t take her long to catch up to the slug-slow caterpillar. As they made their way, Lacey swallowed the last of her leafy mouthful. “What did Jeremiah want to talk about?” she asked the moody Gus. He thought for a while. “Well, I don’t really know how to talk to you about one thing he told me, but let me tell you about the other thing he told me...”

A smile spread over his green face. “I learned that dragonflies don’t normally eat plants. Yeah.” He added as he saw Lacey’s dumbfounded look and brushed a piece of leaf off of Lacey’s cheek. “Apparently you eat flies and mosquitos and such. You’re a carnivore!”

“Flies!” Lacey looked shocked for a moment. Then she looked at Gus. “Oh my!” The two burst out in peals of laughter. “You might be the only vegetarian dragonfly in the whole world!” Gus exclaimed.

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Chapter 6 - Along Came a Spider

During their stretching & yawning the next morning, Gus greeted his friend with an idea. “Good morning, Lacey! You know, I just thought of something. In my travels around the Land Under the Cabin, I’ve avoided that area over there.” His antennae indicated Musty Dusty Corner. “I saw a big spider web once, which means there’s gotta be a big spider, right? I don’t think I’d like to meet that spider...”

But, you remember what Jeremiah said yesterday. Well, I was thinking that we might find some of the food your kind usually eats over there, maybe we can catch a fly or something. It could help you feel stronger, you know, maybe they are full of vitamins and stuff. What do you think?”

Lacey looked with curiosity at the dark corner that they had never discovered together, and her eyes glittered. “That sounds like an excellent adventure! I’m not concerned about a little old spider... but you seem to be.”

Gus raised his fuzzy eyebrows. “Spiders sure seem scary to me!”

Lacey nudged her friend playfully. “Now Gus, if Jeremiah was here, he’d probably say something like, ‘You can’t judge a book by its cover.’” Lacey was even able to make her voice squeak, which made Gus laugh.

“You’re right, Lacey,” Gus replied. “I mean, look at us! Who would guess a caterpillar and a dragonfly could be friends?” His stomach rumbled. “There are some mushrooms we can have for breakfast along the way. I think you’ll like them. Ready?”

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The air was crisp and fresh as they traveled, and they got their fill at the mushroom patch. Lacey nodded politely when asked if they were to her liking, but anyone watching her facial expression would have a hard time believing her words. Gus didn't notice though. His poor eyesight made it hard for him to see little details like that.

They talked about some of the games they could play later and wondered aloud what they might find up ahead. "Maybe it's just an old, abandoned web and we won't find anything," Lacey suggested as the murky space crept into view. The friends ventured into *Musty Dusty Corner*, side by side.

"Let's hope so!" Gus replied nervously. Gus's nervousness rubbed off a little on Lacey, but she shook it off and made a suggestion. "Let's go over and see if anyone lives there," she coaxed with a whisper.

Gus stopped in his tracks and stared at her. "We are supposed to be here to look for food, Lacey! Let's not be dangerous!" Gus whispered back.

Lacey prodded her friend again, "C'mon, Gus. You didn't run away when you found me. And now we're good friends, aren't we?" Gus protested. "But you are *my* size, Lace... whatever made *that*," pointing an antenna toward the web, "it has to be bigger than both of us!" Lacey just gave Gus a look and waited.

Gus finally sighed and agreed. "Well, all right. But if things go bad... don't wait around for me, ok? Just get out of here."

"Oh, Guster... you can be so dramatic!" Lacey observed playfully as she approached the web, looking back a few times to make

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sure Gus was following her. “Hello? Is anyone there?” Lacey’s voice faltered a little as she called out into the silence. For a moment, all was quiet. Almost too quiet...

Then, a gentle tremor rippled through the elaborate web stretched out in front of them. The web had a curious zigzag pattern of silk running through the center called a stabilimentum, which shimmered in a mesmerizing way with the vibration.

Another tremor shook the web, this one stronger. Gus lost some of his color as his mouth gaped open. The largest, scariest spider he’d ever seen suddenly appeared from a dark crevice and moved silently down to the center of the web.

The legs started out yellow, almost glowing yellow where they attached to the body. But after the first segment, they transitioned to the darkest black. The abdomen coloring matched the legs, with a striking combination of black and yellow markings, not unlike those of a bumblebee. The thorax was a light almond hue, which seemed almost out of place compared to the very colorful lower body and legs.

Where they attached near the mouth, the spider’s glistening fangs matched the light yellow hue of its legs. But they ended in pointed black tips that added a sinister aura to the scene. As if the rest of the spider weren’t sinister-looking enough! Gus’s knees weren’t close enough to each other to knock together, but they trembled mightily as he tried to stand brave.

Lacey moved a little closer to Gus. Gus moved a little closer to Lacey. Neither dared speak as they watched the graceful entrance of Musty Dusty Corner’s stealthy inhabitant. The

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spider's dark, glistening fangs clicked ominously, just before a silky smooth voice penetrated the stillness.

"Well... it has been a very long time since I've entertained company. As a matter of fact, most visitors are not expecting to meet anyone at all when they pass this way." The spider's voice sounded warm and inviting, but did Gus detect an undertone of danger and mystery? Or was that just his imagination...

"Are you two lost, or did you mean to enter... what do you call it? 'Musty, Dusty Corner', isn't it?" The spider's expression was hard to interpret. Gus couldn't tell if she was offended by the name he gave to her home.

Lacey looked at Gus. Gus looked at Lacey. He thought they must be thinking the same thing... "How does she know what we call this place?" After a moment and a look of reassurance from Lacey, Gus cleared his throat. "W...well, yes, that *is* what we call this area of the Land Under the Cabin, but I can't figure out how you know that. Are you... a magic spider?" Nervously rambling on without waiting for an answer, Gus continued, "I'm Gustavius Caterpillar, and t...this is my friend, Lacey Dragonfly. Well, that's the name she's using right now, she can't remember her real name or where she came from, or what happened before she came here. Or d...did you already know that, too?"

The frightening fangs clicked as the spider chuckled softly. "Well, as a matter of fact, yes, Gus. I do know a bit about you two. I've actually been watching you for some time. Keeping an eye on the neighbors, you know." the spider flashed a covert winked at her visitors with a sly smile. "I like to be aware of what goes on in the land. Gus, young man, you seem to have grown up quite a bit in the time since you found Lacey. But I

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must admit that I hadn't expected to see you here in my domain. You seem to have avoided this part of the Land Under the Cabin in the past, wouldn't you agree?"

Gus glanced toward Lacey, then looked back to the spider guiltily. "Well, you see, I have a friend who told me scary stories about spiders who eat caterpillars. He warned me to avoid this area."

The spider remained quiet for some time. Then she sighed. "What your friend said is true. There are many spiders who would regard you, Gus, and even you, dear Lacey, as their dinner." She watched Gus with a critical eye. "I thought that our meeting may one day come to pass. And now that you are here, the time has come for us to talk."

Another silence enveloped the trio as she invited Gus and Lacey to walk with her. "Your friend Jeremiah and I... actually, he and I used to be friends. Good friends. It's not my place to say what came to pass, but Jeremiah no longer holds esteem for me. He now detests all spiders, I daresay. But what's happened in the past cannot be undone. And the love of another cannot be forced. Love must be given freely." In a quiet voice tinged with sadness, she added, "That is why I honor Jeremiah's wishes and keep my distance."

Gus considered what the spider had told them. He could not conjure a reason in his mind that could justify Jeremiah turning away from a friend. He had been a friend to Gus for most of his life, and he tried to imagine what it must feel like to have lost that friendship. "I'm sorry to hear that sad story, Miss Spider. Jeremiah is my best friend. I don't understand why he would act

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that way toward you. That doesn't seem like the Jeremiah I know."

The spider smiled sadly. "Indeed. One of the great challenges of life is to learn to accept with grace a friendship lost. Another is to extend trust after suffering trauma or betrayal.

Shaking her head, she straightened. "Please forgive my manners. I have not properly introduced myself! Lacey and Gus, you may call me Aluna. This musty, dusty corner, as you call it, has been my home for quite some time. I like to think that some portion of the peace and quiet we enjoy in the Land Under the Cabin is a result of my vigilance. I have met some visitors to our land who unfortunately, I had to invite to leave. And of those, a few unwise creatures who chose not to heed the invitation..." Aluna's clicking fangs made Gus shiver.

Lacey curtsied politely. "It is a great pleasure to meet you, Aluna. I thank you for watching over us, and I am sorry we didn't visit you before today. The story of Jeremiah saddens me. Are you the queen of this land? You certainly seem like one."

Aluna answered with a shake of her head. "Here in the Land Under the Cabin, there is no need for title or ceremony. I'm simply Aluna, the Yellow Garden Spider. I know how important and special a friendship can be, and Jeremiah is a kind and worthy friend. I do not wish to cause any conflict between you. But, today you came to me. And I sense that perhaps we were destined to meet."

Gus cleared his throat. "That seems to be the case. Yesterday, Jeremiah told me that Lacey *isn't* a vegetarian like caterpillars

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are. I suggested we try to find some of her kind of food, and we thought that this might be a good place to try catching a fly.

When we got here, Lacey wanted to call out. She is a lot braver than I am. At first, I didn't think that was a good idea. But after thinking about it, I don't know... I guess I just felt like it was a good idea. I can't explain why!"

Aluna smiled, but didn't seem surprised by his story. "I was wondering if Lacey was ever again going to enjoy a nice, tender fly. I don't think I could survive on a leafy diet, but who knows? I've never tried." She moved to a bundle hanging by a silvery thread of silk attached to the web. "Maybe tomorrow, but not today. Today, dear Lacey, allow me to treat you to a real meal."

Gus, looking a little flushed, decided not to stick around to watch. "Oh! Look over there! I wonder what *that* is..." Gus waved his antennae vaguely toward nothing in particular. "I'll let you two get to know each other a little better. Enjoy your breakfast!"

He moved away as quickly as he could, but couldn't help but overhear Aluna explaining to Lacey how to open the sac. "Maybe tomorrow, but not today..." he muttered to himself as he inched along. "I *like* eating plants! They are so yummy. And green. And clean!"

Gus enjoyed exploring this unfamiliar patch of ground, finding some lonely blades of grass to munch on. After some time, he heard two familiar voices approaching. "There you are, Gus!" Lacey exclaimed excitedly. "You were right- I *do* feel like I have more energy now. I never thought flies could be so delicious!"

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Gus swallowed. “That’s wonderful...” but his voice didn’t seem convincing. “Good old Jeremiah, right?”

“He has been a great help to me,” Lacey concurred, then turned to their friend. “You are too, Aluna. I’m so glad to have met you!”

Aluna inclined her head, “Likewise, good Lacey. You are an extraordinary dragonfly.” She smiled at Gus. “Well, Gus... Lacey couldn’t stop going on about you. And I agree with her. You two complement one another nicely.”

Gus and Lacey exchanged a glance. Sensing Gus was at a loss for words, Lacey broke the silence that followed the compliment. “Well, Aluna, I’m afraid we really should be going. I have my exercises to do, and Gus was going to take me back to Treasure Trove today. Isn’t that right, Gus?” Gus nodded his head with relief. “Thank you so much for welcoming us with friendship. Might we plan to visit you again soon?”

Aluna bowed, her multifaceted eyes glittering with reflected sunlight. “Most certainly, dear. My web is open to you, night or day. I am very happy that our paths have finally crossed.” She turned to take her leave. “A pleasant journey to you both, Lacey and Gus! Until next time we meet.”

Gus and Lacey admired the graceful movement of Aluna’s legs until she disappeared behind a support pillar. “Well, that was the best! Thank you so much for bringing me here.” Lacey commented contentedly. “It feels good to meet a new friend, don’t you think?”

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Gus nodded. "It sure does. I think Aluna feels the same way about us!" He paused thoughtfully. "I guess I should give other creatures a chance before I decide if they are friend material."

Lacey flapped her wings energetically. "I'm glad she's nice. She told me that some spiders eat caterpillars and dragonflies! I guess we are pretty lucky... that could have ended badly for us." Her wings slowed as she glanced at him as if inviting his thoughts.

Gus felt butterflies in his abdominal segments when he thought of encountering one of *those* kinds of spiders. He didn't want to think of what might have happened. The day turned out to be a pretty good one... so far.

But Gus, who had been feeling a little off since he woke up, now felt achy and feverish. "Now we know, that's for sure! I'm glad Aluna turned out to be a friend." Gus stopped and turned toward his companion. "Do you mind if we go back to the moss? I feel a little funny. Maybe those mushrooms weren't ready to eat."

Lacey looked concerned. "Sure, Gus. Let's go home." Gus started to worry that he was really sick. He tried to pretend he was fine, but as they approached the mossy area, he decided to let Lacey know how he was feeling. "I feel hot and wiggly inside, and my skin feels itchy all over," he reported, "and my antennae are burning and itchy, too."

Lacey urged him to lie on his mossy bed and rest. "I know just what you need." Her large eyes were full of empathy. "I'll go get you some of the leaves you like, and you'll feel better in no time!"

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Gus groaned softly as he collapsed onto his soft green bed. “Maybe. I don’t really feel all that hungry, but I guess some food might help. Thank you, Lacey.” He closed his eyes wearily as Lacey started off toward Flower Garden.

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Chapter 7 - Gus Goes Missing

Lacey finally returned, mandibles clutching a bunch of tender green leaves. “Gus, look what I brought you!” she sang out as she dropped the leaves on a smooth rock near the slumbering caterpillar. Gus didn’t respond, not even a snort. Lacey checked her friend’s condition and grew concerned. His skin appeared flaky, and she could see it was pulsating softly.

“Oh, Gus...” she said as she touched his hot, dry skin, “Tell me how to help you!” She looked helplessly at the pile of leaves, then back at Gus. She tried nudging him softly, then with purpose. “Gus!” She urged, “Wake up! It’s Lacey!” When he still failed to respond, Lacey’s concern turned into despair.

Suddenly, Lacey felt very alone. “What can I do? I don’t know where Jeremiah lives. I don’t know anybo...” She blinked back tears as she recalled their adventure of just a few hours ago, yet it seemed like days to Lacey now. “Aluna!” She smiled, despite her fear. The thought of having a friend who she could turn to gave her great comfort. “I’ll go see our new friend, Gus! She’ll know what to do!”

Lacey felt tired, but all she could think of was getting help. “I’ll be back soon, Gussy Bear. Just rest and I’ll be back with Aluna before you know it.”

She began to walk toward Musty Dusty Corner and Aluna’s web with backward glances. As she lost sight of the moss and the green lump that was Gus, fear once again gripped her. She began walking faster, then running. She used her wings to propel her even faster past landmarks that were now familiar to her.

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By the time she came within sight of the spider's web, she was nearly flying! "Aluna! Oh, Aluna... are you here?" she cried out as she neared the spot where she and Gus had encountered the spider earlier that day. Fighting back tears, she searched along the crevice in the footing of the cabin where the spider had previously appeared, but saw no movement. Nothing. A sense of desperation filled her as she caught her breath and turned her head this way and that.

Presently, her keen eyes noticed movement. Aluna approached from the direction of Weed Jungle, moving with no particular hurry. The graceful movement of Aluna's long legs dispelled Lacey's despair, but words failed her. As she stood and turned to face the approaching spider, Aluna noticed the state Lacey was in and quickened her pace.

"Lacey, my dear! I didn't expect to see you again so soon! I'm just returning from my evening stroll. Where is Gus hiding?" As she neared the trembling dragonfly, she looked at Lacey with concern. Lifting her chin gently with a sleek fore-leg, she soothed with a gentle voice, "There, there, child... Tell me what's the matter." Her eyes glittered with a tenderness that made Lacey feel comforted inside, while at the same time causing all of her emotions to once again flood to the surface.

"Oh, Aluna!" She managed as fresh tears filled her eyes and spilled down her cheeks. "I don't know what to do!" Her words tumbled out so fast that the spider had trouble keeping up. She told Aluna all about the trip back to the moss, leaving Gus to gather some food for him, and her inability to rouse him when she returned. "Won't you please help me?" she begged. Lacey started to sob, her delicate legs covering her eyes.

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“Oh My! Let us not delay,” Aluna responded as Lacey tried to compose herself. “Lead the way, dear. Yet, I have a feeling that the situation is not as dire as you may think. Do try to be brave, Lacey dear.” The pair started off toward the moss and the ailing Gus. Aluna had no trouble keeping pace with Lacey as she sped along, fretting and imagining all sorts of terrible things. Aluna did her best to comfort the distressed Lacey, but the young dragonfly was unconsolable.

Soon, they approached the mossy area. Lacey saw the leaves that she had gathered, but she didn’t see Gus! “Oh no... where did he go?” Lacey wondered as she looked around frantically for her friend. “He was laying right there, and I couldn’t rouse him no matter what I tried. And now, he’s gone! What can we do? Shall we search for him?”

To her surprise, Aluna was smiling tenderly when Lacey turned to her. Aluna’s expression and attitude were so calm that Lacey didn’t quite know what to think. It surprised her so much that she stopped ranting and waited for Aluna to speak.

“Lacey, my dear girl... I have something to tell you that you will find quite remarkable, and I believe it will help you feel much better.” Seeing that Lacey had calmed somewhat, she moved closer and pointed over Lacey’s head. As Lacey’s gaze followed the direction of the outstretched leg, she saw something that she had never noticed before...

Near the spot where Gus had been lying, a support pillar extended from a cement base to the cabin floor. And on that support pillar, there was a rusty nail about halfway up. The nail stuck out a few inches and was slightly bent. But that wasn’t the most interesting thing about the nail.

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The most interesting thing about the nail was that something new hung beneath it. There was a smooth, green cylinder attached to it that Lacey was quite sure she had never seen before. She looked at her companion and asked, “Aluna... what is that?”

Aluna settled down on the ground, legs folded neatly beneath her body to allow Lacey to look her in the eye without straining her neck. “Well, I know that you consider Gus a good friend, he certainly is kind and generous. But beyond those qualities, he is quite an amazing creature for other reasons as well.

There’s a reason that Gus is so plump. At a certain point in a caterpillar’s life, they undergo a strange and marvelous change! Gus is inside there. That sac is called a chrysalis. He’s going to need all that body fat to survive in there for a time, but don’t despair. Gus will emerge from that shell one day soon. In the meantime, you keep him company. Watch over him, and you’ll be reunited before you know it! While we wait for him to emerge, I will visit you every day and bring you tasty flies to keep your strength up. How does that sound?”

Lacey beamed, relief filling her and smoothing her worried features. A radiant smile of gladness eased the grief that she had felt all evening. A tear fell from her eye, but this was a tear of relief and gratitude. “Oh, thank you, Aluna. I don’t know what I would have done if you weren’t here,” she said. At once, she realized that she was very, very hungry. “Did you mention something about flies?” The two friends laughed as Aluna rose from the ground and went to fetch an evening snack.

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As Lacey waited for Aluna to return, she gazed up at the chrysalis in wonder. It was so hard for her to imagine her friend was up there, hanging by a thread in a delicate green sac. She imagined the effort it must have taken for him to get up there in his condition. “Why and how on earth do caterpillars do that?” she wondered to herself. Then, in a sing-song voice, she called out to her friend.

“Gus, oh Gussy! It’s me, Lacey. I’m down here... where you left me. Can you hear me in there? I just want you to know that I’ll be here waiting for you to come out, and then we can go on more adventures together! Just don’t take too long, ok?” She paused in reflection, as if debating something in her head. She hummed to herself, muttered to herself, then hummed some more. She closed her eyes in concentration.

“As you snore? No that’s not right... toss and turn? No, no... c’mon, Lacey... think!” Then suddenly her eyes opened. “Yes, that’s it!” Smiling, she addressed the motionless green sac again. “I noticed how much you liked the song I was singing the other day when you and Jeremiah came back from your walk. So I thought I’d come up with a new song just for you. I was going to sing it to you after I got the final part figured out. Well, now I do! I think I’ll sing it to you; hopefully it will help you know that you’re not alone.”

Lacey hummed to warm up her voice, then began to sing.

*I was scared and alone when you found me
My thoughts were all lost in a whirl
I was frightened and blue,
Didn’t know what to do
I was one rather pitiful girl.*

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*I needed a friend just like you, Gus,
You're friendly, and tender, and kind
I don't know my name,
Don't know what's to blame
But you, dear sweet Gus, you don't mind.*

*Now fate has reversed our position
It is you who is helpless, asleep
I am here, watching over
Your chrysalis cover
As you slumber, a vigil I'll keep*

Lacey didn't notice that Aluna had returned sometime during her singing. "That was quite beautiful," her eight-legged friend commented after a moment of silence. Lacey jumped, not expecting company at that moment.

Aluna placed a leg on the startled dragonfly's shoulder. "Forgive me, my dear. I didn't mean to surprise you. You certainly do have a talent for singing, Lacey. I'm sure Gus could hear your beautiful voice, even in his sleep." She smiled sweetly at Lacey and offered her the promised snack.

The two friends spoke for a while about Gus. Aluna told Lacey more about Jeremiah, his wife, and children. Lacey could tell that Aluna was quite fond of the mouse, but couldn't think of anything to say to help relieve Aluna's sadness. So she just gave her a hug.

Finally, Lacey was ready to sleep. It had been a very eventful and emotional day. She nestled in her usual spot and looked over at the bed of moss normally occupied by Gus. Aluna climbed up the pillar and, finding a shadow to inhabit, watched over her young charges through the night.

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Chapter 8 - How Jeremiah Got His Name

Days passed. Lacey found herself gazing for hours at the chrysalis that held her friend suspended above her in the air. She noticed things about it in the light of day that had escaped her when he had crawled up there and hid himself away from the world. The sac had a circlet of what seemed to Lacey to be golden gemstones circling halfway around the chrysalis in a graceful arc. The rest of the sac was studded with more of the golden spots that fairly glittered. She considered Gus's temporary home one of the most magical things she had ever seen.

Most of her time during those lonely days, Lacey stayed near the mossy area. She would talk out loud to Gus, hoping that he could hear her voice and know she was near. She would sing him the new songs she created and dance her graceful dances. She also kept up her exercise routine. Somehow she knew that Gus would ask her about those exercises when he awoke!

Several times a day, she would check the... what had Aluna called it? Oh, yes. The *chrysalis*! Gus's new, very tiny home. Try as she might, Lacey could not detect any movement or changes inside. As still as it was, she had a hard time believing that her friend was in there. She missed him terribly. While Aluna was a great comfort and an agreeable companion, her formality and the difference in their ages made it... well, it just wasn't the same as spending time with Gus.

There was, however, a new hobby she discovered with Aluna's help. Lacey learned how to braid spider silk into coils of strong silk cord. While she didn't have a use for it, the activity gave her

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something to do while passing the time alone or talking to Aluna. It also kept her mind occupied with something other than thinking about Gus.

True to her word, Aluna passed by every morning and afternoon with tasty morsels for Lacey, and the two would talk. Aluna told her how she had come to live in the Land Under the Cabin, and of her life long ago when she was a young spider. Jeremiah used to tell her about his experiences as a young mouse and stories that he had heard from others, and she enjoyed relating the stories to Lacey.

One of the stories was about Jeremiah's grandfather, Cecil. He was a great storyteller and taught the skill to his grandson. When he was a lad, Cecil lived with his parents and siblings in a farmhouse a full two days of mouse-journey from the cabin. They roamed around in the space inside the walls and searched for food only during the night when the farmhouse was quiet.

The family had an orange tabby cat that they brought home to hunt mice. In reality, the cat was a gentle creature who didn't have any desire to hunt rodents. The mice were timid creatures though, so they avoided the cat and people at all costs. There were always scraps of food to be found, as the family wasn't very good at cleaning up after themselves. And so, they all lived together in relative peace and comfort; humans, cat, and mice.

Cecil grew up and became the leader of the mischief of mice living in the farmhouse walls. He married a pretty mouse named Cecilia. Their youngest son, Alexander, would one day become Jeremiah's father. When Alexander was young, he was a disobedient pup. He was always finding trouble, and his parents blamed him for most of their gray hair. But Alexander had the

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sweetest disposition, and somehow found his way out of many punishments that he very much deserved.

One day, Alexander decided it would be fun to leave the safety of the walls to explore the kitchen! His mother had warned him many times that he must never leave the nest in the daylight, but she couldn't watch him closely because she had her hands very busy with caring for all of her other children. Alexander loved how doing dangerous things made him feel, and he was of an age where he didn't believe anything bad could happen to him.

This morning, however, Alexander was going to learn what happens to young mice who don't listen to their parents. He was crossing the floor from the knothole that served as the mouse family's front door and started following his nose in search of food. As he crossed the kitchen floor, he caught the eye of Toby, the youngest member of the human family. If there was anyone who was a match for Alexander's mischievous nature, it was Toby.

Alexander was overjoyed when he found a few pieces of breakfast cereal on the floor near the dining room table! He couldn't believe his good fortune as he sank his little teeth into one of the toasted Os he had discovered. How happy his mother would be when he brought her back this treasure! Alexander may have escaped Toby's clutches had he started back toward the safety of the knothole immediately, but he couldn't resist taking just a tiny taste of his prize first.

The drinking glass pinched his delicate tail as Toby lowered it over the distracted Alexander. The pain in his tail and the sound of the glass striking the wooden floor startled Alexander so much

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that it took him a few moments to understand that he was trapped. The boy's head was magnified by the glass as Toby peered close to examine his new pet, and it terrified the mouse to be so close to a human. A piece of cardboard slipped under the glass allowed Toby to pick up the trap and take it to his bedroom.

Toby tapping on the glass did nothing to settle Alexander's frazzled nerves. He trembled as the boy placed him on the nightstand next to the bed and balanced a heavy book on the glass, to ensure that he wouldn't be able to escape while a proper cage could be found. "I'm going to name you Squeaky," Toby informed his captive. "Don't go anywhere... I'll be right back!"

Toby ran out of the room in search of a more permanent home for Alexander. Try as he might, the pint-sized mouse couldn't budge the glass. Perhaps if the boy hadn't placed the book on top, he would have been able to push the glass to the edge of the table and free himself. But it was no use. Alexander curled up in a ball and tried to calm his frantic heartbeat. He thought about his parents. Would they notice he was gone? Would he ever see them again?

Alexander felt very sorry for himself. He now realized the dangers that his parents warned him about were very real. Why hadn't he listened? He knew his parents loved him and only wanted to keep him and his siblings safe, yet he was always getting into trouble because he didn't listen. Well, *this* misadventure had certainly gotten his attention. He vowed that if he could get out of this predicament, he would change his ways. He would show his parents that he *could* be obedient. If only he could escape...

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It was then that the orange tabby entered the room. He had come into the house as Toby threw open the back door, on his way to the barn. Toby was on his way to retrieve a birdcage he had spied while watching his father as he worked on outdoor projects and cared for the farm animals. Toby knew that his new pet would never be able to chew his way through the birdcage's metal bars!

As he entered Toby's bedroom, the cat sniffed at the air. He could sense a new scent, but it took him a little searching to discover the young captive trapped on the nightstand. Jumping up on the bed, he looked curiously at Alexander as the mouse cowered against the far edge of his prison, paws hiding his face. Alexander had never seen a cat up close, and in his excited state, the sight of the large animal was too much for him. "Well, now," the tabby said as he sniffed the glass. "You seem to have gotten yourself into quite a pickle. My goodness... your tail is bent! How did the boy catch you?" But it was easy for him to guess. "You must have left your nest during the day..." he scolded.

Alexander was desperate. He didn't know what a pickle was, but he didn't like the sound of it at all. He knew the boy would be back any minute. Would he live in a cage for the rest of his life, or become the lunch of this monster first? Both fates terrified him. He cowered, trying not to think of either outcome.

The cat saw that the little mouse inside the overturned glass was trembling, and had pity for the little guy. "Okay, let's see what we can do about getting you out of there..." the cat said as he swiped tentatively at the book with a paw. The book was a hefty one- the S volume of a hard-bound encyclopedia set. It didn't budge.

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Just then, the back door slammed as Toby returned from the barn outside. “Oh no!” the cat exclaimed, and he knew that time was running out. “Here goes nothing, little guy... watch your tail!” He put his head against the book and pushed.

At this point, several things happened in rapid succession. Toby, with the birdcage in hand, turned the hall corner and entered the room. The glass tipped over as the heavy book fell... Alexander was free! The book hit the lamp and Toby’s alarm clock on its way to the floor, landing with a thud, opening to a page explaining Salamanders. The lamp fell to the floor next to the book with a loud POP, as the light bulb shattered upon impact. The alarm clock was the old-fashioned kind with two bells with a little hammer between them. The impact from the book caused the hammer to start doing what it was designed to do. The clanging clock and the exploding light bulb startled the cat, who jumped into the air a few feet and, upon landing, decided he would rather be under the bed. He disappeared in an orange blur.

As all that was happening, the glass that had held Alexander captive was rolling slowly toward the edge of the table. He watched it roll off, bounce off the open encyclopedia, and clatter to a stop next to Toby’s discarded pajamas on the floor.

Wide-eyed, Toby dropped the cage where he stood, trying to make sense of everything that he had just witnessed. “Nooooo!” he screamed as he rushed to recapture his new pet. He cupped his hands over the stunned mouse before Alexander had a chance to regain his senses. Toby carefully lifted his prisoner and carried him toward the birdcage.

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Alexander's head was ringing from the clamor of the alarm. He was disoriented, and for a moment he didn't know what was happening. Suddenly, he felt the boy's sweaty, grimy hands clamp over him and lift him off the table. The hands squeezed him, making it hard to breathe. Alexander's instincts took over as he was carried toward the cage that lay on its side near the door. He did the only thing that his little brain could think of... he bit Toby's finger.

Toby shrieked. His hands flew open and Alexander fell, striking Toby's shoe and rolling to the floor. He was shaken, but except for the crimp in his tail, unhurt. Before Toby had a chance to do anything but grasp his injured finger, Alexander ran. He scampered out the door and down the hall. "Get back here!" Toby yelled as he ran after the mouse, the pain in his finger temporarily forgotten.

Alexander reached the knothole and dove through it, just as Toby lunged to grab him. He could feel the weight of Toby's hand fall on his crooked tail. Luckily, it slipped through the boy's grasp. Alexander was safe! At least for the moment. As he panted in the cramped space in the wall, he heard Toby's mother enter the room. "What on earth is going on, Toby? I told you to keep it down so I could take a nap! It sounds like a tornado just tore through the house!"

"But mom, you don't understand!" Facing his angry mother, feeling his finger start to throb, and seeing a drop of blood near the teeth marks was too much for Toby. He started to cry. Through his sobs, he tried to tell the story of spying Alexander, capturing him, and going out to find the birdcage. Toby's mother had a hard time understanding the incoherent story, but she seemed to be grasping the main points. At last, he got to where

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the book was upset by the cat. “I came back in, and Jeremiah was trying to get my mouse! He messed everything up!” Toby shrieked, and buried his face in his mother’s blouse.

Lacey interrupted the story with a start. “Pardon me, Aluna. But did you say the cat’s name... was Jeremiah?” She looked at the spider with an incredulous expression. Aluna smiled and nodded. “That’s right. Alexander was so grateful that he was saved by that tabby cat, and for other things that happened later, that he named his first son Jeremiah.”

“Wow!” was all Lacey could say for a moment. Then she giggled. “That was quite a story! I wonder how Jeremiah feels about being named after a cat,” she added, shaking her head and continuing to giggle.

“Oh, I don’t think he minds,” Aluna replied. “He told me that his father kept his promise of listening to his parents after that. He became the most obedient mouse in the family! And the most cautious. Jeremiah really admired his dad, and I believe that learning from his father’s good example is a big reason for his character today. I’m sure he will tell you more if you ask him. He learned the art of storytelling from his grandfather, and he loves to talk about his family.”

Aluna stretched her long legs and resettled herself before continuing. “We haven’t reached the end of the story, however. It seems that Toby’s parents were *not* happy to learn that they had a mouse living in the house, and they decided to call an exterminator. Once again, Jeremiah Cat came to the rescue. He was able to warn Cecil and Cecilia in time, and told them of the shed right outside this cabin! He brought them here the night

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before the exterminator arrived. Over time, Alexander and Jeremiah Cat became very good friends.”

“My goodness!” Lacey reflected as she considered everything Aluna had told her. “I look forward to hearing more of Jeremiah’s stories in the future! I’m afraid we haven’t had much time to get to know each other in the two visits he’s made since I arrived. I just realized that he doesn’t yet know what has happened to Gus! I do hope he will pass by again soon.”

Aluna replied with a shrug, indicating that Jeremiah’s comings and goings were a mystery to her as well. “I know he has a large family, and taking care of them takes most of his time. But don’t fret, Lacey dear. I’m sure he will visit you one day soon.” Lacey smiled, but at the same time, her eyes conveyed the hope that Aluna would one day regain her friendship with Jeremiah.

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A few more days passed, but Jeremiah did not make an appearance. Despite her attempts to recall the past, Lacey could only recall shadowy, cloudy memories of her life before meeting Gus. The days since arriving in the Land Under the Cabin, however, she remembered very well and recounted many of their talks and adventures to Aluna. “I would like you to know all about Gus by the time he is back with us,” she explained.

During times when Lacey was down, Aluna would remind her that Gus was there with them, and that any day he would come out of the little house he had made for himself. Things would not be as they were before, they would be even better!

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“Oh, Aluna! I know you’re right, but I’m so tired of waiting. Gus, please hurry up!” Lacey cried toward the chrysalis. Then, with a mischievous look in her eyes, she added in a louder voice, “Don’t you know that Aluna and I are planning a great feast to celebrate your awakening?” She winked at her friend.

Lacey’s ruse caused Aluna to chuckle. “You should have thought of that days ago, my dear! If anything will lure Gus out, it’s food!” The two friends laughed merrily. But inside, Lacey still missed her friend terribly.

# *The Caterpillar and the Dragonfly*

## *Chapter 9 - Transformation*

*It* was a Tuesday when it finally happened. For Lacey, it began as a rather bleak and dreary day. The weather outside was raging, rain pouring from dark storm clouds and wind punishing the poor cabin above. Luckily, the area where Gus had positioned his chrysalis was protected from the drops of rain that trickled through some sections of the cabin floor.

The sudden realization that occurred to her each morning that Gus was still inside the chrysalis was never pleasant, of course. Although the weather and her mood didn't help to motivate her, Lacey busied herself with her morning routine of jumping, flitting, and running. She felt that she was nearly able to fly, but each time she thought her fingertips would touch the timbers of the cabin above, she would begin falling back down to earth. It was frustrating, but it also motivated her to work harder. It seemed to Lacey that she was getting closer every day. She felt that one day soon, she would touch those wooden beams.

After her exercise, she stretched her tired wings and slowed her breathing. A slight movement caught her eye in the direction of the chrysalis. As she stared toward it, she realized that the movement came from the chrysalis itself, swinging slightly on its tether. Upon closer inspection, she saw that Gus's temporary home had become quite transparent! Inside, she could see movement from whatever (or whoever) was inside, but it sure didn't look like her friend. Lacey saw folds of soft green inside the clear membrane, accented with light green lines that looked like veins.

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Her breath caught as she noticed more movement! Amazed and transfixed, she watched as the bottom of the clear sac split open, and the creature inside began to emerge. She thought that it was probably the head of the insect that she could first identify. Ever so slowly, the chrysalis split open wider and wider. Lacey watched as two spindly legs reached out and grasped the outside of the clear chrysalis husk, just before it released its hold on the creature. She gasped as it hung there, clinging precariously to the clear membrane as two slender, graceful antennae swung outward and upward from where they had rested, snug against the head and body. They were much longer than the stubby caterpillar antennae Gus had sported, and they added a gracefulness and delicate aspect to the insect.

As the figure hung motionless, seemingly resting after such an exertion, Lacey wondered how on earth this could be her friend. It looked nothing like him, save the color of its wings and body that shared the same tones she had known to be Gus's colorings. "Aluna said he was undergoing a transformation in there, but this... this is quite unbelievable!" she thought to herself as she gaped at the spectacle playing out before her eyes.

Now free of the chrysalis, the dark folds of velvety material unfurled like a magician's cloak. Lacey watched in awe as the creature's abdomen expanded and constricted, the wings growing larger and more defined with each pulse. In moments, the soft folds transformed into elegant panels of verdant green, shimmering with lighter veins. Much larger and more dense than her wings, Lacey watched with wonder as they waved back and forth gently.

After what seemed to be an eternity, the butterfly- for Lacey could now tell that she was *definitely* looking at a magnificent

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butterfly- dropped down from the chrysalis shell, executing a graceful twirl with a deft flit of its outstretched wings. It landed lightly on the ground a few feet from Lacey with its back to her. Finally, Lacey managed a single word. “Gus?” She had difficulty believing that the butterfly standing before her could possibly be her formerly rotund friend. But then again, what other answer was there?

The figure turned slowly to face her. “Lacey!” The familiar voice was enough to convince her that it really was Gus, though this whole thing was so remarkable, she wondered if it was all just a dream. “I feel funny,” the butterfly confessed. Then he noticed Lacey’s startled expression. His head tilted to the side a bit, giving him an endearing look. “W...what’s wrong, Lacey? The last thing I remember was meeting that spider. What was her name? I can’t recall...”

He was almost bowled over as Lacey rushed to him, wrapping him in a warm embrace. “Oh, Gus! I am sooo glad to see you! You’re back!! Aluna told me you would come out, but she didn’t tell me that you would... that you would...” Tears of happiness rolled down Lacey’s cheeks. Gus took a step back, clearly confused.

“Oh, right... Aluna! That’s her name. She told you what? We just met her! How long have I been asleep? Why do I feel so strange?” a bewildered Gus queried. Lacey gazed at her best friend, suddenly at a loss for words. There was so much to tell him! She didn’t know where to start, how to begin explaining things in a way he could comprehend. She decided to start slowly, and trust that the right words would come to her.

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“Now Gus...why don’t you come and perch yourself over here?” She indicated a bit of root protruding from the ground. Gus obeyed. Once he had settled himself, Lacey started with, “You say you feel strange. Can you tell me more?”

Gus perched there on the bit of root, seeming to decide how to explain. “Well, to start with, everything looks different,” he began. “Things are so bright, and well... clear and focused! You look, you really look much more... more shiny and glittery, Lacey. You have always glowed, but now? Well, I can’t explain it. Your body and your wings- it’s like you’ve become even more... vibrant.”

Lacey blushed, and it seemed to Gus, grew even more radiant. As a caterpillar, he was accustomed to a near-sighted, black and white view of the world. Seeing the world through his butterfly eyes, he could suddenly see colors and his focus was much sharper. He could see so much farther! Of course, since he had never seen colors before, he didn’t have the vocabulary to describe what his new eyes were seeing. It was all very wonderful and amazing. “I can see so clearly! I feel like I’m seeing the world for the first time.”

He spun around, looking at the new, vibrant, electric, colorful world around him. “And I can feel things that I haven’t felt before! I can feel vibrations as drops of water hit the ground! I feel strong, and light, and powerful! I feel... superfillyistic!” His great wings fluttered, fanning a light breeze that Lacey could feel. “What’s happened to me, Lacey?” Gus trembled with nervous excitement as his sparkling eyes gazed at her expectantly.

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Lacey's voice trembled with emotion, happiness, and wonder as she began to explain all that had happened since Gus had begun his transformation. She told him about how she felt when she couldn't rouse him and fled to find Aluna. About the marvel of discovering that he had somehow suspended himself inside the chrysalis. She repeated what Aluna had told her, that this was something that caterpillars did, and how she had neglected to tell Lacey just how much of a transformation he would undergo while he was asleep. "I thought you just might be a little skinnier! I think I'll have a few words with her..." she said with a laugh.

She pointed to the empty, clear husk that had been his home for so many days. She recounted the loneliness she experienced while waiting for him, thinking up new songs to sing to him, longing for him to awaken.

"I remember hearing your voice!" Gus interjected. He hummed a little bit of the first tune that Lacey had sung to him, the night he retreated within the chrysalis. "It all seems like a long series of dreams. And you were there with me..." He smiled at his friend. "Thank you for watching over me, Lacey."

The dragonfly returned his warm smile. "Well, of course! After all you've done for me, it's the least I could do. You're the most caring friend I could ask for. I'm so glad you're back!" It was Gus's turn to blush as he looked away awkwardly.

Before he could think of something to say, Lacey continued. "This is the day I've been waiting for, and it's so much more wonderful than I could have imagined! I think it's time to tell you just why you feel so different. I think Aluna didn't tell me what was going on inside that chrysalis because she didn't want to

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spoil the surprise, and boy... am I surprised! Are you ready to be surprised, dear Gus?" Her eyes glittered, and she was rubbing her legs together, looking as if she would burst with excitement.

Gus asked himself if he *was* ready. He wondered what on earth she could tell him that could explain all of these new feelings and sensations. For a moment, he thought of how things had been before. It was true he liked the way he was feeling, but all this change was a lot to process. He thought of his life since finding Lacey perched on that old boot, and how she had changed his life ever since. That calmed his nerves somewhat. Yes, he decided. This was all new and that made him nervous, but having Lacey here to share this moment gave him courage. He began to tingle with the same excitement she felt. "I'm ready!" he replied and held his breath. But he was about to find out that actually, he wasn't.

He heard the words: "You're not a caterpillar anymore, Gus. You're a butterfly! A beautiful, green, magnificent butterfly. You have wings, Gus!!"

And then, Gus felt light-headed. The world spun around him, then everything spiraled into a singular pinpoint of light, followed by total darkness.

Gus  
    had  
        fainted!

~~~~~

Gus woke up in a meadow. A light breeze whispered across his face as the bright summer sun caused him to squint and he opened his eyes. Lacey was dancing merrily as Jeremiah and

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Aluna admired her grace, clapping as she twirled and leapt. What had she told him? That he was a butterfly? Him! Soft and round Gus? Lacey had told him he had wings! Wings? He shook his head, not daring to believe it could be true. Aluna noticed that he was awake, and all of his friends turned and started to run toward him, chattering excitedly. But the faster they ran, the farther they seemed to move away. What was happening? Gus began to panic.

Faintly, he heard a familiar voice from high above, calling his name, “Gus!” He looked up. Again, he heard the voice. It was louder, more urgent. It sounded like Lacey’s voice! “Gus... can you hear me? Gus, wake up!” Gus blinked as he looked for the source of the voice, searching for Lacey. Slowly, the sunlight dimmed. He blinked again, and saw the familiar floorboards of the trusty cabin overhead.

“Oh, Gus! You’re awake!” He turned his head to see Lacey bending over him, a relieved expression on her face. It slowly dawned on him that he had been dreaming. He wasn’t in a meadow, he was in the Land Under the Cabin. Lacey was right in front of him, leaning down with a look of concern that was easing into relief as he started to stir. He shook his head to clear the cobwebs and looked around. He saw that Lacey wasn’t alone. Behind her, there was Aluna the Garden Spider, crouching low. Aluna’s warm smile gave Gus a sense of comfort as he was gently helped up by his companions.

“It’s a pleasure to make your acquaintance, Mr. Gustavius Butterfly.” Aluna said with a bow. “We were wondering when you would emerge from your chamber and join us. Well, it was certainly worth the wait, don’t you agree Lacey?” she added.

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Lacey chuckled as she responded. "I'll say! I don't think time could move any slower than while you were in that chrysalis, Gussy!" Turning to Aluna, her eyes narrowed. "But I have a bone to pick with you, Ms. Aluna Spider... You could have given me a little more information to help prepare me for what was happening to Gus all this time. It nearly gave me a heart attack!" While her words seemed accusatory, the inflection of her voice and the big smile on her face showed that she wasn't really upset.

"Forgive me, Lacey dear. I thought you would enjoy getting to know this new version of Gus without any preconceived notion of what to expect." Addressing both of the young insects, she continued. "Gus just experienced 'metamorphosis'. In fact, many insects undergo this startling transformation during their lives. Dragonflies also go through a similar change called 'hemimetabolism'. That happened when you were young, Lacey. Even if you could remember your past, you probably wouldn't remember the time of your life when you yourself didn't have wings." Aluna fangs clicked, signaling that the entomology lesson had ended.

"I can't believe it!" Gus said, more to himself than to the others. Sure enough, as he turned his head and stretched, he could see the curved, delicate bends of wings... his wings! Using muscles new and powerful, he beat the air. Slowly at first, but faster as he felt an instinctive urge to bend and flex them in a pattern that somehow felt natural and right. With a gasp, he felt his feet lift off the ground and he floated magically in the air above the moss and dirt.

"Woo hoo!" he shouted triumphantly as he moved left and right with ease a few inches above the earth. The floor of the cabin

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didn't allow him to go very high, but he was doing it- Gus was flying! His equilibrium was a little off from the fainting spell, and he staggered slightly when he alighted again on the root, falling off and completing his inaugural flight with a little less grace than he had intended.

Lacey's claps of joy were interrupted as she lunged to his side to steady him. "Whoa, take it easy, Gus!" she admonished. Aluna supported him from the other side and added, "Well done, Gus. You're a natural-born aviator!" Gus couldn't stop smiling. He couldn't believe what had happened to him. He was so happy that he didn't know what he wanted to do next, until a rumble inside him made that obvious.

"What's for breakfast?" he asked with an embarrassed grin as his tummy rumbled again. "I'm starving!" The trio made their way toward the flowers, Lacey laughing and talking excitedly about the morning's events. The rain and wind outside had stopped, but the sky was still dark. At least the floor wasn't dripping, which made the way easier to navigate. Although the pathway to Flower Garden was shrouded in shadow, Gus hardly noticed. His new super vision made it easy for him to make his way, even in the dim light.

Gus felt a pang of sympathy for Lacey and her damaged wing, and resisted the urge to fly again as they made their way past familiar landmarks and quickly neared the flowers. With Aluna trailing them like a dutiful chaperone, the group traveled toward Flower Garden much more quickly than they had in the past.

To Gus, this world that had been his home for so long suddenly felt much smaller. He had seen the flowers in the distance sooner than ever before. His stride was long, purposeful, and

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quick. He noticed the colors. Colors in everything around them. He kept looking at Lacey...the deep hues of color that reflected in his new eyes. When he was a caterpillar, she had to walk very slowly to allow him to keep up. Now they walked together at a pace that even Aluna found challenging. Or was she falling purposely behind, to allow Lacey and Gus some time to themselves?

Gus couldn't stop smiling. He had thought of life as good when he was a caterpillar, but just a few hours of life as a butterfly had opened a whole new world of senses and possibilities. His mind was filled with so many thoughts, he was quite overwhelmed with it all. So many new emotions and sensory inputs to consider. He was glad to have Lacey to share in the experience. "Gosh, Lacey. Can you believe this? I am so full of energy and... well, life!" Lacey smiled and nodded her agreement as Gus's stomach rumbled again. "Just that little test flight... what a feeling!" His smile faded as he looked at her torn wing. "Gosh, Lace... I really wish we could fly together."

Lacey stopped for a moment and looked him in the eye. "Now, Gus. I don't want you to feel sad for *me*. I am so happy for *you*. Let's not spoil this wonderful day with thoughts of how we wish things could be. I want to enjoy today for what it has brought me... brought to both of us! At least I remember how it feels to fly... and I'm grateful for that. You looked so magnificent hovering in the air! Flying is the best feeling in the world, isn't it?"

Gus nodded and smiled in agreement, then his eyes opened wide as he remembered his last discussion with Jeremiah. "Wait a minute... Yes!" Apparently, something had occurred to Gus as he smiled euphorically at his friend with wide eyes. Lacey looked

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back at him curiously. What could possibly be more exciting than what had already happened today? Aluna approached the pair. Breakfast for Lacey and herself dangled from her mouth, suspended from fine silk threads.

Gus looked at his two friends, hardly able to contain his enthusiasm. “I have some wonderful news!” Another rumble interrupted him, and he realized his friends must be hungry, too. “First, we should eat! What I have to tell you is something that is worth a few more minutes.” Gus was all smiles. And he learned he had acquired another new talent. He could whistle! He walked into Flower Garden, whistling a happy tune. Lacey and Aluna shared a look with raised eyebrows and shrugs, then smiled at each other as the happy butterfly meandered through the flowers as if seeing them for the first time.

Gus surveyed the familiar feeding place. He noticed something was different about the way he saw the flowers. He looked at the leaves that used to be his favorite food, but they didn’t call his attention as they used to. Instead, his gaze was drawn to specific flowers that shone as if they were lit up from inside! He approached a bunch that belonged to a bush on the other side of the cabin’s foundation. Some of the bush’s branches had found their way through a gap in the foundation. These flowers had never called his attention before, but they sure did today! The blossoms glimmered like a beacon to his new eyes, and their curious scent drew him closer. Smells were new to him too, and he felt intoxicated by their fragrant aroma.

“Ah, how appropriate for the moment!” commented Aluna, who had dropped her cargo and offered Lacey breakfast balanced on the end of one of her spindly legs. “Those purple flowers grow on a plant known as a Butterfly Bush.” As they observed Gus,

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Lacey's mouth fell open. Gus's mouth had opened as well, and a spirally, straw-like tube unfurled from within and dipped into the center of one of the colorful flowers. "And that built-in butterfly straw is called a proboscis." Aluna informed the astonished dragonfly. "Gus won't be eating leaves any more. Butterflies drink nectar from certain flowers. Nectar is a sweet liquid, full of nutrients that will give Gus the strength and endurance he will need to fuel those new wings of his."

Lacey looked at Aluna with awe. "Gosh Aluna... How do you know so much?" The spider smiled her ever-mysterious smile. "A spider of my age has learned a few things about the world. I have studied many creatures over the years. Different insects have rather unique feeding habits. One can learn a lot from simply observing. They watched Gus for a few minutes. He looked quite absorbed in his newfound eating, or rather sipping ability, moving from flower to flower hungrily.

Aluna realized that she and Lacey still hadn't eaten. "Come now, let us enjoy our own breakfast, so we will be ready to hear Gus's story when— or perhaps if—" Aluna inclined her head in Gus's direction, "*he* ever gets full." Lacey giggled at Aluna's comment as she turned her attention to her own meal.

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Chapter 10 - A Lovely Plan is Hatched

At length, Gus finally did get his fill of nectar and returned contentedly to his friends, who had finished eating as well. “Oh boy,” Gus sighed with a burp, “Excuse me! I never imagined anything could taste so good! I found out something new...” he informed them. “I can taste things with my tarsi... I wasn’t expecting that!” Butterflies have organs that act as their taste buds at the end of their forelegs, quite different from the maxillae that caterpillars have in their mouth for the same purpose.” his friends snickered to each other as his face took on a quizzical look, as if he was wondering how he could possibly know all that.

Gus looked at the empty silk sacs that remained from his friends’ breakfast. He was even more grateful for being a butterfly, telling himself that flies and mosquitoes couldn’t possibly compare to the delicious liquid elixir that he had discovered!

Lacey and Aluna looked at Gus expectantly. Apparently, they hadn’t forgotten about his cryptic comments before breakfast. For once, the thought of food no longer seemed that important to the usually ravenous Gus. “Oh. right! Where to start...” Gus pondered. “Well, you remember when Jeremiah told me that dragonflies don’t usually eat what caterpillars eat, don’t you Lacey?”

Lacey giggled and replied, “Well, of course! How could I forget? We met our dear Aluna the next very day!” Regarding the regal spider, Lacey imagined for a moment what it would have been like to endure Gus’s transformation alone. She smiled at the kind and wise Aluna, hoping that her friend knew how much her

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companionship, not to mention all of the other thoughtful favors that Aluna had granted, meant to Lacey. She recalled what Aluna had told her about friendship. And she considered the tremendous impact that a loyal and selfless friend can have. It made her appreciate the few friends she had all the more.

“That’s right!” Gus agreed. “That sure was a great day. It was also the day I began changing! Well, when Jeremiah was telling me about the foods you prefer, he also told me something else. Back then, I wasn’t quite sure how to talk to you about it.”

Lacey nodded. “I remember when we talked about that. I felt a little odd about it, but I told myself that you would tell me when the time was right.”

Gus looked a little ashamed. “Yeah, I did feel awkward about not talking to you about it then. I hope you’ll understand why, once you hear what I am about to tell you. We didn’t want to tell you something that was exciting, but also disappointing. Hopeful, but at the same time despairing. But now, all that has changed! Now we have a way and I can’t believe that my metromorphalis has provided the key!”

An uncharacteristic snort escaped Aluna. “My dear boy... the term is met-a-morph-o-sis,” she corrected the rambling butterfly. “And I’m afraid that I don’t have the slightest idea as to what you are talking about. Perhaps if you slow down a bit and explain things with more detail, Lacey and I can follow along and understand what on earth you’re saying.”

Gus looked at Aluna with a look of surprise. Apparently he had thought he had been making perfect sense. When he glanced at Lacey, she confirmed Aluna’s comments with a shake of her

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head. “You are kind of all over the place, Gussy. I’m sorry, we really *want* to understand...”

Gus laughed apologetically. “Sorry. Let me start over.” He took a few deep breaths and thought about how to begin again. He told his friends about how Jeremiah had found Randall the Wise, and the badger’s fable of ladybugs who could somehow heal torn insect wings. About how they lived on the other side of the river, impossible to reach unless you could somehow get to them. “Do you see why we didn’t know how to tell you about something that might give hope for a future of flying, without being able to verify the existence of these ladybugs? I was going to tell you after I had a chance to think of a plan...”

Aluna cleared her throat. “How very interesting. I have never heard of this, but it does intrigue me. By the way, did either of you know that humans call different groups of animals and insects by unique names? For example, they refer to a group of your kind as a ‘flight’ of dragonflies,” she explained, her last comment directed to Lacey.

“And a group of butterflies is called a ‘kaleidoscope’, although I must admit that I don’t know what that means.” she continued. “Well, they refer to a group of ladybugs as a ‘loveliness’. Isn’t that something? Thinking of that always makes me smile.”

Gus and Lacey agreed that the term was quite... lovely. “Gee, Aluna... you know an awful lot about so many things!” Gus commented, clearly in awe of the spider’s wealth of knowledge. Then he continued sharing what had occurred to him after realizing that now, he could fly.

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“Before I fell asleep, I was thinking that maybe I could search the Land Beyond the Cabin to find someone who could help us. Not the birds, of course. But maybe some other flying insects.” Gus paused to catch his breath. His excitement was causing words to come out faster than his brain could think. His eyes gleamed. “But now, there’s an even better solution! I can fly, Lacey! I can go and find those ladybugs! Isn’t it wonderful?”

Lacey had been listening to Gus’s story with rapt attention, but at this last revelation, her eyes grew wide as she thought of the dangers that lurked beyond the confines of their home. “You would do that for me? The Land Beyond the Cabin is a perilous place! Look what happened to me... and Jeremiah almost became an owl’s dinner! I don’t know that I like this plan of yours.”

Gus looked toward the drops of water clinging to the slats of the rotted floor above them and thought about how he had never had the courage to see what lay in that great land. He felt a twinge of shame when he thought of how he had let his fear hold him back for his whole life. But he felt very differently now. He realized that his fear and apprehension had been replaced with optimism and an overwhelming desire to help Lacey.

He turned back toward her, a look of determination on his face. “I need to try and find those ladybugs, Lacey. I’ve stayed here under this cabin my whole life. Is it safe here? Maybe...” He gestured with his antennae toward the world beyond. “But out there... is a land of possibility! And maybe a solution to our dilemma.” He placed his tarsi on Lacey’s shoulders and looked into her eyes. “We *are* meant to fly, you and I. I can see now that we are both destined to live out there... and I want to explore the Land Beyond the Cabin with my best friend.”

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Lacey smiled with adoration and embraced him. “Oh, Gus. You are a true friend. I love you.”

Gus certainly wasn’t expecting that! He squirmed awkwardly, not sure what to say or do.

Aluna came to his rescue. “That is certainly admirable, Gus, my dear boy. Quite admirable. I must confess that I myself have never heard of any such creature that can mend wings, but if these magical ladybugs do in fact exist, I agree that they should be sought out. First rate!”

Lacey finally released Gus from the hug and stood gazing at him. Not used to being the center of attention, Gus tried to think of something impressive to say. “Well, gee... It’s not that big a deal as all that,” he managed flatly. “I know that you’d do the same for me, Lacey. That’s... I mean, that’s what best friends do for each other.”

Aluna broke the mood by announcing that she had to get back to her web. “I look forward to seeing you both on the morrow,” she said in parting. “I hope that we can discuss your daring plan then. For now, I bid you adieu.” At Gus’s blank expression, she explained, “That means goodbye for now.”

Gus nodded. “Ado to you too!” he said sagely. “Thank you for everything, Aluna.” He and Lacey wished Aluna well and watched her recede into the distance.

Gus walked over to the bricks that served as a barrier to the world outside. Try as he might, he couldn’t see much through the cracks in the cabin’s foundation. “I have an idea... do you want

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to go outside and take a look around?” suggested Gus. “Maybe we can see the river from here!”

“We could go out there and see what it’s like,” agreed Lacey. “To be honest, I can’t think of anything I’d rather do right now than go on an adventure with you!” she said with eyes shining.

A smile broadened across Gus’s face. “Great!” He looked around for a way to get outside, but the cracks in the foundation were not large enough for them to pass through. “There’s a door in the Treasure Trove, but I don’t think we could get it open. It looks pretty heavy. I wonder if Aluna knows of a place where we could get out more easily.”

Lacey thought for a moment, then she brightened as she remembered the hobby that she had learned during the time Gus was in the chrysalis. “I want to show you something... it’s back in Fern Forest!” Happily, the two made off toward the area that they considered their home. On the way, they chatted contentedly about the marvels of life. Neither imagined this eventuality, that they now had a whole new future to work toward. The days to come promised new adventures and the possibility of flying together through flower-filled meadows.

When they reached the area marked by an empty chrysalis husk hanging from a rusty nail, Lacey invited Gus to close his eyes and wait until she told him she was ready. Gus obliged her wishes, wondering what surprise Lacey had in store for him. In a few moments, he heard Lacey’s voice. “Ok, Gus. You can open your eyes now!”

Gus opened his eyes and looked in wonder at the curious bundle Lacey held in her forelegs. Coils of finely braided spider silk hung

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down, almost touching the ground. “I learned how to braid this while I was waiting for you to awaken.” she explained. These cords are quite strong. I was thinking that if you flew up through the hole above the boot and fastened one end to something in the cabin, I could climb up and we could walk right out the doorway!” What do you think?”

Gus took the bundle of silken cord from her. As he hefted the coils, he was amazed that they weighed next to nothing. He wrapped a length around a root and pulled, testing its strength. Try as he might, Gus could not break the braided silk. He noted that it had a slightly springy quality as he pulled and tugged at the silver cable. “Wow, Lacey... that’s impressive! How did it occur to you to learn how to do that?”

Lacey smiled at Gus’s approbation. “I’m not sure... I guess a lot of things can occur to someone who’s awaiting the return of a loved one.” She blinked her eyes coyly, and Gus felt a fluttering inside him.

“Do you think my plan might work, Gussy?” she asked. “I don’t see why not!” Gus returned, a broad smile on his face. “Let’s go try it out!” The pair stopped at the dripping basin to refresh themselves before returning to Flower Garden.

Once they had arrived back at the old leather boot, the allure of nectar was too much for Gus. “Do you mind if I have a quick sip before we try?” Lacey couldn’t help but giggle at her hungry companion. “Of course, Gus. You may need an energy boost out in the Land Beyond the Cabin.” She couldn’t know then how true that comment would be. As Gus sipped more pollen, Lacey danced and twirled among the pretty flowers.

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Finally, Gus was ready. Holding one end of the longest coil of silken rope, he fluttered his mighty wings and rose up through the hole in the cabin's floor with ease. "Hold on while I tie this end to something!" he called down to Lacey, waiting with the other end of the rope in her grasp. Gus found a nail protruding from one of the floorboards near the hole. He created a loop with a knot and dropped it over the head of the nail. "Ok, try tugging on it, let's see if it will hold your weight!" He shouted down from above.

Lacey let the slack out of the rope and pulled on it. The braided silk stretched a bit, but as she continued to pull, it drew taut and held fast to the nail anchor. Using her multiple feet, she quickly scaled the makeshift ladder and soon Gus saw her antennae and head peek out of the hole. He bent down to help Lacey climb up. "Well, that worked like a charm, Lace!" Gus complimented her as they both looked over the edge at the boot and flowers below. "It looks different from up here, don't you think?" he commented.

"It does. Looking down at the place we've spent so much time together lets me see it in a whole new way." Lacey agreed.

"Well, are you ready to go?" Gus asked, a glint of adventure in his eye. Lacey nodded excitedly in response. Gus led the way, pausing a moment and turning to face her as they reached the doorway. "It looks like today is the day!" he quipped. "I bet we're going to find that there's a lot to do in the Land Beyond the Cabin, anyway!"

Lacey giggled and admired how much her friend had changed in such a short time. "I'm glad we're doing this together, Gus. We're on an adventure- It's so much fun!" Lacey gushed, her

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heart full of emotion. “Me too,” replied Gus. His wings quivered with anticipation. “Ready?”

Lacey nodded vigorously, her eyes glimmering. “Let’s do it!” Tarsus in tarsus, the friends stepped through the open door and onto the cabin porch.

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Chapter 11 - A Spark of Memory

Both friends took a deep breath of crisp air at the same moment, relishing the fresh, pure scents that follow a heavy rainstorm. Drops of water clung to the blades of grass and trees surrounding the cabin. Gus's immediate impression of the Land Beyond the Cabin was just how endless it was. No walls or ceiling to limit his view. As he gazed off toward the horizon, he was overcome with a sense of what a small part of the land he occupied. But instead of feeling intimidated by the vastness of the world, he had a sense of unlimited opportunity and potential. "Gosh, Lacey... There seems to be no end to it... There's so much room!" he whispered to his companion.

"It's quite something, isn't it?" Lacey concurred as she stood beside him, leaning over to rest her head on his shoulder. The pair spent a few minutes in quiet contemplation and awe at the scene. They could see the sky above them, as the roof that once protected the porch was mostly gone. The corner posts still stood, supporting some remnants that remained attached to the cabin on either side of the open doorway.

There were three steps leading from the porch to the ground. A graveled area, peppered with weeds and patches of grass spread out in front of the porch. Two well-worn tire paths lead away from the gravel and connected to a wider dirt road that ran along the front of the property on the other side of a weathered wooden fence. Overgrown green grass dominated the rest of the yard, a sturdy oak spreading its leafy branches over a large portion of the lawn. A swing that hung from chains fastened to a large branch and an abandoned tricycle rusting near the trunk of

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the tree provided evidence of a time when insects and arachnids shared the cabin with humans.

Gus stood on the porch next to his best friend. His heart was full of gratitude, and his mind full of wonder. He wondered how he could be so fortunate to have gotten wings along with a strong and swift body. He wondered what this moment would be like if Lacey hadn't dropped into his life. And he wondered what could possibly happen next.

It was just then that Mother Nature decided to answer Gus's last wonderment. He noticed the light increasing all around them- the storm clouds high above started to move as currents of unseen air began to push them away. All at once, a shaft of light broke through the dark clouds, bathing the friends in sudden bright illumination. Naturally, Gus turned to Lacey to comment on the warmth of the sun. But he forgot everything he was thinking about as soon as he saw her. His eyes grew wide and his mouth opened as he gazed at her, transfixed. In a way, it was as if he were seeing her for the first time. Ever since waking up and seeing the world with enhanced sight, the day had been drab and dim under a canopy of dark clouds. The abrupt transformation to bright sunlight brought an even higher level of detail to what Gus was seeing.

Gus didn't know the names of colors. But if he could, he would describe what he was seeing as purple. A deep, royal, jewel-like purple. As Lacey moved in the bright sunlight, he saw deep shades of red and brilliant sparks of silver as the sun reflected off the sleek curves of her body. Her delicate wings absorbed the sun's rays, glowing as if they were lit up by some internal energy. After a few moments, his gaze started to make Lacey feel self-conscious.

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“Gus, why are you staring at me like that?” she asked with a coy smile that showed she had an idea of what he was thinking, and what he was feeling inside.

“Gosh, Lacey- seeing you in the sunlight! With my poor eyesight combined with the dim light of the Land Under the Cabin, I had no idea just how captivating you are. Absolutely breathtaking!”

Lacey’s cheeks took on an even deeper reddish hue. “Well, thank you, but really...” She looked at him with a curious grin. “You’re quite spectacular yourself, Mr. Butterfly. I always thought you were quite adorable as a plump and friendly caterpillar, but I must say that this version of you is simply stunning. Can you turn around for me?”

Now Gus knew what it felt like to have someone looking at *him* with admiration. He hadn’t experienced that as a pudgy caterpillar, but didn’t she say that she thought he was adorable when he was a caterpillar? He was glad that he had a friend who liked him just the way he was, even when he hadn’t thought of himself as anything special. She liked him for who he was, not for his appearance. That made him happy, because he felt the same way about her. He wasn’t the sort to act differently just because he looked different, but he was grateful that Lacey seemed to share the attitude that the real beauty of someone comes from within.

“Gus?” Lacey’s voice snapped Gus from his thoughts. She made little circles in the air with her tarsus.

“Huh? Oh, yeah...” He dutifully turned around slowly, feeling self-conscious again.

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“Wait...Stop!” There was a note in Lacey’s voice that startled Gus, and he froze, facing away from her with his wings outstretched.

“What’s wrong?” he asked nervously.

Lacey didn’t respond immediately. He was almost ready to turn around, but then, “I think I’m remembering something. Don’t move.” she instructed. He could hear her walking back and forth. And he could feel her eyes on him. “It just occurred to me...” Lacey started, “those wings of yours remind me... of a lily pad.”

“A lily pad?” Gus wondered. He certainly hadn’t expected *that*. “What’s that?”

Lacey giggled. “A lily pad is a plant that grows along the edge of a lake. They are green and round, and they float on the water, grouped together. The way the lines on your wings and the edges curve... they remind me of the lily pads near my home.”

Gus didn’t know what to say. He tried, “Thank you?” It was more of a question than a statement.

“Don’t you see, Gus?” Now Gus had to turn and look at her, because he didn’t see, and he really wanted to. She had fresh tears in her eyes. “Your wings *remind me* of a lily pad! Seeing your broad, green wings extended like that stirred a memory of lily pads, and my home. I... I remembered something!” A tear fell from her eye as she let out a little laugh. “I could see it in my mind! The lily pads, the reeds waving along the river’s edge, even the big tree whose branches hung over the water... oh, Gus!”

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Gus ran to her, brimming with excitement. “Wow, Lacey. Gosh! Tell me more... What’s your name? How did you get hurt?”

Hard as she tried, she still couldn’t remember her name, but she did recall bits and pieces of her friends and family, and the marshy pond that she used to call home. She could describe the tadpoles, fish and waterfowl that shared the marsh with the dragonfly swarm, but the images were hazy and disappeared as she fought to hold onto them.

“Don’t worry about it, Lacey. Don’t try to force it. I think it’s a great sign. You’ll remember more, you’ll see.” He smiled reassuringly.

Lacey’s smile returned. “You’re right. It is a good sign. I can’t wait to tell Aluna about it!”

Gus embraced her warmly. “She will be so glad to hear it, I’m sure!” Hoping to distract her from the frustration of not remembering more, he nudged her gently. “Well, we wanted to see if the river is visible from here, but...” He searched the horizon in vain. The trees that lined the road in front of the house prevented him from seeing anything beyond. “I can’t see anything, can you?” Lacey shook her head. “If we could just get higher... maybe from the roof of the cabin...” Gus suggested, looking for the best route toward one of the corner posts. “We could climb up there and...”

Lacey giggled, “Aren’t you forgetting something?” When Gus looked blankly back, Lacey fluttered her own wings. “You can fly, Gus!”

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Gus grinned sheepishly. "Oh yeah. I did forget for a minute there. I guess part of my brain still thinks like a caterpillar."

"I'm the one with amnesia, Gus!" Lacey joked. Gus could tell that she was feeling better, and that made him happy. The friends shared a bit of laughter in the bright afternoon sun.

"Well now... I do have wings! I guess I should learn how to use them, right?" Gus stated, stretching them out and bending them backward and forward to limber up.

Lacey nodded in agreement. "Just take it easy, hot shot. Don't be dangerous!" Lacey warned, a crease of concern on her brow. "Get a feel for it before you go too high. I wish I could remember more of the details of flying, so I could give you some tips." Not wanting doubt to trouble her friend, she added, "You'll do great, Gus. I'll be watching you and I'll wait right here. Don't go too far, ok?"

Gus smiled gently in return. "I'm just going to go up for a look around, hopefully I can see the river from up there. I don't want to leave you alone out for too long." He started flapping his wings slowly, then gaining speed. It was amazing to him how effortless it was to get off the ground. "Well, my wings are pretty huge," he thought to himself as he rose higher. He could now see through the empty hole in the cabin wall that used to frame a window. Moments ago, it looked so high to him. He looked down at Lacey. She seemed anxious, her forelegs rubbing together.

"How do you feel, Gus? Got the hang of it?" Lacey had no need to worry. Gus took to flying as if he had done it his whole life. He flitted and darted in every direction, turning and reversing with ease, just a little adjustment in the angle of those massive wings

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was all it took. He brought them forward in a scooping motion, the shape of the arcs making a sort of figure-eight pattern in the air. His movement was much like a swimmer's, with an endless expanse of freedom to go wherever he pleased. He floated on the breeze, tilting downward in lazy circles toward Lacey.

"It's incredible, Lacey! I can imagine what it will be like to fly together. I'm going to go up to the roof, but I'll be right back. Just wait right there, Ok?"

Lacey shielded her eyes with a wing. "You look like you know what you're doing, all right. I am so happy for you, Gus. I'll be right here waiting. Keep an eye out for birds!"

The mention of birds made Gus think of Jeremiah's close call and he spun around, scanning the sky. "Right! You better believe I'll keep my eyes open. See you in a few minutes!" Gus glanced back at his friend as he fanned the air. He felt his determination grow. "I'll find those ladybugs, Lacey," he whispered quietly. "I'm gonna find them if it's the last thing I do!" He looked back at her. She looked so small standing on the porch alone. He wished that she could be with him in the air. "No time for that right now, Gus!" he told himself, shaking his head to clear his mind. "Stay focused on the task at hand!" And he directed his eyes back toward the sky, alert for signs of danger.

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Chapter 12 - A Narrow Escape

In a matter of moments Gus was perched on the roof of the cabin. The sun warmed him as he looked around in awe. The Land Beyond the Cabin was vast! He saw ribbons of dusty trail where the tires of cars and trucks had made their way through the forest. He could see all of the picket fence surrounding the property. From his vantage point, he could make out the tops of the greenhouse and the shed located behind the cabin.

“That shed must be where Jeremiah lives!” he thought to himself, “Why, I could be there in just a few minutes!” Then he remembered why he was on the roof in the first place. “The river!” Looking out past the rooftops, he could see glimpses of a dark blue band between tree limbs. “I need to get a better look,” he thought. “That must be it, but I’ve got to be sure.” Testing the strength of the breeze with his antennae, he spread his wings and took flight once again.

Higher he flew, looking down for a moment to spot Lacey. There she was - at least he thought that was her - a tiny speck of glittering purple. “Just a little higher...” There it was! A great, lazy river, winding its way through verdant fields, curving off into the distance. “I can fly across that,” he told himself, though it looked to be a very broad river indeed. “I’ll just have to, Lacey is counting...” His thought was interrupted by the most terrifying sound he’d ever heard in his life!

“Screee!!” Gus’s keen eyes traced the sky above and he quickly detected movement overhead. “Screee!” a large black bird circled toward him, flapping its great wings. Suddenly it pitched forward, diving directly toward him!

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Time slowed as Gus felt a natural instinct awaken within him. This instinct informed him that this would be a very good time to flee, and so he did. Falling as fast as gravity would allow while using his wings to churn the air, he looked around for options.

He decided to make for the cabin's dilapidated roof, hoping to find shelter from the hunter. Looking back, he saw the bird was gaining on him, the space between them growing smaller by the second. In his heightened state, it seemed to Gus as if the bird were moving in slow motion. Detailed images were sent through his new eyes to his clever mind so quickly, he did kind of feel like a superhero.

Turning back toward the cabin, he made for the section of roof that had caved in, a large hole brimming with possibilities. "Screeee!!" The sound let Gus know that the bird was almost upon him. He could envision the curved, yellow beak opening wide. Just another few feet...

All at once, a strong urge prompted him to veer to the left, instead of entering the hole just ahead of him. He angled his broad wings, letting them catch the wind. The move stopped his downward momentum, and he skimmed just inches over the rooftop, narrowly avoiding the brick chimney jutting up like a great castle tower. The move caught the pursuing bird by surprise. There was no time to alter course; it did not have the ability to stop and turn as Gus had done. It made a valiant attempt, but dropped through the hole at an awkward angle. Gus could hear crashing and thrashing as the bird hit something inside, perhaps a picture or maybe a pitcher? There were sounds of breaking glass, then silence.

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Gus didn't wait around to investigate. He flitted to the end of the roof and got his bearings. He knew by the location of the greenhouse and shed that he was on the opposite side of the cabin from Lacey. He headed back across the rooftop and dove toward the porch as fast as he could flutter. He saw her standing near the door, a purple figure that stood out brightly from the brown planks of flooring. "Inside, Lacey! Get inside quickly!" Gus shouted as soon as he was within earshot.

"What happened?" Lacey shouted back, frantic from the clamor she had heard inside the cabin moments before. "I'll explain when we get back under the cabin.." Gus answered, stumbling a bit as he hit the porch near her. "Hurry!" he added breathlessly. Gus ushered her through the door, scanning the sky behind them as they ran. They jumped into the hole and floated down onto the boot, and into the relative safety of the Land Under the Cabin.

It took a minute for Gus to slow his breathing as Lacey examined him for injuries. "I'm ok," Gus panted. "Just give me a minute." After collecting himself, he suggested that they hide inside the boot, in case the bird recovered from the fall and decided to start looking for them.

They jumped to the ground and Lacey darted inside. It wasn't so easy for Gus, who realized the boot hadn't been designed for an insect his size. He had to fold his wings down against his body just to get inside. If the moment wasn't so tense, it would have been comical. He found a little more room inside as he made his way toward the sole, where he found Lacey waiting for him. She scooted toward the toe to give him more space.

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As they huddled together inside the boot, Gus recounted his time on the roof in hushed tones. He told her of the landmarks he had seen while he was standing on the roof, and the view he saw of the river after he decided to fly higher. When he got to the part where the bird had spied him, he tried to downplay his narrow escape for Lacey's benefit. Nevertheless, he could tell by the worried look on her face that the violent noises of the crash had frightened her badly. "It's ok, Lacey," Gus said softly in an attempt to reassure her. "The good thing is that I saw the river. I know the way now! And, Jeremiah's shed is on the way. Maybe I can stop by and update him about my..." Gus wrinkled his brow in concentration. "My met-a-phor-falis!" he looked hopefully at his friend.

Lacey smiled encouragingly at Gus. "Close! But I think it's met-a-morph-o-sis." she suggested helpfully.

Gus sighed. "I don't know why it has to be such a long word! But I've got it now." he said confidently.

"Shh!" he warned suddenly, placing a tarsus on Lacey's shoulder. He listened and felt with all his senses as a sound alerted him. Was it the bird coming to find them?

After a few tense moments, Gus relaxed. "It's ok, Lace. I've heard that sound before. I think it's a branch hitting the side of the cabin. There must be a breeze outside.

Lacey's look of concern remained. "Gus, I don't like this. We went outside for a few minutes, and look what happened! I don't think you should go." she whispered, looking imploringly at Gus in the dim bootlight.

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Gus touched her face tenderly and spoke with a gentle smile, “Lacey, I know how you feel. But please try to understand my feelings. I feel like this is something I have to do. Something I have to try, at least. You and I aren’t meant to live the rest of our lives under this cabin. I know there’s danger out there, but you were meant to fly. We both were meant to fly! I can’t live like this, knowing there’s a chance to repair your wing. It would mean that we could fly together... the start of a new life for us! You understand that, don’t you? I have to try.”

Lacey sighed. She thought of her damaged wing and their life in the Land Under the Cabin. She allowed herself to imagine flying, Gus at her side. To feel that freedom again, and the possibility of adventuring together with him in the great outdoors. Finally, she turned to Gus and nodded, whispering, “I suppose you’re right. But if anything happens to you...”

Gus held up a foreleg. “C’mon, Lacey. We have to think positive! I need to know you have confidence in me. *I* know I can do it if *you* know I can do it. You know?” His antennae waggled in little circles, making Lacey laugh.

“Oh, Gus, I do know you’ll do it. The life you describe, I want it too. I can see what it can be... in my imagination, anyway.” Lacey responded with hope in her voice.

Gus beamed. “That’s the spirit!” Listening for a minute, he added, “I think it might be safe to get out of here. I haven’t heard anything but that knocking, nothing that sounds like a bird. What do you think?” Gus asked, his voice a little louder, but still not quite at its normal volume.

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Lacey agreed, and the duo cautiously left the confines of their emergency shelter. “What would we do without this old boot?” Gus commented, admiring it and thinking about the first time he had seen Lacey perched... right up there. Lacey smiled and rested her head on Gus’s shoulder, lost in a moment of quiet contemplation.

The moment did not last long. Looking at the butterfly bush, Gus broke the silence. “Do you mind if I indulge in a little snack? That adventure gave me quite a thirst!”

Lacey escorted him over to the plant. “Of course, mister- you deserve a treat after your first real flight! You really did a fine job out there.” Lacey complimented the butterfly as he dipped his proboscis and drank deeply as Lacey hummed a pleasant tune. The humming ended, and Gus continued to sip contentedly. He felt he was really getting a handle on what being a butterfly was all about! Lacey worked on a new dance while she waited.

Suddenly, Lacey stopped and said, “I think I have an idea of something we can do, once you’ve gotten your fill.”

Curious, Gus decided that he had in fact gotten his fill, rolling his proboscis up neatly. “I love surprises!” he said with enthusiasm. “What is it?”

Lacey led the way, beckoning to Gus to follow her. “Come with me to find out!” Lacey led Gus toward Treasure Trove as their conversation turned from discussions about the future and dangerous adventures to simpler things. It was as if the two friends had realized that so much had happened in such a short period of time that neither had much desire or energy to talk of

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grand plans, hopes, and dreams. Instead, they spoke of their time together, the good times they had enjoyed getting to know one another, and new things that they had learned about themselves. Even this last adventure, Lacey had to admit, was exhilarating and had ended well.

“Lacey, you’ve been a real blessing to me,” Gus said with emotion. “Before your arrival, my life was quite mundane. Compared to life with you, it was downright boring.” he admitted with a rueful smile. “The thing is, I didn’t know what I was missing until you came along and showed me what friendship and companionship feel like. Now, I can’t imagine a life without you.” Gus fell silent as they walked quietly past Weed Jungle and saw the colorful Treasure Trove in the distance.

“Well, Gussy... I think you know how I feel about you, too. I can tell you as someone who was lost, frightened, and hurt how it feels to have a true friend show up, as if by magic, and take care of you. But it’s more than that, Gus. Yours is a good heart, and you have taught me how to be a better dragonfly through your example.” She stopped and looked at him. “It makes me think of the song I made up for you and sang as you were slumbering in your chrysalis, turning yourself into, well, *this...*” she ran her tarsus along the curve of his wing. Gus smiled awkwardly. Lacey cleared her throat and sang again the song that she had sung to him all those days ago.

Gus had a tear in his eye as she finished her song. “That was beautiful, Lacey. Like I said when I woke up, I remember little pieces of the song and you talking to me as if it were a dream. But hearing it now, well gosh. It’s so beautiful.” Gus said. “You did such a good job taking care of me, making sure nothing

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happened while I was hanging there. Helpless.” Gus gave Lacey a warm embrace. “Thank you again for watching over me.”

Lacey returned the hug with happiness. “I had a great teacher.” she responded. “Hey Gus, do you ever get the feeling that we were meant to meet each other?” she asked with a quizzical look. “Like it was destiny?”

Gus thought for a minute, his antennae making little circles as if they were attached to the gears in his mind. “I never really thought about it before, but now that you mention it... it does seem that we have been able to help each other get through some challenges, haven’t we? I think you might be onto something, Lace.” Gus replied. “Destiny. Gosh...” his eyes took on a faraway look.

His contemplative look struck Lacey as funny and she pushed Gus playfully. “Come back to me, Gussy!” she joked. Nodding toward Treasure Trove, she said, “Look... we’re almost there!”

They soon approached the overturned box with the silver serving platter leaning against it. As they walked, Lacey let Gus in on what had occurred to her earlier. “I remembered the day we were looking at our reflections here, then it occurred to me. With this, you can actually see the new you!” She walked over to the platter and beckoned to her friend. “Gus, I’d like you to meet... Gustavius the Butterfly!”

Gus approached and gazed at the reflection. He saw his big new wings and slender body. He looked over at the image of the dragonfly standing next to him, his best friend in the whole world. Gus extended his wing, brushing it against hers lightly. He couldn’t think of any words that could express what he was

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feeling at that moment, so he just stood there and gazed at their reflection.

“I think we make a good pair, you and I,” Lacey said softly, moving a little closer.

Gus couldn’t have agreed more. He took in the scene and took a deep breath. “Coming here was a really good idea, Lacey. I’m going to keep this moment in my memory during my journey. If the sky gets stormy and the road is rocky, thinking of this time with you will help get me through it.”

Lacey turned away. “Oh, Gus... I really don’t want to talk about that right now.” she said with a tremor in her voice.

Gus went to her and wrapped his forelegs around her torso. “I know. I don’t either, but we need to plan. I think tomorrow is the day, Lace,” Gus declared. “Why wait? The sooner I go, the sooner I’ll be back. Tomorrow, I’ll be off to find that loveliness of ladybugs. I’ll bring them back here, and we’ll get you all fixed up!”

Lacey didn’t say anything. She placed her tarsus on top of his, gently caressing it. Gus could tell that they were feeling the same thing; excitement, nervousness, a little fear. But most of all, hope.

“Hey, don’t you think that this old box would make a nice place for us to sleep?” Gus asked in an attempt to lighten the mood. “The moss made a comfortable bed when I was a caterpillar, but I think this might make a nice house for you to stay in while you wait for me to come back.”

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Lacey nodded. "I think that's a wonderful idea, Gus. We can sleep here tonight. But while you're gone, I think I'll sleep inside the boot. I felt safe there today with you. It's a little small for you and your big wings, but it's just right for me." She turned and looked at Gus, inviting his opinion.

"Well then, the boot it is!" he agreed. After a pause, he added, "You know, I think we should go visit Aluna first thing tomorrow. I'd hate for her to go looking for us and getting worried. What do you think?" Lacey nodded her agreement. "I was just thinking the same thing!"

Gus eyed the pinwheel sticking out of the other box in the Trove. "I bet that now, I can make that thing spin like you did!" he ventured with a grin, and moved to face the toy. After a few flaps of his mighty wings, the pinwheel was spinning so fast that the stars blurred, turning into circles like they did when Lacey had made the toy spin. "That's much more fun than hitting it with my antennae!" Gus said with satisfaction.

Lacey beamed at her friend. "Very nice, Gus! Those new wings of yours are useful in a variety of ways! I bet you could use them to keep me cool on a hot day." she concluded with a wry smile. Gus smiled back. "It would be my pleasure!"

Inspired, Gus used his power of flight to get to the top of the open box. Balanced on the edge, he called down, "See if you can get a running start and use your wings, Lace. I'll help you up!" Gus suggested.

Lacey looked up with a doubtful expression. "It looks kinda high, Gus. But, I'll try..." she walked back several feet and started to run, flapping her wings as she jumped and reached for his

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waiting tarsus. She was able to touch it, but failed to grab hold and instead hit the box, falling back to the ground.

“Almost!” Gus exclaimed as the dragonfly collected herself. “It was my fault, Lacey. I should have held on,” he said with chagrin. “I guess that wasn’t a good idea after all. I’ll come back down and we can call it a day.”

Lacey surprised him with a defiant look and a defiant response. “No, you know what? Let’s try again. Practice makes perfect, right?” she said with a smile.

“You’re absolutely right, Lace! We’ll do better this time.” Gus promised and reached down with determination, flashing a look of encouragement toward his friend.

The memories of all the exercises Lacey had done while waiting for Gus to emerge from the chrysalis came to. “You can do this.” she told herself. “Now’s the time to show what you’re made of!” She started with a few stuttering steps toward the box, then lengthened her stride until she was running at full speed. Her inner voice told her that it was time to jump, so she pushed off with her strong legs and flapped her wings, hoping she would gain just a little more height...

This try was much more satisfying. Lacey jumped at just the right time and her wings provided just enough lift. She and Gus locked tarsi at the perfect time, and Gus hoisted the dainty Lacey up to survey the contents of the box. “Great job, Lace,” Gus gushed. “That was spectacular!” The two friends bumped tarsi, savoring the moment as they looked out at the Land Under the Cabin from this elevated vantage point.

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“You can see all the way to Fern Forest from up here!” Gus observed. “You’re right!” Lacey nodded. “You know Gus, this has been a really good day. I’m glad we could share it together.” The smile on Gus’s face told her that he felt the same way.

As it happened, the box held myriad treasures to entertain the two adventurers. They looked at each colorful toy with amazement. There was a xylophone, balls of various shapes and sizes, and stuffed animals that stirred their imagination. The two friends had a grand time trying to guess the purpose of each object and making up stories involving the animals they had found. On top of the pile, they discovered a strange cylindrical object that was wide at one end and narrow at the other. Lacey noticed a small hole in the narrow end and peered through it. “Wow, Gus... you have to see this!” she exclaimed excitedly.

“What’s in there?” Gus asked with fascination. Lacey made room for him and beckoned him to take a look. Gus bent down and put his eye close to the hole. He gasped in amazement. Through the hole, he saw a kaleidoscope of colors. The patterns and varying hues of different shapes and colors stunned him as he took them in. “Incredible...” he breathed after a few minutes of intense gazing. He backed up and let Lacey have another turn. “You know, Lace... I had no idea how much beauty there was all around me. Just when I start to get used to this, something new comes along and reminds me that I haven’t even started to experience all the world has to offer. It makes me feel very grateful.” His gaze took on his trademark faraway look.

Lacey came to sit beside him. “I love seeing the world through your eyes, Gus. I’ve come to realize how much I’ve taken for granted. Thank you for sharing this with me,” she said quietly. B

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Dragonfly and butterfly sat in silence for some time in thoughtful contemplation.

As the daylight started to fade, they hopped down from the box and made their way into the overturned box, their home for the night. They spent their final night together perched side by side on the handle of a cast iron frying pan.

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Chapter 13 - Departure

Early the next morning, Gus and Lacey awoke and set off for Musty Dusty Corner. There was tension in the air, both friends trying not to think about Gus's impending departure, but knowing full well that it was approaching. They made small talk, neither wanting nor willing to discuss the uncertain future. It was apparent that they both wished for time to slow, so they could enjoy each other's company for a little bit longer.

Too soon, they neared their destination as Aluna's web came into view. They saw her perched in the center, seemingly having anticipated their arrival. "Well, good morning, my young friends! Such a pleasant time for a stroll," the spider said in greeting as she moved to meet them, with bundles of breakfast for herself and Lacey in tow.

"Good morning, Aluna," Lacey returned with a forced smile. "It's so nice to see you."

"Yes, good morning Aluna," Gus added with a nod. He looked at Lacey to see if there was anything she wanted to say, but the dragonfly seemed content to avoid his eyes. It seemed it would be his job to bring Aluna up to speed. "Do we ever have a story to tell you!" Gus exclaimed, maybe with a little too much gusto.

Aluna listened with interest as Gus recounted the adventures of the previous day, only interrupting the story once. "My, my!" she interjected when Gus described the bird's awkward descent into the cabin. "I was wondering what all that ruckus was!" She clicked her fangs in her customary way and invited Gus to continue.

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Gus carried on with his animated recounting of the story. How they used the silk cord to get Lacey up into the cabin, his first real flight, and the bird attack. Here, Lacey became more involved in the story by adding her feelings when she heard the crashes, about their hushed discussion in the boot, and finished the tale by relating the trip to Treasure Trove. “We should go there some time, Aluna. There are lots of interesting things to look at!” she said as she finished speaking.

After allowing a few minutes to allow the spider to digest all she had heard, Lacey asked Aluna for her thoughts regarding Gus’s plan to find the ladybugs. “If anything happens to him, it will be my fault!” Lacey lamented.

Aluna took some time to consider both viewpoints before she spoke. “It appears you have already gained some valuable experience dealing with the dangers that lurk in the Land Beyond the Cabin.” She gazed at Gus, as if sizing up the butterfly. “Have you had second thoughts about setting forth on your grand adventure, after what happened yesterday?”

Gus stood a little straighter as he returned the gaze. “Not at all! I feel like it’s something I have to do. This has been on my mind since I heard Jeremiah’s story.” He turned his attention to Lacey. “You know how I feel, Lace. But, if you tell me that you don’t want me to go, I’ll stay. I think that if I don’t go, I’ll always wonder if I could have made a difference.”

Aluna cleared her throat. “Lacey, you asked me to give you my opinion, and so I shall.” Turning to Gus, she said, “The fact that you are still intent on going, despite the danger, speaks to your character. You are brave and you have a noble heart. Incidentally,

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I've found that a little experience can often make all the difference in life. I believe that if you go, you will continue to learn new skills that will help you survive. Much of life is a gamble, and I respect your desire to take this risk to help your friend."

Now she turned her attention back to Lacey. "I understand the fear you feel, my dear. It's difficult to see someone you love do something that places them in danger. But, if life's experiences have taught me anything, it's that we mustn't try to control the actions of others. It's clear that Gus understands the dangers involved, and he is still of a mind to do this. As hard as it is, I feel that the right thing to do is accept his decision and support him as best we can.

Lacey nodded somberly as she listened to Aluna's advice. She closed her eyes and took a few deep breaths, thinking of what to say. Finally, she opened her eyes and turned to face Gus. "Gussy, I know I have been thinking of all the bad things that could happen to you if you leave. But there are so many good things that can happen, too. I do want the future you have described, and I know that you are smart and strong and brave." She sighed, then stood tall and gave him a beaming smile. "You go and try to find that loveliness. But... if you change your mind or find out the legend isn't true, come back straightaway. Together, we will discover a new future. The most important thing to me is that you return safely. Okay?"

Gus rushed to hug Lacey and lifted her off the ground. "Thank you for understanding! I promise to do everything I can to be safe. You don't know how much your support means to me, Lacey. He kissed her cheek and touched her antennae with his. \

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As he stepped back, he realized he had one more thing to ask Aluna. “I’m grateful that Lacey won’t be alone while I’m gone. Will you keep an eye on her for me?”

The spider regarded Gus with surprise, looking mildly offended. “What a question, my dear boy! I shall safeguard this singular treasure with my life.” Aluna gazed at Lacey with genuine affection.

Gus felt his anxiety dissipate. “That’s a great comfort. Thank you... I’m so glad we met you, Aluna.”

“I feel the same, my dears,” Aluna replied, smiling at the insects that had become so dear to her in the short time they had been acquainted. “It has been most satisfying to see how you two have managed this very eventful period of your lives. I look forward to witnessing how your adventure evolves.”

A familiar noise came from Gus’s midsection. “Strangely, I’m suddenly quite hungry! Might we make our way to Flower Garden for breakfast?” Gus inquired with an endearing look that was impossible to ignore.

Aluna smiled and hoisted her cargo from the ground. “Lead the way, intrepid adventurer!” With that, the three set off. Along the way, Aluna did her best to lighten the somber mood with a story of a human custom she had learned while listening to one of Jeremiah’s many stories. It involved bringing an evergreen tree inside the house, adorning it with lights and colorful ornaments, and placing brightly decorated packages under its boughs. “They have a custom of giving one another gifts during a celebration called ‘Christmas’.” she told her young friends.

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“Humans are indeed curious creatures,” she observed as the trio reached the bright garden, morning sunlight pouring in through the hole in the floor above. The air was crisp and clean, a perfect setting to enjoy their meal. Gus busied himself sampling nectar from a few different flower varieties while Aluna and Lacey watched him, enjoying the food that Aluna’s sticky trap had provided.

“I still think the nectar from that bush is the best,” judged Gus, pointing his antennae toward the butterfly bush. He looked at his companions. “So far, anyway,” he added with a wry smile. After a few moments of uncomfortable silence and the shuffling of feet, he looked at his companions. “Well, I guess it’s time that I get going...”

Lacey stifled a sob and cleared her throat. “Oh Gus, promise me you won’t be dangerous. Don’t take any unnecessary chances, okay? I want you to come back safe!”

Gus smiled reassuringly. “I promise, Lacey. Don’t worry. I’ll be back before you have a chance to miss me.” Lacey smiled back a feeble smile. “Too late!” she answered with tears in her eyes.

The three made their way to the boot, and the hole above. Aluna looked at the silken cord, still dangling from the hole with an appraising eye. “You found an interesting use for your handiwork, my dear.” she said to Lacey with a complimentary smile. “Well done!”

Aluna paused for a moment, then reached inside the boot and produced a curious-looking item. “I placed this here last night, in anticipation of this moment. I must confess, I didn’t expect the moment to come so soon, but here we are. You see, your

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weaving inspired me to do a little experimentation of my own, Lacey.” she explained, holding up the item for the others to inspect. Lacey and Gus examined it closely. A square of silk mesh, with fine, braided cords of silk attached to each corner. One braid was attached to two corners, forming a loop. The other two braids hung down toward the ground.

“It’s quite beautiful, Aluna,” Lacey observed, her voice hushed with awe. “Your skill in weaving makes my work look quite simple in comparison!”

Gus had to agree; not with Lacey’s last comment, but her first. “I’ve never seen anything like it,” he concurred. Then, he asked, “What is it used for, exactly?” His question was tentative, as if he was wondering if he was supposed to discern its use just by looking at it. He hoped his question hadn’t offended the spider.

Aluna chuckled, her fangs clicking together as they always did when she laughed. “This, my boy, is a pouch. I thought that you may have the need to carry items along the way, and this will allow you to do so with tarsi unencumbered. I do hope it fits, and that it will prove some use to you.” she expressed.

“Oh, wow!” Gus exclaimed, though the look on his face showed that he was still a bit mystified.

“Bend over a bit, Gus, and I shall show you how it is to be used.” Aluna instructed. Gus complied, and Aluna passed the loop over his antennae and let it fall across his neck. Then she moved behind the butterfly and tied the two remaining cords around his abdomen, beneath the point where his wings were attached. When she was finished, the silk pouch was centered nicely. After giving an approving nod, she showed him the opening at the top,

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which would allow him to place small objects inside. “I’m not sure what you might need to carry with you, my boy. But you never know...” Aluna commented. It was clear by her expression that she was pleased the design fit him as well as she had hoped.

“Gee, this is so cool!” Gus exclaimed as he practiced opening the pouch with his tarsi. “It even has a pleasant taste!” he added as an afterthought. Aluna and Lacey laughed as Gus tested flitting his wings. “I can’t even feel the cords when I use my wings... it fits perfectly!” Gus informed Aluna, clearly pleased with the gift he had been given. “Thank you, Aluna. I think I know what Christmas must feel like!” He smiled and offered a hug to the yellow garden spider.

Aluna looked touched as she brushed away what must have been a bit of dust from her eyes. “Tut tut, now Gus. We mustn’t get carried away.” Aluna answered. But it was clear that his reaction had exceeded her expectations.

Lacey tugged at the pouch. The apparatus stretched a bit, then snapped back into place when she released it. “It is a thing of wonder, Aluna. She walked around Gus, then frowned a bit. “There is one thing that troubles me, however...”

Lacey turned to her friends and said, “It’s just that the silver color contrasts so much with the green of your body, Gus. And it’s shiny. I’m afraid it might attract the attention of dangerous characters.”

Looking at the pouch again, Aluna realized Lacey had a point as she shook her head. “I must admit that the thought hadn’t occurred to me. But you are quite right, Lacey. It would be a bad

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idea to make Gus a beacon of attention. I suppose it wasn't the best idea after all..."

As Aluna moved to unfasten the pouch, Lacey stopped her. "Wait a second, I have an idea." She went to a flower that had broad leaves and plucked a few. Wrapping them around the cords of the pouch, she rubbed back and forth. In short order, the chlorophyll in the leaf absorbed into the silk, turning it a pleasant shade of green. She did the same to the pouch itself, then stepped back to judge the results. "What do you think, Aluna?"

Aluna beamed at the dragonfly. "Well done, Lacey! Once again, you have demonstrated remarkable resourcefulness. Indeed, it blends in quite nicely with Gus's body now."

Lacey giggled in response to the compliment. "I remembered how the green juice of the leaves colored my tarsi back when I first arrived here," she revealed. "Wait, I have one more idea." Lacey went to the Butterfly Bush and plucked a petal from it. Then she went to the daisy that grew behind the boot; the flower that Gus was intent on tasting the day they met. She plucked a petal from that flower as well. Opening the pouch, she tucked the petals inside. "For luck!" she explained.

"I take all the luck I can get!" Gus remarked. "Look, it's already doing its job!" Aluna and Lacey laughed as he held up his empty tarsi. Then his expression turned serious. "I hope you both know what you mean to me." The laughter stopped and the mood grew somber. "A guy couldn't ask for better friends." He reached out his arms, receiving a tender hug from each in turn. "I really don't like goodbyes..." he confessed with a sigh.

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After a few quiet moments, Gus stood tall with his wings outstretched. “Enough of that. Shall we go up? I suppose I won’t be more ready than I am now.” His friends nodded with melancholy smiles.

Gus flitted his way up through the hole. Soon Lacey and Aluna, with the help of Lacey’s cable, were standing beside him. Together they walked out onto the porch and the bright summer sun. A gentle breeze was blowing and white clouds billowed in the sky, a cheery contrast to the mood shared by the three friends.

“It certainly is a beautiful day!” Gus remarked. He turned to Lacey. “My hope is that one day soon, we will be flying together on a day like this. Maybe if you think about that day, waiting for me to return will be easier?” Gus suggested.

“I’ll do that.” Lacey promised. “I’m going to come here every day, watching for you.” she added. “I’ll be thinking of how nice it will be when you’re back, ladybugs or no.” She gave Gus a kiss on the cheek and hugged him tight, trying her best not to cry.

Gus hugged her back. “I’m going to miss you, Lace.” he said gruffly.

Reluctantly, they released their embrace and Aluna drew near. She placed her tarsus on Gus’s shoulder. “I have every confidence in your ability to complete your mission and return to us speedily and safely,” she declared. “May good fortune and chance guide you.”

Gus smiled. “Thanks, Aluna. Your confidence in me means a lot.” Moving to the edge of the porch, he tested the air and prepared

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for flight. “Ok, I’m off...wish me luck!” Gus declared as he took one final look at Aluna and Lacey.

“Good luck!” his friends said in unison. And with that, Gus lifted off and flitted away. He set course for the tool shed as his friends waved until he rounded the corner of the cabin and disappeared from sight.

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Chapter 14 - Gus Meets the Family

Now that he was on his way, Gus felt his mood transform. He had a mission to accomplish, and he felt a sense of responsibility mingled with excitement as he drifted on the current of the breeze. He zigzagged even more than usual, keeping a watchful eye above, alert for any signs of movement or color against the blue and white backdrop of the sky. Aluna was right. Gus certainly had learned a valuable lesson the day before- the lesson of constant vigilance out here in the world. Gus hummed the cherished tune Lacey had sung to him at Treasure Trove, and he was in high spirits when he arrived at the tool shed.

Gus landed on the branch of a bush outside the shed and looked back at the distance he had traveled in such a short time. He was filled with awe and gratitude. It would have taken Gus the Caterpillar a week of inching to travel that far! He looked about and marveled. The colors, scents, and textures were all things that he couldn't have appreciated as a caterpillar. He felt quite blessed to have such a change in his life. Here he stood, Gus the Butterfly, in the Land Beyond the Cabin, on an adventure to help his friend. He had to laugh out loud. "Crazy!" he said to himself with bemusement as he approached the faded white and green tool shed. It, like the cabin, had been neglected. Its paint, wood, and roofing showed their age. One of the doors was kept closed by a cinder block that had clearly been doing the job for years, while the other sagged and swayed slightly in the breeze, held in place by one rusty hinge squeaking out a lonely melody.

"Jeremiah?" Gus called out as loudly as he could. "Jeremiah! Are you in there?" After a few moments, a pink nose and whiskers

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peeked through an open knothole of a weathered board at the bottom of the shed wall. But it wasn't Jeremiah's nose and whiskers.

"Who are you?" a female voice squeaked suspiciously.

"Hello there! I'm Gus, Jeremiah's friend from the Land Under the Cabin! By any chance, are you Diane?"

The eyes of the mouse appeared in the knothole and appraised Gus critically. "You can't be Gus," the mouse proclaimed, squinting. "Gus is a big green caterpillar. You, sir, are not a caterpillar. You're a butterfly."

Gus fluttered his wings in what he hoped was a friendly way as he tried to explain. "It turns out that caterpillars turn into butterflies! Believe me, nobody was more surprised that I was to find that out!" Gus exclaimed good naturedly. "It really *is* me, though. Jeremiah has told me all about you... and Lila, Jeff, LouAnn, Chris, Tony, Nicky, Ricky, Tom, Mike, Kevin, Nancy, Patricia, Kim, and Luis." Gus recited the names with concentration, his eyes closed. "Oh, and little Joye, of course!" He opened his eyes, hoping he hadn't forgotten anyone.

"Well, goodness." breathed Diane. "You must be Gus, alright! Jeremiah isn't back from gathering breakfast yet, but he and the boys should be back pretty soon. Do you want to come inside to wait? I'm sure the little ones would be interested in meeting a butterfly." Gus nodded eagerly. "You can come in through the door over there." Diane's nose pointed toward the squeaky door Gus noticed earlier. "Make your way around the rake and burlap bag, then you'll see a red wooden crate straight ahead. You can't miss it!" The head disappeared back into the knothole.

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Gus followed her directions. Sure enough, there was the red crate with Diane standing outside it as he rounded the burlap bag. “Welcome to our home, Gus.” She looked at the butterfly, then at the small hole gnawed through the bottom edge of the overturned crate. “Well you’re never going to fit through there. Wait here, and I’ll bring the children out.

Diane disappeared into the crate. In short order, four small mice appeared. Their mother came out last and explained that the oldest three mice had left the crate to start families of their own. The next three in line, Chris, Tony, and Nicky were out foraging with their father. The others (Ricky, Tom, Mike, Kevin, Nancy, Patricia, Kim, and Luis) regarded Gus with curiosity, sniffing him and tickling his torso with their wiry whiskers. “Joye is hiding somewhere inside; that girl is the cause of all my gray hair!” Diane said with a sigh. “I’m sure she’ll make herself known when she decides the time is right.”

Gus smiled his friendliest smile and addressed the youngsters surrounding him. “Hello, little ones. I’m a friend of your daddy. My name’s Gus!” He tried to guess their names, and the mice squeaked merrily when he confused Nancy with Patricia.

“Don’t feel bad,” offered Diane. I can’t tell those two apart myself.”

The children giggled as Gus fluttered his wings and wagged his antennae to entertain them. Then, Gus said loudly, “Gee, I wonder where Joye could be. I really wanted to meet her.” He winked conspiratorially at Diane.

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Diane responded in kind. “Your guess is as good as mine! I guess you’ll have to meet her another time.”

Just then, Gus jumped with a yelp as he felt two small hands on his back. “Boo!” a tiny voice shouted as he spun around amid a chorus of titters to see who had startled him. “Hello, Mr. Gus. It’s a pleasure to meet you,” squeaked a little voice belonging to the smallest of all the pups, a mischievous grin on the tiny face.

“You must be Joye!” Gus exclaimed after recovering from a mock heart attack. “Your dad told me about that freckle on your nose. It’s a pleasure to meet you, too.”

The tiny mouse beamed, then looked curiously at the pouch that Gus was wearing. “What’s that?” she asked curiously.

Diane interjected, “Joye, scaring our guest was not nice. I’ve told you how we act when we have visitors.” she looked sternly at her youngest.

Joye looked down and answered quietly, “Yes, ma’am.”

Diane’s gaze softened. It was clear that she had a tender spot in her heart for Joye. “No harm done. Just remember for next time.” Joye looked up with a happy countenance as her mother said to Gus, “I was wondering what you’re wearing myself. Can you tell us about it?”

Gus started to explain, but didn’t get very far before everyone’s attention turned toward the burlap bag. “Papa!” Joye exclaimed as she bounded toward her father, who had dropped the acorn he was carrying in his mouth. Apparently, he hadn’t been expecting to see a big green butterfly encircled by his wife and children.

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“Oof!” Jeremiah exhaled as little Joye barrelled into him, wrapping her little arms around his tummy as best she could. “My little peanut!” Jeremiah patted her on the head. “Take this to your mother, please. Be a good girl and help her get lunch ready.”

Joye grabbed the acorn by the stem and tried to drag it to her mother, but it only moved a few inches. One of Jeremiah’s three sons who had come in behind their father chuckled, patted Joye on the head, then helped her pull the acorn to where their mother stood waiting. As the older boys piled seeds and nuts into a pile and the mouselings gathered around to watch the food preparation hungrily, Jeremiah approached his guest.

“It’s not every day I come home to find a visitor, much less a butterfly! But if Diane let you in, I guess you must be a good enough fellow. My name’s Jeremiah. How can I help you?”

Gus pretended to be hurt. “Jeremiah! Don’t tell me you don’t recognize me. It’s me, your pal Gus!” He waggled his antennae playfully.

Jeremiah looked dumbfounded. He looked at Diane, apparently expecting her to be able to explain. She just shrugged in response. “Well, dear, he knew the names of all the children. I thought that was proof enough. Besides,” she regarded Gus. “There’s something about him that I like. He claims that caterpillars turn into butterflies.” She shrugged and returned to her work.

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Jeremiah turned back to Gus. “Caterpillars turn into butterflies, huh? That’s a new one to me. Say something else,” the mouse demanded, closing his eyes.

“It is me, Jeremiah, your friend Gus! Last time we talked, you told me about Randall and the ladybugs,” Gus started. Then as an afterthought, he added, “Lacey says hi?” Gus looked at Jeremiah hopefully.

Jeremiah opened his eyes. “Well, you sure *sound* like Gus... but, a butterfly?” He shook his head in amazement.

Gus shrugged and nodded. “I know, right?”

Jeremiah started to laugh, slowly at first, then with gusto. “Gus the Butterfly! Isn’t that something.” He came close and gave his friend a hug. “You must have quite a story to tell me!”

Gus returned the hug happily. “Do I ever!” As Jeremiah’s family feasted on nuts and seeds, Gus entertained them with his story of meeting a friendly spider, sleeping inside a chrysalis, seeing the world- and Lacey- with new eyes, exploring the skies of the Land Beyond the Cabin, his narrow escape from becoming a bird’s noontime snack, and seeing himself in the silver platter’s reflection. “I said goodbye to Lacey and Aluna this morning,” he concluded. “I’m going to find those ladybugs. They’ll fix Lacey’s wing!” he announced confidently.

At the mention of Aluna, Jeremiah and Diane shared a look that Gus didn’t notice. The young mice just looked at him with blank stares. Jeremiah had to fill in parts of the story so they could understand what Gus was hoping to accomplish on his quest.

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Then he said to Gus, “I don’t know... This plan of yours sounds dangerous. Who knows if those ladybugs even exist?”

Gus shook his head defiantly. “As long as there’s a chance that they’re out there, I intend to look! I just came to tell you where I’m going. And ask you to take care of Lacey, if... if I don’t come back.”

Jeremiah looked at his friend, contemplating his words. “Well, shoot, Gus... You know you can depend on me. But...” he swallowed, “You’ll be ok. Just take care of yourself, and get back here in one piece,” he implored with a slight quiver in his squeaky voice.

“Jeremiah! Not you, too! You sound like Lacey. I’ll be fine. You’ll see.” Gus’s countenance exuded bravery and confidence. “I’m glad you came home in time, but I have to go soon. I want to get across the river before the sun goes down.”

Jeremiah looked at his friend and asked, “Before you go, I’ve got to know what that thing is that you’re wearing. What on earth is it?” The other faces staring at Gus seemed very curious as well, and Gus chuckled. “I was just explaining that when you walked in. It’s actually a gift from Aluna.” He continued explaining the purpose of the pouch and how Lacey had figured out how to color it green. “I’m not sure what I’ll use it for,” Gus admitted. “But right now, it has two lucky flower petals inside!”

Joye’s face lit up. “Lucky flower petals! Can I see?” Gus allowed her to fish the petals out of the pouch and pass them around for everyone to examine, then she placed them back in their hiding place after giving each a kiss. “Now they’re even more lucky!” she declared as she patted the pouch reverently.

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Jeremiah approached Gus. “I know you want to get going. If it’s alright with you, I’ll go with you as far as the river’s edge. I’d like to see those wings of yours in action!”

Little Joye piped up, “Can we go too, Papa?” A chorus of excited voices clamored in agreement. Jeremiah looked at his wife and got another shrug in reply.

He sighed, “Well, alright, but only if you all stay close to your momma and me, and you pay attention to us. The world outside this shed is a dangerous place.” The young mice all promised excitedly. “Hop up on my back, Joye. And hold on tight!” The littlest mouse scampered into place obediently.

Looking at his family, he ensured they were all paying close attention to him. “Remember. Stay close, stay alert, and above all, do as I say, you hear?” The young mice all nodded. Joye was so excited that her little paws tugged at the hair coming out of his ears. “Ouch! Hold onto my ears, little one. Not the hair!” He looked at his oldest boys. “Tom, Mike, Kevin, you stay in the rear, watch the youngsters, and stay sharp.” Directing his gaze toward Diane and Gus, “You two lead the way, and we’ll follow.”

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Chapter 15 - A Riverside Conversation

Soon the mice and butterfly were gathered in front of the shed. “Show us what you got, Gus!” Jeremiah encouraged, and all eyes fell on the butterfly. Gus stretched his wings and tested the breeze. Turning a bit to face into the wind, he leapt and caught the air. He fluttered in eccentric circles around the family of mice amid cheers and squeaks. Then he gained altitude and headed for the river, dividing his attention between the mice scampering around rocks and trees below, and the sky above. Flittering and fluttering a zigzag course, he led the way toward the river. The mice had a time of keeping pace, until, near the river, Gus spied a little garden of nectar-laden flowers and couldn’t resist dropping down for a fill-up before embarking on the trip across the broad river... and to let the family of mice catch up, of course.

Gus sampled the flavor of the various nectars through the taste receptors in his tarsi before extending his proboscis to drink deeply. The energy-filled liquid recharged him, preparing him for the long flight across the water. The younger mice frolicked and chased each other happily in the tall grass nearby, while their parents tried to maintain some amount of order and watch for signs of danger.

“Time to go!” Jeremiah shouted after a signal from Gus that he was ready. “Come on, Joye, you know what to do. Stay sharp, lads!” The group made their way to the river bank with Gus leading the way. He alighted on a branch near the slow-flowing water, the family of field mice forming a semicircle around him.

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“Good luck!”

“Come back safely!”

“Be careful!”

“We hope you find the ladybugs!”

Shouts of encouragement filled the air until Jeremiah held up his paws for quiet. “Gus, I wish you luck. How long do you think you’ll be gone?” He asked his friend.

“I’ve been thinking about that. I’m going to give myself two weeks. If I haven’t found them by then, I’ll come back.” Gus answered, his face showing that he didn’t want to think of that eventuality. Then, looking at his long-time friend, he said, “Hey Jeremiah, can I talk to you privately before I go?”

“Sure,” Jeremiah responded. The circle of mice parted and the friends walked along the river bank. The gentle sounds of the water were new to Gus, and the scene seemed to him peaceful and serene. “A nice place to have this discussion,” he thought to himself.

Clearing his throat, he began, “Jeremiah, I hope it’s ok to bring up this subject. If you don’t want to talk about it, just say so, ok. The thing is, Aluna told me some things that have made me wonder. She... she mentioned that you two were once friends, but that you don’t talk anymore. I thought it curious, because we’ve talked a lot, yet you have never mentioned her in all the time we have been friends. Will you tell me what happened?”

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Jeremiah's smile disappeared. "That topic is not easy to talk about." Gus opened his mouth to say something, but Jeremiah put a paw up. "No, not easy, but you are a true friend, and you deserve to know what happened. I should have told you earlier." The mouse took a seat next to the river, and Gus perched on a nearby stick.

"I told you about the eleven kids Diane and I have, and now you have met most of them. What you don't know is that there was another. Our firstborn, Jeremiah Jr. He died when he was a youngster." Jeremiah's voice broke and he looked away, trying to compose himself.

Gus felt shocked. He had no idea that Jeremiah had experienced such a loss. He fumbled for something to say, finally managing, "Gosh, Jeremiah. I'm so sorry."

Jeremiah answered with a tight smile, wiping a tear away. "It was my fault. Back then, we lived in the shed, but not under the crate. We lived out in the open, which was foolish on my part. I left my family too exposed to danger. One day, I was out foraging for food, and Diane was tending Junior and the others. We had a total of eight pups then. Well, Miah went wandering away from his momma. Diane heard a little squeak, and rushed to find him. By the time she arrived where the sound came from, the largest spider she had ever seen was carrying little Junior through a gap in the shed's wall planks. There was nothing she could do; she couldn't leave the other younglings, and even if she had tried to save him, that spider..." He fell silent, his shoulders shaking as he tried to maintain his composure.

Gus knew that no words could bring Jeremiah peace, but he hoped a hug would help. He placed a comforting arm around his

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friend and they spent a quiet moment together, mourning the loss of Jeremiah Jr.

After some time, Jeremiah resumed his story. “Diane didn’t want to have any more pups after that. Ricky is the last of our own; the others you met today were orphans we took in. Before we lost Miah, we were planning on having a large family.” Jeremiah heaved a sigh with shoulders drooping, as if he had just carried a huge burden up a hill. “I moved the family into the crate right after that, but it was too late to save my boy. If only...” his voice trailed off and he fell silent.

Gus gave Jeremiah some time. He looked out at the river, marveling at the amount of water that was flowing along. He considered how difficult a burden the loss of Miah was to his friend and to Diane. He was sure they both felt it was their fault that he had died. The story reminded him of Jeremiah’s grandfather, Alexander. Similar story beginning, but this one had a tragic ending. His mind wandered to the dangers he was sure to encounter on his own travels, wondering what fate had in store for him.

Jeremiah’s voice brought Gus back to the present. “Anyway, I couldn’t associate with Aluna after that. I know she had nothing to do with what happened, but I can’t find a way past the fact that she’s a spider. When I think about going to talk to her, the images of my boy flood my mind and it feels like my heart is going to burst.” He looked sadly at Gus. “Do you understand now why I haven’t spoken to her since?”

Gus thought for a time, considering. When he spoke, his voice was soft and gentle. “I can only imagine the grief you feel,

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Jeremiah. I'm so sorry that you and Diane, and your other pups, had to suffer such a tragedy. I wish I could have met little Miah."

He paused before continuing, hoping what he was going to say next was appropriate. "Lacey and I met Aluna the day before I began my transformation into a butterfly. I want you to know how much she helped Lacey through that time with love and compassion. She has proven to be a true friend in the short time we have known her. I sensed sadness and a feeling of loss when she talked about you. I wanted to let you know about the Aluna I know, because if you go to visit Lacey, I'm sure Aluna will be with her. I'm sure she would really like to see you again."

Jeremiah was gazing out over the river as Gus was talking. Finally, he nodded and turned to look at Gus. "Aluna was a good friend to me, and it sounds like she has treated you with the same kindness. I've missed our talks and her wisdom and guidance before... before..." was all he could manage. Then he shook his head and cleared his throat. "Well, Gus. I can't make any promises concerning Aluna, but I promise to look after Lacey. If you don't return, you can count on me to do whatever I can to make that dragonfly happy and keep her safe."

Gus placed his tarsi on Jeremiah's shoulders, (which he discovered *didn't* taste nearly as good as nectar). "Thank you, Jeremiah, I know Lacey's in good paws. If it weren't for you, I wouldn't have even known about this possible chance to heal Lacey's wing. Besides that, you have taught me so much!" He looked at the sun's position in the sky, then added, "It's getting late... shall we head back to the family?"

Jeremiah nodded, and the two friends walked back down the river bank toward the waiting family of field mice. As they

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walked, Gus broke the silence. “Thanks for telling me about what happened. Who knows? Maybe with time, things will resolve themselves. If I’ve learned anything so far, it’s that life is hard to predict!”

Jeremiah chuckled. “You speak the truth, Gus. I mean, I’m walking next to a butterfly that used to be a caterpillar!” They laughed at that, and when they reached the rest of the group, their body language showed little evidence of the difficult conversation they just had.

Gus flew to perch on the top of a tree stump and addressed his travelling companions. “Thank you all for accompanying me here. Your support means more to me than you know! I look forward to getting to know you better when I return.”

Jeremiah cleared his throat with a mousy cough. “Gus, you already know to beware of birds. But there are other creatures who like to eat insects. I know you haven’t seen a lot of other kinds of animals, but snakes and lizards should definitely be avoided. As a general rule, try to stay away from creatures who are larger than you. Especially if they have smooth or scaly skin, no fur, and a long tongue!” the mouse warned.

Gus nodded. “Bald, long tongue. Got it! Thanks, Jeremiah.” he said, filing the information away in his preoccupied mind. As he turned to face the wide expanse of water, he announced boldly, “I’m setting off today on a mission that may be perilous and difficult, but the support of my friends will help me get through what may come.” He turned back one last time to the mice. “Thank you for coming all this way to see me off. I love you all, and I can’t wait to see you again!” he proclaimed. Finally, the moment of departure had come.

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Gus stood tall, testing the wind direction and speed with his antennae. It was blowing in the same direction as the water's flow. That wasn't as favorable as a good tailwind, but it was gentle and he didn't think it would hinder his flight much.

"Alright, you ladybugs... here I come!," he declared as he lifted off. Another cheer and more well-wishes sounded as he turned and started his long flight across the water. When he was out of sight, Jeremiah and Diane rounded up their children and headed back to the safety of their cozy crate.

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Chapter 16 - Winds of Change

Gus felt happy and excited as he flitted over the water. “What a great big world, this Land Beyond the Cabin,” he thought to himself. He couldn’t make out the shore on the far side of the river from this height, so he flew higher to get his bearings. There it was. How far away it looked to the relatively tiny butterfly as he churned through the air. “But I’m getting closer with every flap of my wings...” he told himself. Rolling hills dotted with clusters of trees lay beyond the river, and he convinced himself that the trees were getting larger as the minutes ticked by. Remembering the first rule of survival, vigilance, he scanned the sky above. All he saw was a patchwork of white, billowing clouds against the endless blue sky.

Almost immediately, a voice of doubt crept into his mind. “How are you going to find some tiny ladybugs hiding somewhere in this vast land?” it asked. He shook his head and answered himself out loud, determined. “Lacey is depending on me. I will find them!” His wings plowed the air. He took deep breaths and tried to stay focused. “The first thing I have to do is to get across this river,” he told himself. “One step at a time, Gus.”

It was then that he noticed the breeze began to shift. To his dismay, it turned to blow directly against his flight path. His forward progress stopped- it was all he could do to keep from going backward! As he continued to strain against the wind, the thought occurred to him that he may do better to turn around and go back. But when he looked behind him, he doubted that he could make it back with his remaining strength. He had passed the point of no return! Desperately, Gus battled forward. His muscles cried out and his heart raced.

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“You have to keep fighting,” he told himself. “Think of your friends... no, your family!” Gus corrected himself. “They are your family. You made a promise to them. Lacey is counting on you!” As the minutes dragged on, it was all Gus could do to stay aloft. At times, he could rest on the breeze by opening his wings wide, allowing the air current to do the work for him. But then, a gust would flip him upside down or around like a top, and he would have to expend all his saved energy to get turned around the right way again. Gus started to doubt that he could continue much longer. As hard as he tried to maintain his altitude, the blue-green surface of the river seemed to slowly rise up toward him.

Just when his legs were ready to touch the water, he would summon a little more strength, “Just one more time,” he told himself, and gained a little elevation. But he knew it was only a matter of time. Occasionally, the breeze would die down for a few minutes and Gus was able to make a little progress toward his goal. But then it would pick back up, and the battle to stay aloft continued. “Oh, Lacey, forgive me. I tried... but I didn’t even get across the river.” Hot tears of frustration blurred his vision. He felt his great wings getting heavier, each stroke through the air took all his effort. Even his antennae sagged. Gus was exhausted.

Just at the moment he was about to give up, he saw it out of the corner of his eye. At first, he thought his vision was playing a cruel trick on him. But, no... There was something breaking the water a little downstream. What was it? It was then that Gus learned another life lesson. Even when things are at their darkest, when despair seems insurmountable, a little hope makes a big difference. Surely, Gus reasoned, I can fly just a bit

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higher to see what was causing those ripples... a dark spot not too far away... Yes! That *had* to be a branch protruding from the water!

Gus was flying over a rather shallow, slow-moving part of the river where sand and rocks had been deposited by the river currents. Fortunately for Gus, the soft sand had snared the roots of a tree floating downstream. Gus could see the submerged trunk under the gently flowing water, with one lone branch reaching into the air. It wasn't much, but it was just right for a worn out butterfly!

Gus willed himself onward. By altering his path toward the branch, he no longer faced the wind head-on. He found that by flapping hard for eight strokes and letting off for eight gave him a chance to catch his breath, and... was he actually making headway? He convinced himself that he was, anyway. Inch by inch, foot by foot, he closed the distance. The breeze slacked off, and Gus put all his effort into one final push. Just as the breeze picked up again, Gus felt his rear legs touch down on the slender branch. He had made it!

Grateful to be alive after such a harrowing flight, Gus said a little prayer of thanks. He thought of Jeremiah, Diane, and their children, of Aluna. And of course he thought of Lacey. As he caught his breath and rested his weary wings, he wondered what she was doing at that moment. Was she thinking of him as well? Did she sense the danger he was in just moments ago? He hoped not.

Something happened inside of Gus as he perched on that little branch in the river, the breeze blowing steadily in his face. He thought of how close he had come to giving up. Of failing even

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before he really began his quest. But he hadn't! Gus had persevered when there was little hope that he could survive. He had kept fluttering his wings for all he was worth, and this branch had appeared just as he was ready to succumb to fatigue. As a result, he felt just a little more confident. A little more hopeful. And even more determined. "Maybe tomorrow, but perhaps today. Sooner or later, I'll find the way!"

He continued to stretch his wings and breathe slowly and deeply. Dipping his proboscis into the river, he quenched his tremendous thirst. By and by, Gus started to feel better. A little stronger, somewhat recovered from the near-total exhaustion he experienced. He looked at the sun. It was dipping lower; reds and oranges streaked the sky. Gus had never seen a sunset. As a caterpillar, he never would have been able to appreciate what he was now witnessing, perched on this slender purchase with water all around him. Sunlight haloed the fluffy white clouds with a silvery fringe. Pink and purple hues started to emerge, bathing the hills in magical vaporous layers of color that caused the butterfly's breath to catch. Gus was filled with awe and wonder. "Only one thing could make this moment more special," he said aloud. Deep down, he knew that one day, he would share a moment like this with a certain dragonfly, and he smiled blissfully. As darkness settled over the Land Beyond the Cabin, Gus decided that he would be just fine right where he was until morning. He gripped the branch tightly with his sticky feet, and with his wings folded neatly, he tried to sleep.

Unfortunately, Gus didn't have a very restful night. The breeze didn't let up and continued to buffet him, but he held firm to his perch and finally managed to doze off as the breeze abated in the early pre-dawn hours. Gus was awake as the sun broke through a misty haze on the eastern horizon, beams of light

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piercing a cloud and illuminating another tapestry of color across the sky. He couldn't decide whether he liked sunsets or sunrises more, but he felt that both were spectacular.

Gus felt better once the warm rays reached him. Being cold-blooded, he relied on the sun to do the job of heating his chilled body. He extended his green wings fully and the sun's heat radiated through him, restoring some flexibility in his joints and igniting hope in his heart. His stomach reminded him that it was time to eat, but there was nothing he could do about that right now. He had to reach the other side. He was sure that bright flowers and sweet nectar awaited him there. As he checked the air, he was grateful to find that the merciless headwind he had faced the day before had been replaced by a slight tailwind. Taking another long drink from the river, he decided that it was time to get moving.

"Goodbye, branch. You served me well, and I thank you for your hospitality!" he offered to the sliver of wood that had saved his life.

Gus turned to face the slight breeze and launched off. He circled back toward his destination and set his course toward dry land. In the light of day and with some rest, it looked much closer than it had the previous evening. He started to daydream about the sweet nectar he would find there, perhaps not paying as close attention to his surroundings as a lone butterfly should. The morning was so pleasant, but his tummy so empty. If Gus knew anything about himself, it was that he thought more clearly on a full stomach.

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Chapter 17 - Enemies and Allies

As Gus neared the far bank of the river, he noticed a low-lying area of shoreline had been flooded, forming a small pond. He noticed ducks moving through the cattails and reeds, looking for breakfast of their own. In an instant, a loud chattering filled the air from somewhere above! He turned to locate the source of the noise, and saw a flash of red-orange against the blue of the sky. An oriole was making its way across the pond! It hadn't yet spotted Gus, but he felt that it was only a matter of time until it did. He picked up his pace. He was so close to the marsh at the edge of the pond! He was sure to find a hiding place there, if only he could escape notice just a little longer...

It was then that he spied the blue jay from the corner of his eye. The dark blue body wasn't as noticeable as the oriole's bright plumage, but Gus's keen eyes saw the movement moments before the bird saw him. "Scree!" The blue jay announced both himself and his intentions as it aimed its flight toward the green target fluttering toward the pond. At least Gus had a few seconds to prepare himself before he had been discovered; he didn't feel the same blinding panic that had gripped him when the blackbird attacked him back at the cabin.

"Come on, Gus... you've got this!" He coached himself as the blue spot grew larger. To Gus's dismay, now the oriole had also spied him, thanks in part to the cry of the blue jay. The oriole picked up speed and started a shallow dive toward Gus. In the span of a few minutes, the peaceful morning had suddenly gotten quite precarious! With two predators closing in on him from different directions, it was all Gus could do to keep an eye on both predators. The blue jay was closer, but the oriole had

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the advantage of altitude. Its dive was allowing it to close the distance on par with its rival.

Gus could tell that at this rate, both birds would reach him at about the same time. He tried to stay calm and evaluate his options in the remaining seconds. He conserved his strength and searched the area for anything he could use to his advantage. There! Could it be? Gus spied some green circles dotting the edge of the pond. Gus thought of Lacey's comment when her memory had sparked. In an instant, he had a plan! Assessing the predators closing in, he knew he would only have one chance for his plan to work, and he was going to need plenty of luck as well.

The hard, curved beak of the blue jay opened in anticipation of his mid-morning morsel, but the bird didn't know just how agile butterflies are. At the last second, Gus flipped upside-down, pulling at the air. Suddenly he wasn't where the bird had expected him to be. Gus had purposefully moved under the blue jay, effectively blocking the oriole's path.

In the attack above the cabin, Gus had learned that birds can't change direction as fast as he could, especially when they were flying at high speeds. If the birds knew about butterflies' agility, their frantic greed to be the first to reach Gus perhaps had caused them to be careless. It was too late for the oriole to change course. He tried, but that just made the impact a little more spectacular. The oriole's outstretched wing clipped the blue jay's body, knocking the blue jay off course and sending the oriole cartwheeling into the reeds with a splash. Apparently, the blue jay wasn't too keen on being struck with red-orange missiles, and it was waiting when the soggy oriole emerged from the reeds, somewhat disoriented and dizzy. After getting a flurry

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of blue wings and sharp clawed feet directed toward its face, the oriole remembered that it had an urgent appointment far away from this pond, and flew away with great haste.

“Scree!” cried the blue jay in triumph. It flew higher, circling the pond in search of its prey. But Gus was nowhere to be found.

“Scree! Scree!” the bird shouted in frustration. It skimmed the cattails, criss-crossing the pond in vain. Finally, the blue jay gave up the hunt and flew away across the river.

If anyone were observing the pond carefully, they may have noticed one of the lily pads rocking gently in the still water. And, if the observer were to look very carefully at that lily pad, they might be able to detect the green wings of a butterfly stretched out flat on top of the round, floating plant. Lacey’s words of inspiration still glimmered in Gus’s mind, “Those wings of yours remind me of a lily pad!” Gus lifted his head and looked across the river. He couldn’t see the cabin of course, but he knew the general direction. “Thank you, Lacey!” he whispered.

Now that the danger had passed, the first order of business for Gus was food. The trip across the river combined with the frenzied flight this morning had depleted all of his internal reserves. He lifted off, and soon his super nectar-vision showed him that he could breakfast in the nearby meadow. Gus tried to enjoy his new hobby of evaluating the new nectar qualities that he was discovering, but he couldn’t shake the sense of urgency inside. He felt that there wasn’t a moment to waste.

“Slow down, Gus. Remember to notice these moments. Your friends are going to want to hear your stories when you see them again!” Gus told himself. He took some deep breaths, enjoying

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the energy growing inside from breakfast. “It is a beautiful day, and I’m across the river!” he noted, full of gratitude.

It was then that Gus noticed the moving at the base of the flower whose nectar he was sampling, and he fluttered lower to investigate. The sleek, brown head and antennae of a wood cockroach broke through the black soil. Not seeing Gus, who was hovering above and slightly behind, the cockroach crawled out of his burrow and shook the dirt from his wings. The mere fact that this insect had wings like him caused Gus to wonder if he could trust this creature. “Maybe,” he mused, “All winged insects are allies!” He fluttered down to the ground to introduce himself. “Hello, friend. My name is Gus!” He said with a smile.

The cockroach stopped and turned back to regard Gus. “Well now. It’s not every day that I get approached by a butterfly,” the cockroach rasped. “As a matter of fact, you’re the first. What could a magnificent creature like you want from an insignificant ground-dweller like me?” he asked with a sarcastic tone.

“Ah, well...” Gus hesitated, a little flustered by the harsh response. “I’m not from around here. I’m on a special mission. Do you by any chance know of a group of ladybugs that live in this area? It’s very important that I find them.” Gus asked matter-of-factly.

The cockroach pondered for a moment, then replied, “Magic ladybugs? I’ve never heard of such a thing.” Before Gus could respond, the roach continued, “But... a friend of mine knows a lot more than I do. His name is Billy Bob, the Bullyfrog. You can usually find him in the bog, over yonder...” Slender antennae pointed toward an area beyond the reeds marking the border of the pond. The area had a dark green hue due to the overgrowth

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of vines and a blanket of kudzu covering the trees in a leafy-green cloak.

“Um, Ok... Thanks for your help!” Gus exclaimed, happy to have a lead, even if the bog did look a little ominous to him.

The cockroach replied dryly, “No problem. You can tell him Benny sent ya. By the way, what’s that thing you’re wearing? I never saw anything like it.” Benny gestured toward Aluna’s gift.

“Oh, this? It’s a pouch. You know, for carrying stuff.” Gus replied. Not wanting to get caught in a longer conversation, he added, “It was good to meet you, Benny. Thanks for the help!” Gus launched himself immediately and began to wing his way toward the bog.

Gus didn’t hear the rest of Benny’s words as he watched the fluttering butterfly recede into the distance, “Carrying stuff? I thought I had seen everything. Well, that was almost too easy. You owe me one, Bill. Hehehe...” he chuckled mirthlessly. Maybe even a little wickedly.

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Something felt off as Gus reached the bog. The sun’s rays had a difficult time breaking through the dense canopy. Shadowy, humid air and the deafening buzz of cicadas set an atmosphere of apprehension inside the butterfly. “Well, I have come all this way, and I have to talk to the creatures who live here if I hope to find the ladybugs,” he told himself. He gathered his resolve and flew further into the stagnant bog. “Hello?” he called out. “Anyone in here?” Hearing nothing, he pressed into the stale gloom even further. “I’m looking for Billy Bob... Hello?”

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A booming voice caught Gus by surprise. “I’m Billy Bob,” a deep, croaky rumble rose up from a dark corner of the pond in response to Gus’s shout. Gus landed on a kuzu-tufted tree branch. Looking down to locate the source of the croak, Gus saw two beady eyes perched atop a squat, green head. The enormous pouch under the frog’s curving mouth pulsated slowly. Its massive girth drooped in resignation, a green halo draped over the smooth rock that supported Billy Bob’s weight.

“Nice to make your acquaintance, sir. My name is Gustavius. I am searching for magical ladybugs that are rumored to live somewhere in this land. I met Benny and he suggested you may know where I can find them.” Gus smiled warmly, hoping that this encounter could be the break he needed.

“Ladybugs... hmm. Oh, yes, I seem to remember something about that. But tell me, Gustavius, why are you looking for them? Come closer and tell old Billy Bob your story.” Gus came halfway down the tree. A sense of foreboding was tugging at Gus, but he told himself to relax. It was probably hard for Billy Bob to see him in the dim light, he reasoned. He waved his green wings to make sure the frog saw him. A bit of gelatinous drool oozed out of the corner of Billy Bob’s mouth as he smiled broadly.

Gus explained about Lacey’s damaged wing and the fable of the ladybugs. He was getting good at recounting all that had happened, and he spoke with animation and passion. “I’ve got to find them... they may be Lacey’s only chance to fly again!” he added in case the frog hadn’t fully grasped the importance of his mission. Billy Bob squatted, listening, apparently very interested in the tale Gus was telling.

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“I’m having trouble hearing you, son. Come perch yourself on this branch next to me here,” indicating a branch less than a foot from the frog. Gus felt frustration at this long back-and-forth. Sighing, he dropped off his perch and flew in erratic circles, getting closer to the frog. He talked as he descended, but then stopped as he finally paid attention to the thought that had been trying to get noticed. He recalled what Jeremiah had told him on the river bank, before Gus had set off on his adventure: “Stay away from creatures who are larger than you, especially if they have smooth or scaly skin.” Gus heard his friend’s voice as if the mouse was there with him as he descended closer and closer to the waiting frog.

His senses alert to danger, time seemed to slow as Gus circled in front of Billy Bob, who was now just a little below now. He hadn’t moved since this encounter had begun, but Gus saw a flash of unexpected movement now. Billy Bob’s great fleshy mouth all at once opened violently. A great, pink tongue hurtled, unfurling, straight toward Gus. Part of staying alive in this land, Gus was learning, was to trust your instincts when in a situation where danger might be lurking.

Gus didn’t have to think. He automatically stopped his forward momentum by extending his wings, then in one swift motion he was sliding to his left... just in time. The sticky tongue whizzed by Gus’s wide eyes, licking empty air in vain. Before Billy Bob could try again, Gus had retreated to safety, out of the range of the bullfrog and his secret weapon. “Come back here, you little...” He didn’t wait around long enough to hear the rest. Even more quickly than he had entered, Gus left the shadows of the bog and found a quiet spot to rest in the sunny meadow where he had found breakfast... and Benny.

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After a short respite (and a little nectar from a clump of sunflowers), Gus set off once more. He felt a little dejected as he flew inland, away from the river and pond and bog. He had decided he'd had enough of water for a little while. His spirits were low because his quest, so far, hadn't been easy or pleasant. Mother Nature had turned against him, or so it seemed. He had barely survived the headwind during the trip across the river. Then he had been attacked by not one, but two birds! He thought about Benny and how dangerous it is to trust the wrong creatures that inhabit the Land Beyond the Cabin. "That's why finding, and keeping friends you can trust is so important." he reasoned as he flew. That thought turned his attention back to his friends and why he was here in a dangerous place. His friend needed help. These thoughts served to temper the negative thoughts plaguing Gus. Hope and creativity crept back in.

Gus felt re-energized. He began to take more interest in his surroundings. He was flying through an apple orchard. Orbs of green and yellow hung from the leafy green branches and there was a pleasant, fresh aroma in the air. Gus took deep breaths and thought of his friends and all the good things he had in life. It was such a stark contrast to what he had experienced as a caterpillar. He could feel so much more now. He could see clearly and in color, taste all of the exquisite varieties of nectar. He was learning to assess the different amounts of energy that each one gave him. He was thinking about all of this so intently that once again, he had forgotten about staying vigilant!

He was no longer in the orchard, but flitting through a lovely meadow. The clouds in the sky caused patches of shadow and light. Movement among the flowers up ahead caught his eye, and

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immediately all of Gus's senses were alert. As he looked more closely, he realized that the creature was small, and he allowed himself to relax a bit. Soon, he was able to make out the black and yellow markings of a large bumblebee!

Although small in size compared to Gus, it was quite round and seemed a bit too large for the quite small wings it owned. He realized with a little shock that he wasn't the only one with a taste for nectar. The bee was busy collecting nectar from the violet flowers of a columbine plant growing near a great oak tree, almost disappearing from view behind the downturned flute of a delicate flower.

Gus reasoned that anyone with an appreciation for nectar *had* to be trustworthy... but he thought about the discussion with Benny earlier. He remembered feeling not quite right about how the cockroach had talked to him. This time, he decided that he should pay more attention to his intuition. "Hello, friend! Mind if I join you?" Gus greeted as he neared the cluster of flowers that occupied the bumblebee's attention. The flowers apparently still held the bee's attention, because it didn't respond to his salutation. Gus didn't know if the bee hadn't heard him or if he was being ignored.

He decided to try again. "Hello there, my name is Gustavius!" Gus said, louder. This time, the bee did take notice of the large green butterfly fluttering nearby.

"Huh? Were you talking to me? Sorry, I tend to get a little distracted." The bee replied in a voice that seemed to hum in melodic resonance with the buzzing of her wings. Gus observed the bee before he responded. She didn't seem to be annoyed or angry, nor overly excited. It seemed to Gus that he was being

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observed with mild curiosity. He decided to extend a bit of trust. “Well, yes. I hope I didn’t startle you. Actually, I just turned into a butterfly recently. I didn’t used to drink nectar, but I sure do like it now! Do you... have any tips for a newcomer like me?” Gus smiled as he flew nearer to what he hoped was a new friend.

As the bee hovered mid-air, a look of fascination came over her. “Wait a minute. Are you telling me... that you just transformed?” The bee flew around Gus, examining him from all sides. “Fascinating! I have always wondered how it must feel to suddenly be granted the power to fly, and to be given all the other abilities that your species develop, virtually overnight! Of course, I’m not denying that bumblebees go through our own larval stage; of course we do. But it’s not the same, not the same at all... you see, I have no memory of that part of my developmental phase. I’m making an assumption that you *do* remember being a caterpillar, mind you. It’s quite possible that, like me, you have lost the memory of your early life.” The bee seemed to be taking mental notes of Gus’s physical characteristics, such as wingspan, markings, antennae length, and so on. “Fascinating,” she repeated to herself. Gus had never felt as scrutinized as he was at this moment. And he didn’t know before meeting this bumblebee that any creature could say so many words so quickly. He felt a bit dizzy.

He cleared his throat. “Ahem... well, yes! I *do* remember life as a caterpillar. But it was quite different, so different that it’s hard to believe that it was really me. It’s kind of like a dream, that time of my life. Yeah... I couldn’t see very well, I was so slow, and I ate leaves...” Gus’s voice trailed off.

The bee nodded thoughtfully. “Well, of course, Gustavius. You had very rudimentary visual abilities as a caterpillar. Nothing like

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the magnificent compound eyes you have now! No, no... You have transformed into another creature entirely. There is very little of that old version of you left. You are a new... you. Well, I'm sure it has been a lot to take in."

Gus smiled at the bee. It was nice to have someone see things through his eyes. None of his friends had understood his metamorphosis like this. He was beginning to feel the pleasant warmth of a friendly connection. And, it appeared from the friendly smile returned to Gus that the bee felt the same way.

"My name is Skylar," the bee announced. "As you can see, I am a two-spotted bumblebee, or *Bombus bimaculatus*, if you prefer. Skylar turned to show off the colorful markings on her back.

"Ah, I see," Gus replied in a tone he hoped sounded wise. "Two spots. Fascinating..." Skylar turned back with a look as if she thought Gus was mocking her, but it was clear from the innocent look that Gus wasn't the kind to mock anyone. "I think your spots are pretty cool," Gus added with a grin.

"Well, thank you for saying that, but I must say that my simple markings are quite ordinary in comparison to your decidedly unique makeup. Your wing shape and your size resembles that of the monarch butterfly, or *danaus plexippus*, if you prefer... But those green markings, well, they are quite unique. I've never seen a butterfly like you." admitted Skylar.

Gus didn't know how to respond to being complimented. "Me neither," he said with a shrug. Skylar seemed to find the response funny, because it made her laugh. The laugh had a bumbly quality to it that made Gus laugh in return. As two new friends laughed together in the meadow, Gus felt less alone than

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he had since saying goodbye to his friends, his family. He was glad that he took the chance to say hello to Skylar, and appreciated the warm feeling of companionship.

“I hope you don’t mind me asking, but you are wearing something that I must admit, baffles me. Could you tell me about it?” Skylar asked, staring at the woven silk.

“Sure! It was a gift from a friend. She thought a pouch might come in handy for carrying things during my adventures. Right now, all I have in there are two lucky flower petals.” Gus explained proudly.

“Fascinating,” Skylar commented. “Do you mind... ?” motioning toward the curious object. Gus perched on a stem of the columbine plant and invited Skylar to join him. After tugging at the straps and opening the top to peer at the flower petals, Skylar appeared to be satisfied. “Your pouch is a marvel, Gus. Quite ingenious, and very well made! I can’t wait to hear more about this friend of yours.”

Gus felt the familiar pangs of hunger. “I’ll be happy to tell you all about Aluna, but do you think I could try some of this nectar first?”

“Oh! You asked about the nectar of these flowers, didn’t you?” Skylar resumed her role of professor. “This is a columbine plant, or *aquilegia vulgaris*, if you prefer. The allure of this nectar is due to its floral overtones, with the hints of jasmine giving it...” Gus found he couldn’t listen to the lecture and appreciate the nectar at the same time. He made a mental note to ask Skylar to repeat the lesson later.

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Chapter 18 - A Guest in the Nest

The sun was dipping lower into the western sky as Skylar began to tell Gus about her life as a bee in a hive of bees. It didn't take long for him to figure out that she wasn't a common worker bee.

She related to Gus a crisis her colony had experienced recently. "Our nest is subterranean, which means we live underground," explained Skylar. "It's a little-known fact that a good majority of bees are ground-dwellers. Folks generally are not aware of this, probably because above-ground bees get all the attention. Anyway, I was inspecting the hive after a nearby tree fell during a storm, and was shocked to find several load-bearing support beams were sagging considerably! I sought counsel with the queen and convinced her that we had to relocate the colony immediately. Luckily, her majesty heeded my advice and we found an excellent new home. I went back a few days after we moved, and found that our original nest had collapsed completely!

I suppose my attention to detail caught Queen Vespyr's eye. I've been serving as her counselor ever since. I do like it; having different projects to work on. You know, freedom from the daily grind..." Skylar ended her tale with a satisfied smile.

Gus whistled through his proboscis in admiration. "Queen Vespyr. A real queen! And she listens to you." As the pair chatted, a few dark clouds rolled in over the eastern hills. The afternoon sun lit them with its rays. Dark gray hues contrasted in stark yet beautiful ways against the blue sky. "I've been searching for someone like you. The thing is, I'm on a mission," Gus confided conspiratorially. The butterfly and bumblebee were perched

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together on the swaying branch of a young sapling growing near the columbine plant.

They were more than full from their afternoon feast. Gus felt drowsy, and he sensed his muscles begin to relax for the first time since setting wing in the Land Beyond the River. To stay alert, he began to tell Skylar his story. He started describing the day he met Lacey, and continued to add details of just about every day since. Skylar listened quietly, asking a few questions and making a comment here and there. She frowned thoughtfully when Gus mentioned the ladybugs, but didn't interrupt the story. She laughed at the funny parts and cringed at the dangerous parts. And she agreed completely with Gus's assessment regarding birds, cockroaches, and bullyfrogs: AVOID THEM. Skylar appeared to be a very attentive listener, which, Gus thought, was a good quality for a friend to have.

During the story, the sky continued to darken as more storm clouds rolled in. His instincts told Gus that butterflies and raindrops are not a good combination. Skylar apparently felt the same way, as she suggested to her new friend that they could use Skylar's nest for shelter. Gus liked the idea; not just for the practicality of escaping the imminent rain, but also because seeing an underground bumblebee nest struck him as something he wanted to do. "Lead the way!" Gus exclaimed, and Skylar did exactly that. They flew back into the orchard. As they passed a fallen tree, she pointed out the nearby depression in the earth that used to be her home.

"It's a good thing that tree hadn't fallen any closer, or we could have suffered many casualties," Skylar remarked as they neared another tree trunk on the ground. This one had fallen long ago, and half of it was buried under a layer of dirt and leaves. "Bee it

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ever so bumble, there's no place like comb," Skylar quipped, though the butterfly mostly looked confused. Skylar just shook her head and led Gus to a knothole near the part of the log that was buried. "It will be a tight squeeze for you, but there's plenty of room inside."

No sooner had they passed through the knothole when Gus heard a gentle patter of rain begin to fall outside. Skylar's comment of ample room inside proved to be accurate, but had failed to mention the sheer quantity of her relations that were occupying the space. Hundreds of Skylar's kinfolk moved about, occupied with one job or another. The workers closest to the entrance noticed the newcomers first, and decided that the green visitor was more interesting than their work. They gathered into large, multi-layered bands encircling Skylar and Gus. A few larger bees, "Sentries," thought Gus, buzzed menacingly in Gus's direction, but a look from Skylar kept them at bay.

"Hallo, sisters! Allow me to introduce a most interesting fellow and personal friend, Gustavius the Butterfly." Gus interrupted Skylar's introduction with a bit of whispering in the bee's ear. "Tell them to call me Tavius, will you? I've always liked that part of my name, but everyone has always called me Gus. A change of name to go along with all the other changes, don't you agree?" Skylar nodded thoughtfully. "Tavius. That's a good strong name. Actually, Tavius is Latin in origin and, by definition, means strong and determined. Very fitting moniker in my opinion. Did you know that one of Nero's generals was named Tavius? Quite so. Not everyone knows that he plotted Nero's overthrow! Quite a fascinating story. As a matter of fact..." Tavius tapped Skylar on the shoulder and tilted his head toward the swarm of bees encircling them. "Huh? Oh, yes. A story for another day."

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She cleared her throat and started again. “Sisters, I would like to introduce Tavius, friend to the Two-spotted Bumblebee Clan of the Fallen Tree!” Skylar’s introduction was so stirring that a cheer erupted all around. Tavius smiled and wagged his antennae and fluttered his wings, apparently the response of butterflies being saluted by a multitude of cheering bumblebees.

“Thank you everyone! It’s very nice to *bee* here.” As silence descended and rolling eyes ascended, Tavius quickly learned the power of a poorly-timed pun in quieting a crowd.

Skylar closed her eyes, shook her head, then continued. “Please spread the word of our visitor, and inform queen Vespvr that I have a guest that I shall present to her shortly.” A gentle buzzing spread out from the circle to groups farther away, humming its way through the hollow trunk like a rolling echo.

“That was cool!” Tavius expressed enthusiastically.

Cooperation, efficiency, and good order are essential to a successful hive. Come, let me show you around,” offered Skylar. “But first,” she said as she turned around and headed back toward the direction they came, “you’re not going to get very far without a light source. I don’t believe butterflies share the bee’s ability to see in the dark.” she opined.

“I think you’re right. I can see nectar from far away, but I can barely see the tips of my antennae in here!” Tavius agreed. As they neared the entrance, he noticed an eerie green light coming from the walls of the trunk.

Skylar smiled. “Luminous moss! Or *schistostega pennatta*, if you prefer. Working together, several bees expertly fashioned a

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wreath made of wax and glowing moss, and ceremoniously placed it around Tavius's neck. "You look right regal," Skylar observed. "Prince Tavius graces our humble nest."

As the bees nearby began to bow, Tavius waved his arms. "Please don't! I'm not a prince... I'm just a butterfly."

Skylar shook her head. "No Tavius, maybe you're not quite a prince. But you're not just a butterfly, either. I know what you are. You're a knight! You see, long ago there were adventurers who would set out on quests to prove their valor and win the devotion of their beloved. That seems to be more appropriate for your situation, wouldn't you agree?"

Tavius considered Skylar's words, "Well, I guess I am on a quest. And I have someone who's depending on me..." he shrugged in acceptance. I don't have to do anything special to be a knight, do I?"

Skylar smiled. "Well, you do have to be knighted by royalty. But, I believe I know someone who can help with that." She led her friend down the center of the trunk. As they went deeper into the nest, Tavius saw bundles of pots made of wax. Buzzing filled the chamber as hundreds of worker bees labored to create new pots and fill them with honey. "We specialize in producing wax. These workers chew the wax and shape it to create these containers. Once a pot is filled, they place a cap on top to seal it," explained Skylar as if she were in charge of a construction project. "Would you like to try some honey for yourself?"

Skylar led Tavius to a nearby group of honeypots that were ready to be sealed and showed him a cluster that was ready to be sealed. Tavius unrolled his trusty proboscis and tested the amber

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goo. It was far too thick to flow through his delicate straw, but a drop of honey clung to the tip when he lifted it from the pot. When he rolled his proboscis back up, the drop dripped into his mouth and Tavious opened his eyes wide. The flavor and energy that was contained in that one drop of honey made him feel like he instantly had a full tank of energy. “Wowee!” he exclaimed, his antennae vibrating from the burst of energy. “That’s some powerful stuff!”

Skylar chuckled. “I suppose I should have warned you. Honey is quite concentrated compared to nectar.

“I’ll say!” answered Tavius. “I wish I had some of this when I flew across the river... I would have made it no problem!”

Skylar regarded Tavius thoughtfully. “Indeed. I’m sure it would have proven beneficial to you.” Smiling, she beckoned her friend forward, “Prepare yourself! We’re about to visit the nursery.” She led Tavius deeper into the hive to an area swarming with young bees. Adult bees were busy feeding and caring for the youngsters. “You may have noticed that all of the bees we have encountered are females.” Tavius shook his head in confusion. “Ah, You’re new to bee culture.” Skylar realized. “Do you see how large the eyes of those youngsters are?” She gestured toward a group of young bees in a group. Tavius nodded. “The male bees have larger eyes and no stinger. Their primary purpose, well, their *only* purpose, is to mate. Females take care of all the other tasks in the hive.”

Tavius blinked in surprise. “Gosh! Sounds like the males have it easy!”

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Skylar shrugged. “I guess it depends on your perspective. We keep a few males in the colony, in case a new queen is needed. But the rest of the males leave in search of queens from other colonies, and they aren’t invited back. It’s kind of a lonely life if you ask me.” she responded.

“Well, that changes things. You know, all in all, I’m glad I’m a butterfly!” Tavius decided. Skylar laughed. “I bet you are.” She consulted her internal clock. “We better be going... we don’t want to keep Queen Vespysr waiting.” She guided Tavius through the nursery and into another chamber filled with more worker bees forming and filling honey pots. As they progressed into the depths of the hive, Gus’s visage took on a tinge of doubt. “Do you think the queen will want to meet me?” he asked.

“Oh, Tavius. I know the queen, and I’m sure you two will hit it off.” Skylar said reassuringly, placing a tarsus on the edge of his wing.

Tavius shrugged. “If you say so... Gosh, I’m going to meet a queen!” He twisted his antennae nervously as he followed Skylar deeper into the nest. Tavius liked the bees’ organization. Everyone had a job, and they all worked together without argument or complaint. And he liked the smell of honey. “I sure do like your home and your whole family, Skylar,” Tavius remarked as they neared a dozen sentries guarding an archway.

The archway was built into a wall of wax that prevented anyone without permission from the sentries to proceed further into the hive. The butterfly gazed up at the barrier with awe, and gulped.

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Chapter 19 - A Knight to Remember

Skylar noticed her friend's apprehension. "Queen Vespyr likes her privacy," she explained quietly. Addressing the guards she declared, "I'm sure you already heard of our arrival. Please ask the queen if she will see us." Two of the guards disappeared through the archway. While they waited, Tavius whispered, "How should I address her, Skylar? The queen, I mean. You realize that I've never met a queen before!" Tavius was breathing rapidly and his eyes had a mild look of desperation in them.

Skylar approached Gus and indicated he should sit on a nearby rock that was just the right size for him. She reassured her buddy with a gentle pat of his tarsi with hers. "'Queen Vespyr' or 'Your Majesty will suffice, Tavius. A bow would be appropriate as well. Just follow my lead."

Tavius swallowed. "'Queen Vespyr' or 'Your Majesty.' Right... and bowing is good..." Tavius muttered to himself as he paced back and forth, awkwardly genuflecting to an imaginary luminary. Skylar had to stifle a laugh.

"You'll be fine, Tavius. She is a good and kind queen. Relax and just... be yourself." Skylar quipped with a wink.

Suddenly, the guards reappeared. "Her Majesty Queen Vespyr will see you now," they announced in harmony. Tavius followed Skylar through the entry with trepidation. As they passed through the archway, he realized that they were walking down a hallway, the walls of which were also made of wax. "These bees sure know their way around wax!" Tavius thought as they neared the end of the hallway. There was a faint glow passing through

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the wall that allowed Tavius to see a little better. As they emerged, the chamber they entered took Tavius's breath away. The room twinkled dimly with floating orbs of light. As Tavius peered closer, he saw that they were small flying insects that he had never seen.

Skylar must have seen the awe in his friend's gaze. "These are fireflies, Lampyridae, if you prefer. I quite like that name, as it conjures images of the mystical land from where these fascinating creatures must originate, don't you think?" she mused. "Come now. We mustn't keep Queen Vespyr waiting!" That final comment snapped Tavius back to reality.

"Oh, right!" He straightened up and followed his friend with a very serious look on his face. The queen was waiting for them, perched on a gnarled root that Tavius considered rather regal-looking. Skylar stopped a respectable distance away, and unwillingly moved a little closer when Tavius, preoccupied with not tripping or making any other mistakes, ran into her. "Sorry!" Tavius whispered hoarsely.

Skylar just sighed, recomposed herself, and took a bow. "Good evening, my queen. I have brought with me an ally of the clan. May I present Tavius, the Green-winged Adventurer. I met him today, and he has been gracious enough to suspend his grand quest momentarily to acquaint himself with our ways... until the weather clears, at least." The queen's eyes sparked with intrigue at the mention of a "grand quest," but didn't speak. She merely looked at Tavius with a royal, expectant gaze. A gaze that caused Tavius to quiver even more than before he entered the queen's chamber.

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He made his way to the side of his friend and tried to imitate Skylar's bow, but Gus didn't have the same kind of natural grace. The bow was awkward and included a little curtsy at the end. "Good evening, Queen Majesty." he said with as much gravity as he could muster.

Skylar couldn't help but release a quiet groan. The queen's eyes narrowed and she inclined her head slightly as she considered Tavius's salutation. She seemed to be deciding what manner of adventurer was standing before her. "Tavius..." Her voice did reflect the polish and refinement that Tavius expected a queen's voice to have. Another uncomfortable pause. "I think that was a most... unique introduction." Then, a kindly, queenly smile spread across her face. "I've decided, I quite like you."

The relief that struck Tavius upon hearing those words was instant. He at once felt more like himself. "Gee, thanks! I really admire your awesome underground castle. And the honey. And all the wax! And these lampyrades and the glowing moss. And the nursery was quite fascinating. Oh, and the honey..."

The queen seemed enchanted and amused by Tavius. She laughed and nodded. "I'm so glad your visit has been a pleasant one so far. Tell me, Tavius, all about this grand quest on which you have embarked."

Tavius proceeded to tell the queen all that he had told Skylar, but with a bit more detail and feeling. Tavius was learning how to be a better storyteller the more he practiced. He was developing the ability to entertain his audience by focusing on the relevant parts of the story. The way he showed emotion and vulnerability added credence to his tale. Tavius didn't pretend to know how he would accomplish what he had set out to do, and

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the listener couldn't help but feel admiration for his determination despite the uncertainty. It was clear that he valued and respected his friendships and was deeply motivated to help his friends in any way he could.

The queen was visibly moved as Tavius related his experiences, beginning the fateful day he met Lacey on that dusty brown boot. She sat in quiet contemplation after Tavius finished his story.

After a few moments, Skylar cleared her throat and spoke. "Your majesty, if I may speak with you in private for a moment?" she said, much to the surprise of Tavius. Skylar shot him a wink as she waited for the queen to respond.

"You may, Skylar. Come closer dear." the queen answered. "Tavius, feel free to explore the chamber for a moment while I talk to your companion."

Tavius executed another awkward bow and meandered around the chamber, looking at the fireflies and the walls of the chamber, all the while stealing glances toward the pair of bees huddled in the center of the room. After a few minutes, he heard the queen exclaim, "Capital idea, Skylar!" the queen spoke a few more words that Tavius couldn't make out, and then Skylar exited the room through the arched hallway. Tavius had no idea what was going on, or what he should do.

Queen Vespyr soon distracted the poor butterfly's thoughts away from Skylar. "Tavius, come speak with me." she directed, and he quickly moved to the same spot he had vacated earlier. "I have sent Skylar on a little mission. While we wait for her return, tell me about this adornment that you wear. What on earth is it?"

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Tavius was happy to oblige. After explaining his pouch, the two spent some time talking about Lacey and other particulars of his story the queen was interested in. Tavius was enjoying the conversation so much that he didn't hear Skylar re-enter the room until she was right behind him. He jumped in surprise as he turned to see Skylar and a contingent of guards entering behind her, forming a semi-circle around the butterfly.

"Tavius! Skylar has told me something that I found hard to believe." Queen Vespyr said rather sternly. Tavius turned back to her with a look of shock and a little bit of terror. "Indeed," the queen continued. "She told me... that you have embarked on a dangerous quest, yet have not been knighted! Can this be true?"

Tavius swallowed hard and searched for the right words. "Well, um... you see, I didn't even know about this whole knight thing until Skylar told me. I'm sorry, I don't... I didn't mean to..."

The queen mercifully interrupted Tavius. "Well, I think this little oversight needs to be corrected right away. Tell me, Mr. Tavius, do you desire to be knighted, so that you can continue your quest properly?"

Tavius swallowed again. He looked at Skylar, who was now standing beside him. She nodded encouragingly and gave him a gentle shove. Looking back to the queen with his look of determination, he responded, "Yes, your majesty. I would like that very much."

Queen Vesper clapped her tarsi. "The royal scepter!" she declared. Two of the guards approached the throne, bearing a long and ornate wax scepter that looked almost too large for the

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queen to wield. She dismounted the throne, took the scepter from the guards, and approached Tavius. Balancing the long scepter expertly in her tarsi, she addressed the butterfly before her in a clear, melodic tone, “Brave Tavius, friend of the bees. You have embarked on a most valiant and noble quest, searching for something that may or may not exist. All of this, you do out of kindness and empathy. You have traveled far, and undoubtedly have a long and dangerous path to trod before your quest is over. I find your heart to be pure, and find you worthy of the title of knight. Kneel before me, adventurer.”

Tavius obediently bent his multiple knees until they were touching the ground. He bent forward with eyes closed.

“In the name of the Hero, may you be brave.” the queen pronounced in a sonorous voice as she touched the scepter to his right shoulder. “In the name of the Protector, may you wield your courage to protect the innocent,” she continued as she lifted the scepter over Tavius’s head, rotating it, and touching it to his left shoulder. “And in the name of the Scholar, may you grow in wisdom and perception.” Queen Vespyr intoned as she once again moved the scepter to his right shoulder. “Rise, and stand strong. Hence, you will be known as Sir Tavius, Knight of the Forest Lands, Friend to the Worthy!”

Tavius stood, a broad smile covering his face as the chamber filled with the buzzing of wings and cheers. He continued to smile as he received the congratulations of each guard in turn, then finally Skylar and Queen Vespyr. “Gosh... I feel different!” he exclaimed as the guards departed, reverently taking the scepter with them. The three were left alone in the now-quiet chamber. “Thank you Skylar, and Queen Vespyr of course! This was very unexpected.” Tavius said gratefully.

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Skylar looked as happy as her friend. “You *should* feel different, Tavius... I mean *Sir* Tavius. You’re a proper knight now!”

“Indeed.” Queen Vespyr added. “And very overdue, I must say.” She resumed her perch on the throne. “You have recounted to us a most touching and engaging story, Sir Tavius. I am honored to have played a part in your quest.” The queen smiled mysteriously. “And, if I could be so bold, I may be able to present you with a key that unlocks the next chapter of your quest, good knight. For I know where you can find the ladybugs you seek.”

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Chapter 20 - The Queen's Counselors

At first, Tavius wasn't sure that he could believe what the queen had said. "Your Majesty... are you saying that the ladybugs exist, *and* that you know where to find them?" He held his breath, waiting for her reply.

"Most certainly, and indeed I do! The queen of the ladybugs is a member of the Queens' Council. I know Janelle quite well." Tavius glanced at Skylar with a dumbfounded look.

Skylar nodded. "I suspected as much. I don't know the full composition of the Queen's Council, as I've never been invited to attend. But what wonderful news! It seems that you may now be within grasp of the prize, good knight!"

Tavius felt his knees go weak. The uncertainty and doubt that had haunted him since he heard the story of the ladybugs melted away in an instant. Hope blossomed inside him, along with a belief that Lacey really would be able to fly again! The butterfly forgot all knightly decorum as he whooped and jumped for joy, hovering in the air above the queen and Skylar. The turbulence from his wings pushed a few of the fireflies off course. His desire to know more burst out of him as he came back to the ground. "Will you help me, Queen Vespyr? Perhaps you could introduce me to Queen Janelle?" Tavius trembled with excitement.

The queen inclined her head. "I think that it is quite possible, as a matter of fact. The council will be meeting in two days from now. Would you and Skylar like to accompany me as my counselors? We are authorized two counselors according to the law of the council. I have never seen a use for them, until now.

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Truth be told, there's only one queen whose opinion holds sway on the council, so why bother?"

Skylar explained in a low voice, "Queen Daphne, Ruler of the Dragonflies! She has wielded power over these meadows for a long time. Rumor has it that she controls the council by sheer will and intimidation. No other queen has shown the ability to challenge her authority."

Tavius looked at Skylar with an expression that invited her thoughts. Skylar responded with an animated nod. They turned together to answer the queen. "I have served you my entire life, Queen Vespyr," answered Skylar. "You considered my warning when our old nest was weakened, and acted quickly to save our colony. You have welcomed and knighted Tavius, whose destiny it seems involves the Queen's Council. It would be an honor and privilege to serve as your counselor." Her words were punctuated by another graceful bow.

"I... I would like to join my friend Skylar... Wait, can a butterfly be a counselor to a bee queen?" Tavius interrupted himself with this new thought. He was a little intimidated by the thought of the council, but he also realized it may be his best chance to be introduced to the ladybugs and enlist their help. Still, Tavius knew he was a stranger to this place and its customs, and had no desire to get his new friends in trouble.

"The law makes no mention of limitations in that regard, so I don't see why not. Besides, the look on Melinda's face when she sees you will be well worth it!" answered Queen Vespyr.

Tavius turned to Skylar again for clarification. "Melinda is the Queen of the Above-the-Ground Bees, or 'Alpha bees,' as they

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call themselves. They call us Below-the-Ground Bees or ‘Beta bees,’ Skylar informed Tavius. “She considers us to be inferior to the Alphas, even though, as I said earlier, we outnumber them. By quite a large percentage, too.” Skylar sighed. “As you might imagine, Queen Vespyr and Queen Melinda do not always see eye to eye.” Tavius couldn’t understand why two species so similar to each other would not get along. Then again, there was a lot in the Land Beyond the Cabin that he didn’t understand.

After some throat-clearing, Tavius found his voice. “I will gladly join Skylar in accompanying Your Majesty to the council. I can’t wait to meet the ladybug queen. With any luck, she’ll offer her support to fix Lacey’s wing!”

Queen Vespyr smiled at the thought of her friend. “I consider Queen Janelle to be the most caring and joyful member of the council. I’m sure she will help you, if she can. Now, if you will please excuse me, there is much to do in preparation. Good Sir Tavius, my realm is yours to enjoy. I shall meet you near the entrance at daybreak, day after tomorrow.” Skylar and Tavius bowed one final time and turned to depart the throne room.

Tavius almost succeeded to perform this without incident, but did manage to run into a firefly who was not illuminated at the moment. “Pardon me!” he said a little too loudly as he followed Skylar into the arched walkway, and Queen Vespyr finally had the quiet she needed to plan for the council.

Skylar and Tavius found a quiet-ish place to rest for the night. Butterflies don’t sleep much as a general rule, and Tavius had too much on his mind to sleep anyway. Skylar spent the night by his side and the two talked through the dark hours, discussing strategies and options, planning for contingencies, sharing

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hopes, dreams and fears. Skylar was clearly excited to participate in a council meeting, but Tavius was thinking only of what would happen in the days that followed. He finally nodded off, dreaming of Lacey and mended wings.

Sunlight streaming in through a small knothole informed Tavius that morning had broken. He was surprised to see that he was alone- Skylar was nowhere to be found. A nearby worker bee noticed that Tavius was awake. “Sir Tavius! Skylar asked me to inform you that she had an errand and will return shortly.” Tavius thanked the bee and wondered what he should do while he waited. His stomach helped him decide, and shortly he was outside the nest.

He took the opportunity to survey the meadow that housed Skylar’s colony. He hadn’t had the chance to explore the grounds when they’d arrived due to the rainstorm. This morning’s sky held nothing of the tempestuous energy of the night before. Before him, Tavius beheld a field full of pink and white flowers, Members of Skylar’s clan helped themselves to the nectar the flowers offered. Tavius joined them and decided that, while this nectar wasn’t his favorite, it was pleasant enough and quite filling.

“That is known as clover, of genus trifolium.” a familiar voice announced from behind. Caught off guard, Tavius sprayed Skylar evenly with a proboscis full of clover nectar as he spun to face her. “Skylar! You surprised me!” Tavius exclaimed.

“I... figured that part out.” Skylar returned as she wiped nectar from her antennae. “As I was saying, clover has less of the floral notes that are characteristic of the lavender we sampled yesterday, but note the robust hues of citrus with that earthy

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undertone that ties the whole flavor palette together quite nicely. In my opinion, one of the most understated of all nectar-bearing flora. Clover does not receive the credit it deserves.” Skylar concluded.

“Hey, where did you go? Sorry about the nectar. I didn’t expect anyone to sneak up on me like that,” Tavius responded with an embarrassed look. “Clover nectar is fine, but it’s not my favorite. Maybe it has too much earthy undertone for me?”

Skylar approached the clover and took a sip before answering. With a look of approval, she commented, “too much of an earthy undertone, huh? It seems you are developing a more complex flavor palate. I may have created a monster!” In a more serious tone, she added “I should not have been able to sneak up on you quite that easily, though. Remember that nothing leads to a long life as much as constant vigilance.”

Tavius nodded soberly. “You’re right, Skylar. I need to heed my surroundings more closely.” Skylar smiled, happy to see that Tavius wasn’t offended by her criticism. In answer to his first question she disclosed, “I have some Alpha friends who know something about the council. One has been a counselor to Queen Melinda for several years. I thought they might have some useful advice for us.”

Tavius looked surprised. “I thought your colony didn’t get along with the Alphas.”

“Well, just because our queens don’t like each other, that doesn’t mean the colonies are at war. I’ve met some really friendly Alpha bees while roaming the meadows.” Skylar explained.

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“That’s good to hear,” responded the butterfly. “I’ve found that friends can be found just about anywhere! So, did you find out anything useful?”

Skylar shrugged. “I hope so. Amanda, the one on Melinda’s council, informed me about some procedural rules and what to expect regarding vote adjudication and the like. I don’t know how strictly the council adheres to their bylaws and due process in the first place, so this will be a learning experience for both of us!”

As Tavius often did when Skylar started using words he didn’t understand, the butterfly merely shrugged and smiled. “If you say so, Skylar. You already know more than I ever will!” he said with genuine admiration, before something behind Skylar caught his attention. “Say, those clouds look like they’re heading our way,” he said, indicating more dark rain clouds, clustered on the horizon. “And they look angry.”

The clouds did indeed crowd into the sky above the two friends during the next hour, at which point they decided to spend the rest of the afternoon inside the nest. Skylar told Tavius that she had some errands to take care of, and left Tavius to experiment mixing honey with water in order to use his proboscis as intended. Tavius discovered that his appendage made for a good stirring stick. And, he discovered that he felt a little dizzy if he drank too much honey, even when it was diluted.

Skylar giggled when she returned and Tavius informed her of the results of his experimentation. “You better take it easy with the honey, bub. Seems like pretty strong stuff for butterflies!” she counseled her wobbly friend. Tavius nodded in agreement.

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The rain let up in the evening, so the two friends left the hive and spent some quiet hours of contemplation and anticipation as they spent the twilight hour together, exploring the meadow. Eventually, the sun dropped out of sight. A cool stillness permeated the air due to the refreshing rain that had fallen earlier. Drops of water thudded softly as they dripped from trees and saturated the rich soil below. Tavius felt a connection to all of it. The plants, insects, animals, the air and rain, the sun and moon... He was part of everything around him. The thought caused a tingle to run up and down Tavius's exoskeleton.

"Look!" Skylar urged. Tavius looked at his friend, who was looking up to the sky. He followed the bee's gaze and his mouth dropped open at the sight. So many stars! The crisp dark canvas of the sky was pinpricked with more stars than Tavius had ever seen! True, he had not spent much time in the Land Beyond the Cabin, but he knew the view before him was something special. His soul was overwhelmed with awe and wonder.

"It makes you feel a little small, doesn't it?" mused Tavius as starlight sparkled in his multi-faceted eyes.

"I'm already small, relatively speaking, to begin with. So I would have to say quite so, my friend. Quite so," confessed Skylar.

Tavius let his thoughts wander.

"We're all connected, Skylar. The animals. the plants, the trees, the earth, the sky... My friends across the river are probably looking at these same stars right now. In a lot of ways, we're connected, despite the distance separating us. It's pretty incredible just to consider that."

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Skylar pondered the butterfly's words as they gazed. Then she blinked and looked at Tavius. "I mean no offense... believe me, I know what it feels like to be different from others. I see the looks of those around me, hear the whispers as I pass. A lot of my clan look at me and just see a nerd. But some of the things you say, Tavius, are just way out there, even for me." She let silence saturate her words as Tavius blinked. "Are you aware that all of this..." she waved her antennae around, "has been categorized and cataloged by generations of scholars, including myself, so that we are able explain, in great detail, just how different, unique, and individual, all of this..." another wave of her antennae, "is!" Skylar continued to mutter some words that Tavius couldn't make out.

Tavius's gaze turned heavenward as he responded. "Gee. I guess there's more than one way to think about stuff."

Skylar sighed, looked at her friend, then up at the stars, "I suppose there is." she responded quietly.

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Chapter 21 - Royal Introductions

Tavius and Skylar were awake and waiting for the queen and her guards outside the entrance to the colony before dawn. Well after the sun had crested the horizon and begun the gentle task of drying the rain-soaked land, Queen Vespyr and her guards emerged from the nest. “Sorry to keep you waiting... a few last-minute matters to resolve,” the queen offered in way of apology. “The formal council meeting doesn’t start until midday, so there will still be ample time for introductions. Shall we go?” Queen Vespyr’s no-nonsense attitude made it clear that her question wasn’t really a question.

The curious group of bees-plus-butterfly climbed into the air and set their course further inland, away from the river. As they passed by clusters of flowers that *Tavius* really wanted to sample, he kept himself focused by remembering the importance of the day, and keeping close to his friends. The last thing he wanted today was to get left behind!

As the queen and her escort flew beneath the boughs of tall trees defining the perimeter of the meadow, *Tavius* saw a great willow tree standing alone in the distance. Green grass and inviting flowers gave way to boulders, rocks, and weeds. The bleak landscape added extra gravity to the tension *Tavius* already felt building inside. He glanced over at Skylar with a worried look. Skylar returned a reassuring smile. “That’s Council Tree up ahead... Don’t worry so much, *Tavius*! You seem to have a knack for making friends. You’ll do fine! But... don’t look to me for much help when we arrive. I’ll be watching the other queens and their entourages for anything that might help Queen Vespyr. I hope I might be of some service to her today.”

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Skylar's words didn't help Tavius relax, but he did understand that her job today was different than his. He decided that the best way to spend the time left before arrival was to go over what he knew and what he hoped to accomplish during the council. He figured that the wisest course of action was to let his friends do the talking and for him to do his best to look like he belonged. He also spent a little bit of time worrying, because he knew that sometimes words came out of his mouth before he had a chance to stop them. And he didn't want that to happen today.

Tavius noticed that they were descending as they neared the drooping branches of the willow. He felt excitement and nervousness churn inside him, resulting in a strange cocktail of conflicting emotions. He decided that he was mostly excited and only slightly less nervous as they passed under the willow branches. Once inside the protective canopy of the tree, Tavius saw groups of insects on the flat, stony ground near the substantial trunk of Council Tree. Tavius noticed that the trunk of the tree had sprouted from a great crevice in the ground's stony surface. He thought it curious that the tree decided to sprout here instead of some soft dirt somewhere. Which then led him to wonder if trees had much say as to where they sprouted.

The groups of insects were easily distinguishable now, as the latecomers were almost upon them. A few friendly waves and upturned noses were extended from various factions on the ground, not to mention the looks of curiosity in seeing a butterfly accompanying the Beta Bee delegation. Looking down at the council members, the scene made Tavius think of a flower. The dragonfly queen and her entourage, clearly the largest of all the groups, stood at the center of a large circle, while the other groups surrounded them like petals of a flower.

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Queen Vespyr and company touched down in the area between the butterflies and the moths. Completing the circle, the above-ground bees stood next to the moths, who stood next to the ladybug contingent (consisting of only two representatives), who stood next to the butterflies.

“The Council will convene in thirty minutes!” proclaimed a voice that came from somewhere inside the dragonfly delegation. The other groups of insects returned to their interrupted council preparations as Vespyr beckoned to her counsellors. “Care to make the rounds with me?” she asked her counselors airily. “I’m sure they are all curious, look at them pretending not to be watching us...” It seemed all those eyes didn’t affect her in the same way they did Tavius.

Skylar spoke up. “Please allow me to make my own rounds, your majesty. There may be information to be gleaned through more... discrete conversations?”

Queen Vespyr nodded her agreement. “Excellent idea, Skylar. Something tells me that bringing you was a wise move on my part.” She may have missed Skylar’s polished bow as she turned her attention back to Tavius. “Right! Might as well get it over with... Let’s start with Queen Daphne, the dragonfly queen. She wields the most influence on the council. Daphne is quite adept at managing political alliances and several of my peers seem to be intimidated by her as well.” Queen Vespyr turned and looked at Tavius. He was trying, but failing, to appear calm and collected. “Perhaps you might let me do most of the talking,” she suggested. Tavius didn’t argue. He nodded vigorously.

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He followed the bumble bee queen as she approached a most impressive and regal ruby red dragonfly, surrounded by a host of guards and assistants. “My, my, Daphne... it seems your court increases in size with every council meeting. Forgive my ignorance, but I thought we are limited to two counselors only.” Queen Vespyr smiled at the dragonfly queen, but her eyes conveyed a different emotion altogether.

Queen Daphne seemed to turn a deeper hue of crimson at the challenge to her court. “Ah, Vespyr! I was wondering if you were going to make it.” She sorted through the small army of minions huddled behind her. “These... Come forward, Ally and Emmy! Quickly now.” An alert-looking dragonfly with a beautiful blue hue and a more petite, blue-gray dragonfly stepped forward. “This is Ally and Emmy, my counselors. Those in the back are *their* assistants! They just can’t talk directly to me during the session. Quite within the limits of the law, I assure you.”

Tavius noted a slight look of annoyance from the blue dragonfly named Ally, as if she would rather be elsewhere. Emmy, on the other hand, was rather shy and spent most of the time looking at the ground. Tavius caught her stealing curious glances of him when she thought no one was looking. Queen Daphne looked down imperiously at the smaller bee queen in an attempt to intimidate her.

“I see,” Queen Vespyr replied, obviously unconvinced and unimpressed. “This issue is better left to discuss during the council. Oh, I’m so sorry... I’ve forgotten my manners! May I introduce you to one of my counselors? This is Sir Tavius. He has been our guest for a time.” Tavius was ready with a friendly smile, but it wilted under Queen Daphne’s skeptical gaze. “Your Majesty,” he managed tentatively.

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“A butterfly serving as counselor to the queen of the b-bees? How... unorthodox.” Queen Daphne continued to discomfort Tavius with her unflinching glare.

“Something else not addressed by the law, it seems,” countered Queen Vespyr evenly. She waved at someone a short distance away. “Could you please excuse us? I’d like to introduce Tavius to the other queens before the meeting starts.”

“It was a pleasure to meet you, your majesty. Miss Ally, Miss Emmy,” Tavius managed with a nod at each as he took his leave, intent on staying right behind Queen Vespyr. He thought he heard a “hmph” and some quiet whispers from the direction of the dragonfly queen and company as he walked away. Tavius certainly wasn’t used to so much attention, having spent most of his life in near-solitude. But he knew that Lacey was counting on him, and that gave him courage to keep moving forward with hope and determination.

Compared to his first introduction, Tavius felt much more comfortable as he was introduced to Queen Ivette and Queen Gwen. Queen Ivette was a breathtaking orange and black monarch butterfly, who made Tavius immediately feel welcome and accepted. Queen Gwen was an equally stunning giant leopard moth with beautiful white wings decorated with black spots. While more austere than the butterfly queen, Queen Gwen was cordial and polite toward Tavius.

Tavius hadn’t interacted with other butterflies or moths before, and it made him feel more comfortable to see insects similar to himself at the Queens’ Council. The butterfly counselors, Jake and Jess, like their queen, were friendly and welcoming. Their

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lone moth counterpart, Fernando, was unfortunately not as outgoing. Despite a few attempts, Tavius found it impossible to get more than one-word responses from the somber moth, though he did take interest in the butterfly's silk pouch.

The awkward silence with Fernando didn't last long, as Queen Vespyr soon appeared at Tavius's side. "Two more queens to meet; we should have just enough time. Ready?" she slipped her arm into his and guided him around the council circle, straight toward the ruler of the Alpha Bees.

"Melinda! How have you been?" Queen Vespyr said cordially as they approached a bee that was taller and slimmer than Vespyr, but whose face lacked the warmth and friendliness of the shorter bee queen.

"Vespyr," the one-word salutation appeared to be all Queen Melinda could muster, as most of her attention was taken by the large green butterfly who was smiling at her for some reason.

Tavius found his eyes wandering, trying his best to avoid staring at anything or anyone, especially Queen Melinda. Out of the corner of his eye, he was Skylar speaking to an Alpha bee in the background. "Hmm... that must be Amanda," mused Tavius to himself.

"Allow me to introduce you two," Queen Vespyr offered, breaking the uncomfortable silence that was beginning to build. "Queen Melinda, this is Sir Tavius. He has traveled far, and has taken a brief respite from his quest to learn a little of our customs. This time, Tavius tried the strong, silent approach. Thanks to Skylar's patient tutelage back in the nest, he was able

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to execute a passable bow. Doing his best to hold her gaze, he waited for Queen Melinda to speak.

“Tovias, you say.” Queen Melinda started. She looked as if she were going to continue when a polite, “Ahem,” escaped the butterfly standing in front of her.

“Actually, it’s ‘Tav^uius’, you know, like ‘happ^y’,” he explained. “Happy Tav^uius,” he repeated to himself. “That’s got a nice ring to it!”

Queen Melinda’s face looked strained, as if she were not accustomed to being interrupted. Or corrected. As her mouth opened to put the upstart butterfly in his place, Queen Vesp^y’s smooth voice broke in. “The happiest of Tav^uiuses, I warrant! I’m sure we all appreciate your help with pronunciation, as your name is not common to us. Wouldn’t you agree, Melinda?”

Queen Vesp^y’s interjection gave Melinda time to assess the situation. Deciding to maintain a regal aspect, she replied with a curt nod, “Quite,” though a condescending curl of her lip betrayed her true feelings. “It was... interesting meeting you, Tav^uius.” she said, holding the first part of his name a beat too long. “Such a shame that time is short. If you’ll excuse me, I would like to discuss some important matters of meadow with my counselors before the council starts.” As she turned to call her counselors, Tav^uius noted with interest that Skylar was nowhere to be found.

Tav^uius’s heart skipped a beat when he realized that there was only one more queen to meet. Queen Vesp^y smiled as their eyes met. She inclined her head toward the pair of ladybugs, who

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were at that moment conversing with each other. Intertwining one of her arms in his, they headed in that direction.

“How am I doing?” Tavius asked his companion. “Queen Daphne and Queen Melinda don’t seem to like me very much.” he noted with sadness.

“You are doing fantastic, Sir Tavius,” Queen Vespyr told him. “You know, there are some individuals we encounter during life’s journey that have a different way of thinking. No matter what you do to foster friendship, they will not respond in kind. Queen Daphne and Queen Melinda are motivated by power and control. They are suspicious and resistant to anyone that could threaten the balance of power in the council.”

“But I don’t understand how they can feel threatened by me,” responded Tavius. I’m just a common butterfly.”

Queen Vespyr stopped and looked at the knight, considering her words. “You may think of yourself that way, but try to see yourself through their eyes. You’re unknown to our community. And you, a butterfly, came to the council with Skylar and I. They are suspicious and skeptical.” She smiled at the look that crossed the young butterfly’s face. “Not all of us feel that way, Sir Tavius.

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Tavius promptly forgot where he was in the story as he tried to find the words he wanted to say to the ladybug queen. She was

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quite a bit older and more frail than the other queens, but she carried herself with grace and dignity. Tavius felt right away that he liked Queen Janelle very much.

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A Temporary Ending

Thank you for reading the first 21 chapters of The

Caterpillar and the Dragonfly. Since completing what has been written thus far, I got busy with a plan to cross the country on my bicycle, and I've been doing that for the majority of 2026.

If you have any suggestions for making the book better, or if you want to encourage me to finish the thing, I invite you to write to me at jt.songseeker@gmail.com. If there is enough interest, I feel I will get motivated to finish the last few chapters.

PS- I have a really good (in my opinion) ending in mind. I just need to get there!